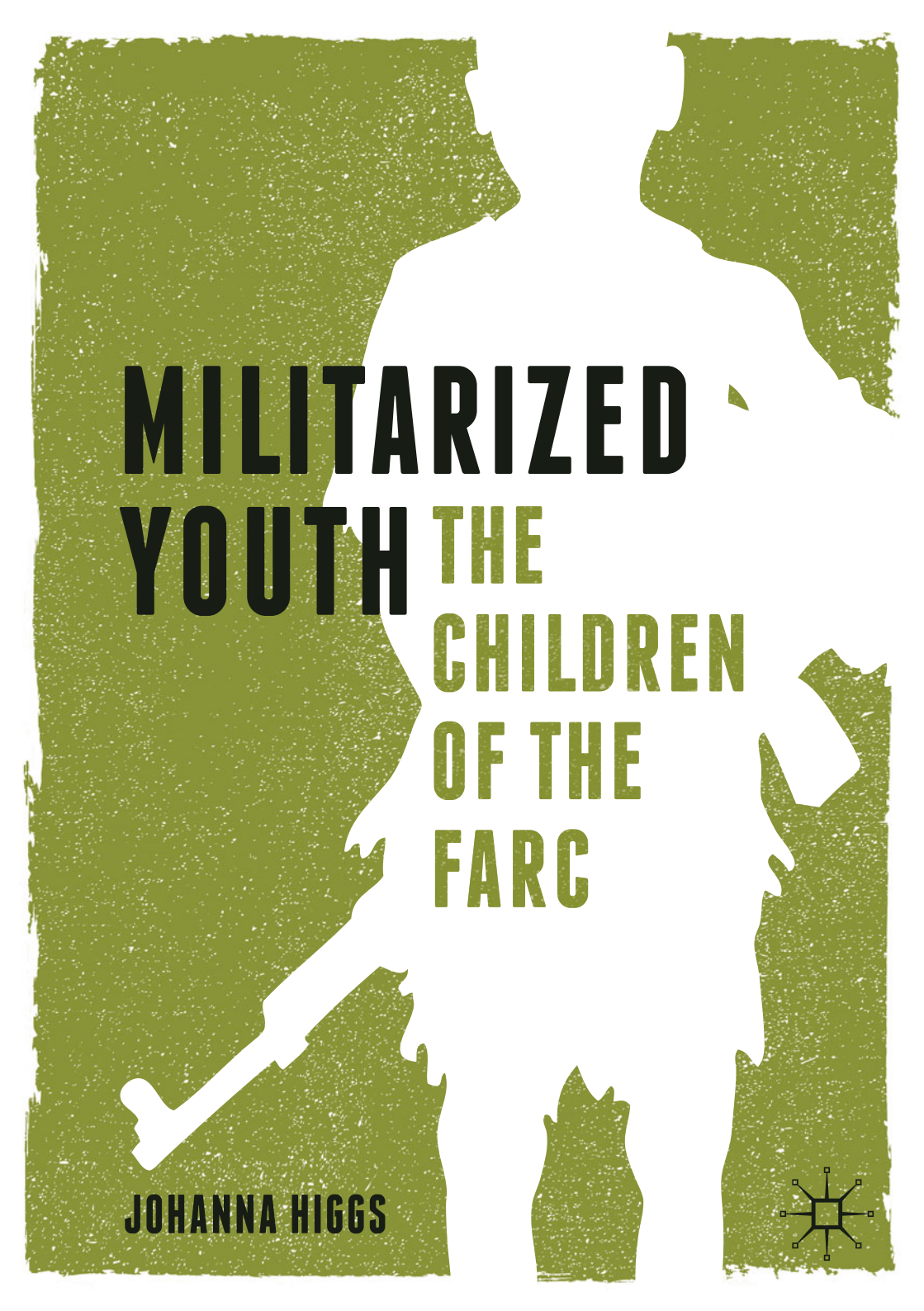




MILITARIZED YOUTH **THE CHILDREN OF THE FARC**

JOHANNA HIGGS



Militarized Youth

‘Using children as soldiers continues to be a global trauma. In this book, Johanna Higgs takes the reader far beyond popular hackneyed ideas of the child soldier as simply forcefully recruited and in a powerful way shows how in zones of conflict children’s lives become militarised and how their lifeworlds instrumentalize them for violent purposes. It is a strong and important contribution to the field of conflict studies.’

—Mats Utas, *Department Chair and Professor of Cultural Anthropology and Ethnology, Uppsala University, Sweden*

‘Based on extensive fieldwork in Colombia, Johanna Higgs provides a detailed account of the lives and experiences of young and under-age combatants caught up in Colombia’s civil war. Collecting their stories at the moment of transition from guerrilla to civilian life allows Higgs to understand the lifeworlds of the child soldiers and gain new insights in the infamous FARC guerrilla movement, before narratives start to align themselves with post-war norms and political expectations.’

—Krijin Peters, *Associate Professor of Political and Cultural Studies, Swansea University, UK*

‘In this timely book, Johanna Higgs sheds new light on the importance of identity dynamics in child soldiers, who enter spaces where violence is normalized. Using the analytic framework of lifeworlds, she shows how children who were recruited into the FARC in Colombia underwent profound internal and social transformations that militarized them. She shows how greater attention must be given to the identity challenges that former child soldiers face if they are to reintegrate successfully into civilian life.’

—Mike Wessells, *Professor of Clinical Population and Family Health, Columbia University, USA*

Johanna Higgs

Militarized Youth

The Children of the FARC

palgrave
macmillan

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PREFACE

This book explores the experiences of children involved with the Colombian guerrilla group the Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (FARC). Based on ethnographic fieldwork, the book examines the process of militarisation of children who join the FARC as well as how they return to civilian lives. My fieldwork entailed six months based in a demobilisation centre for children who had been members of FARC in Medellin and a further six months in various locations throughout Colombia where I spoke to community members about children's experiences of militarisation and the broader social contexts in which this occurred. My analysis goes beyond the predominant humanitarian perspectives on 'child soldiers' and delves deeper into the specific social and cultural aspects of the Colombian conflict to give a contextualised, culturally relevant understanding of the process of militarisation. Using the theoretical approach of lifeworlds, I argue that militarisation occurs as children undergo phenomenological transformations of their identities along with shifts in their social environments. The process of how children 'become' soldiers in the FARC is explored by looking at the specific social and cultural elements of children's home lifeworlds which are conducive to child militarisation. I then examine the processes used by the FARC to militarise children once they join the armed group and the children's experiences within that group. Finally, I consider what happens when children come out of armed groups and enter the demobilisation process in order to 'undo' the militarisation and become civilians again. I argue that it is through understanding how meaning and sociality have

been constructed within children's lifeworlds and by paying attention to the subjective, phenomenological and cultural perspectives of those lifeworlds, we can begin to understand how children take on militarised identities and 'become' members of armed groups.

Bundoora, Australia

Johanna Higgs

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A special thank you to everyone in Colombia who took the time to share their thoughts and experiences with me. I am deeply grateful to you for trusting me with your stories. Thank you to all the former child combatants for your trust in me and for allowing me to spend time with you. You will always be in my thoughts. Also, to the many Colombians who trusted me to tell me their side of the conflict, something that I know was not easy. Thank you.

Thank you also to my parents for providing me with an education and encouraging me to be educated. Something that I now know is not always encouraged, or possible, particularly when it comes to girls. I now appreciate that.

On that note, I would like to send out a special encouragement to all women and girls everywhere, to always strive to be educated take your education as high as you can.

At the end of my fieldwork, I was on a bus in Medellin, ready to finish my fieldwork and to leave Colombia. The secretary from CAE met me in the city just before and handed me a book about the Colombian conflict. In the front, she wrote a small note thanking me for being interested in

Colombia and their conflict. She then asked me to take their stories of suffering, particularly those of Colombia's women and girls and to tell them to others.

Thank you to everybody who has allowed me to do that.

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CHAPTER 1

Introduction: The Children of the Las Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (FARC)

The conflict in Colombia has spanned more than six decades as the government's forces and paramilitary groups have been fighting the Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia (FARC) and the People's Liberation Army (ELN). The current conflict began in 1964 when the left-wing guerrilla movements, known in Spanish as the Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (FARC) and the Ejercito de Liberacion Nacional (ELN), emerged to oppose the conservative government. What has ensued since then has been a long and bitter conflict. Much of the country's rugged geography including the tall Andean mountains, Amazonian jungle and two coastlines have been controlled by the various armed groups who have struggled to gain control over land and the country's lucrative resources including gold, bananas, coal, oil, emeralds and palm oil. Much of the violence has taken place in rural areas where the presence of the armed groups has been the most dominant (Arroyave and Erazo-Coronado 2016). Dirty warfare has been used and civilians, particularly the rural poor, have been subject to much violence as armed groups have tried to get rid of those who dissent against them. Threats, torture, assassinations and massacres of whole communities have led to the displacement of more than 6.8 million Colombians, generating the world's second largest population of internally displaced persons (IDPs) after Syria (Human Rights Watch 2017).

Much of the violence in Colombia can be attributed to the failure of the state to ensure justice and equality in a context of poor economic reform, drug trafficking and conflict over land and natural resources. As a result,

violence has run like a thread not only through the country's official history but also through the personal histories of most Colombians. As Steven Dudley (2004) observed, there is not a Colombian who does not have a story of mutilation, massacre or flight to tell. One of the most noteworthy aspects of the Colombian conflict has been its use of children. They have been a persistent feature in Colombia's various armed groups and have operated as soldiers, spies and drug traffickers with almost as many girls fighting in the armed groups as there have been boys. While Colombia has begun to move forwards with a peace process, many of the younger generations have been involved in conflict as 'child soldiers'. This book is focused on the FARC, its recruitment of children, and how they have been made to become part of Colombia's guerrilla groups.

During my fieldwork, discussed in more detail in Chapter 2, I spent six months beginning in 2015 working in a demobilisation centre for former child soldiers. I then spent the next six months in 2016 travelling through various parts of Colombia speaking with various people who had been directly involved with the conflict, as well as with many civilians. The children I met in Colombia had a remarkable awareness about the Colombian conflict and its dynamics. As I came to learn, this was largely because the war has been fought all around them; it has been fought near their homes and next to their schools. They have had family members who have been either involved with one of the armed groups or affected by the violence from the armed groups. They have served as soldiers for the various armed groups in the country, worked as drug mules for the narco-traffickers and have operated as spies and urban militia for the various armed groups. UNICEF (2016) reports that out of 7.6 million people in Colombia who are registered as victims of the conflict, 2.5 million or 1 in 3 are children. Nearly 45,000 children have been killed and 2.3 million have been displaced. Since 1999, nearly 6000 children have run away from non-state armed groups or were released by the military and received state protection (UNICEF 2016). Of these, one in six were from Afro-Colombian or indigenous communities and 30% were girls (UNICEF 2016). The average age of recruitment into armed groups is 13 (UNICEF 2016). In some parts of Colombia, children have played such a frequent role in the conflict, that police assumed that all children were involved with one of the armed groups. Eduard, a lawyer from Apartado, Uraba, a region that had been heavily affected by the conflict, explained that when he was growing up not more than three or four children were allowed to be on the street. 'If you said you were from Uraba then the police would kill you straight

away because they would think that you are working for the guerrillas', he remembered.

One of the most interesting aspects of child recruitment in Colombia is that a large majority of the children who have joined armed groups in Colombia have done so by choice. In many cases, this has occurred after children have come into contact with active members of one of the armed groups or because they have been encouraged to join by a family member or friends who are already in one of the armed groups. However, in a context such as Colombia, the extent to which children have had full agency in the decisions that they have made should be questioned. The overwhelming poverty and inequality throughout the country have meant that many children have made the choice to join an armed group as a means of gaining better access to resources and protection. There are regions of Colombia where children openly and insistently request to join the guerrillas as a way of escaping poverty. There have also been reported cases where even the mothers themselves, desperate for their children to have a better economic situation, ask for their children to be recruited. Thus, most of the children who are recruited into the armed groups come from the most disadvantaged and vulnerable parts of society. With few other options, joining an armed group may seem the only means of survival. Children have also joined armed groups for revenge and there have been cases of forced recruitment. It is therefore important to realise that voluntary recruitment must always be understood in relation to the options that a child may have in such a context (Steinl 2017).

This book is not so much concerned with *why* children join armed groups. There is already significant research exploring the many reasons that children become involved with armed groups globally, which will be explored in greater depth in Chapter 2. Instead, book is more concerned with *how* children become involved with armed groups and how they take on the identity of those groups. More research is needed to look at what happens to children once they enter into armed groups and how they come to take on the particular identities of the armed groups. This book is concerned with the ways in which children are militarised. Militarisation is understood as a process of becoming and being a soldier, a process that is shaped by the structural forces and dynamics of the broader socio-historical context in which it is taking place (Denov 2010). This typically involves a transition process. Cynthia Enloe (2002), who has written extensively on militarisation, argues that militarisation is a transformative process whereby a person or society gradually comes to be controlled by military institutions

and ideas. Everyday life structures become integrated with military practices and violence becomes increasingly normalised. Enloe argues that militarism is an ideology, a compilation of assumptions, in which specific values are taught about what is good, right and wrong in relation to military values. These usually come through the concerted decisions made by groups of individuals who are pursuing specific interests and goals in relation to their military objectives. These beliefs and values are usually constructed in relation to specific cultural and social values (Enloe 2014).

The way in which the military values are transferred is also highly dependent on the cultural environment and may occur, as Lutz (2004) argues, through the use of popular culture to influence the idea that the military is central to the state. National histories may be shaped in ways that glorify and legitimate military action and symbols. Militarism is therefore often a complex mix of politics, friendship, money, career advancement and idealisms where individuals take on military practices and beliefs that are specific to the social and cultural environment in which they are taking place. Angstrom (2016) argues that crossing the boundary between being a civilian and a soldier means transitioning from one state to another, where a new set of rules, expectations and roles apply. Once the person has crossed the boundary from being a civilian into being a soldier, they are then expected to understand that they must behave differently and even see themselves in a different way. In Western militaries, this process has been well theorised by Goffman (1987) who argues that training barracks can be likened to factories that are set to remould civilian humans into soldiers. Militarisation is therefore the process of moving between different spheres of social reality where the values, norms and ideas differ. Understanding these processes is significant for understanding reintegration processes. Bringing children out of war and successfully bringing them back into the civilian world involve understanding what brought these children into the armed group in the first place. This means understanding these processes of militarisation.

These processes of militarisation cannot be assumed to be the same everywhere, however. As Wessells (2006) rightly points out, the ways in which children are brought into armed groups must be considered when understanding their involvement in armed conflict. Not all armed groups recruit children in the same way (Hart 2008). The cultural and social environment plays a significant role in how these processes of recruitment and militarisation take place. Henrik Vigh (2008) shows in his work on child soldiers in Guinea Bissau that the ways in which military groups recruit children and turn them into soldiers are dependent on social structures, the

nature of agency and subjectivity, patrimonial structures, ethnic networks and friendship circles within the society. The experience of a 12-year-old associated with an armed guerrilla group in sub-Saharan Africa may be significantly different from a 17-year-old associated with an armed force in the United Kingdom (Denov 2010).

Thus, what is much needed in the burgeoning literature on children's involvement in conflict, discussed in detail in the next chapter, is a focus on not just how the mobilisation of children occurs but how loyalties and attachments are formed that make children stay in armed groups. This should include issues such as the way in which honour is distributed, the promising of rewards, understandings of masculinity and femininity, legitimisation of violence and intergenerational tensions regarding age and transitions to adulthood that may be embedded within understandings of militarisation. By taking into account socially and culturally specific constructions of soldiering, we can begin to understand not only how children enter into armed groups but how they take on the identities of armed groups and how they are militarised.

In order to do this, we need to map the ways in which militarism transforms communities, public cultures and the state as well as how it then becomes part of the consciousness of individuals. We need to understand how young people embody militarised worlds and how they come to form their own identities in relation to their militarised environments. This includes exploring how social worlds are formed and how they can be shifted and changed, which is one of the key aims of this book. As Veena Das (2008) points out, in order to understand the reality of violence, it is necessary to understand its potential to make and unmake social worlds. Thus, we must understand how worlds are unmade by violence but also how they are remade. We also need to understand how these worlds are meaningful to children, how children living within conflict zones understand these processes of militarisation and how they influence children's decisions to become part of an armed group? How are children's identities made as soldiers when they join armed groups? Most importantly, how do children undergo these transitions from being civilians into becoming the perpetrators of destruction and violence? This book aims to unpack how these processes of militarisation work in Colombia and explore how children are initiated into the complex world of violence and armed conflict. It aims to explore what Salvadoran social psychologist Dr. Martin-Baro refers to as 'mental militarisation', wherein hostile responses to societal difficulties are seen as the norm and how this occurs in the Colombian context.

In book, I argue that we can understand how this occurs through looking at militarism, as Gusterson (2007) suggests, as a lifeworld of its own with its own logic and ways of being.

Using lifeworlds as a theoretical structure is a useful way to analyse all of these aspects of militarisation. The concept of lifeworlds has its roots in the work of Husserl and is an existential-phenomenological methodology concerned with human experience and the meanings people attach to what happens to them. Lifeworld entered the vocabulary of twentieth-century philosophy and social theory with the publication of Edmund Husserl's *The Crisis of the European Sciences and Transcendental Phenomenology* in 1936. Alfred Schutz had earlier adopted the term, following correspondence with Husserl, in 1932 with *The Phenomenology of the Social World*. By the lifeworld, Husserl meant the intersubjective background understandings that make knowledge meaningful. In this context, knowledge is understood as experience that is built through the cultural environment and the spatial, temporal and casual relations that exist within it. For Habermas (1991), the lifeworld is made up of background facts that are always part of our own lifeworld and those that we share with others. The lifeworld, according to Habermas, consists of three equally significant components: a culture, a society that embodies that culture and the development of a personality structure that is appropriate to living within that particular society. For Berger and Luckman (1966, p. 33), people live in worlds that are 'real' to them, in which they 'know' with confidence what characteristics that world possesses. Reality is thus the knowledge that certain phenomena are real with certainty. The worlds in which we live can therefore be described as the taken-for-granted reality that is perceived to be ordinary by members of society. They are essentially the mental landscapes within which we live that have been shaped by our external environments.

Lifeworlds theory allows us to understand the 'common threads' that have shaped the worlds of the children who have chosen to join an armed group. We can explore how the 'mental map' of child combatants has been formed through understanding the intersubjective relations within which they have grown up both before they joined an armed group and while they are in it. This includes exploring the ways in which the child believes 'how the world should be'. How do children understand the prevalence of soldiers, military vehicles and weapons in their environments? How do children understand the armed activity taking place around them and how do they understand concepts of power, honour and legitimacy in such environments? What factors influence communicative action and how are

structures of knowledge formed in contexts where killing, kidnapping and extortion are commonplace? In environments where war and violence have become the everyday, then war and violence may simply envelop everything that the child ‘knows’, with certainty, to be real. In such a context, a child may view becoming a soldier and using violence as a natural progression to take in life as well as a means of obtaining power, wealth and education.

Understanding the militarisation of children therefore involves thinking beyond just soldiers to consider what it means to be human. It involves understanding the broader cultural environment in which the militarisation is taking place and the processes used by armed groups to create attachment to the armed groups. It involves thinking about how legitimacy and authority are constructed within armed groups and how they establish internal cohesion. It is also essential to understand how symbolism is used to bring about self-legitimation and how rituals, rhetoric and memory that are interrelated with the culture are used to promote militarisation. It involves thinking about how individuals embody their militarised environments and create a particular way of thinking where social norms and social actions associated with the military enter the deepest fibres of their bodily being (McSorley 2013). This book therefore aims to go beyond understanding the motivations of child recruitment such as poverty and revenge and link them to the specific structures and phenomena that shape the social fabric of Colombia to militarisation. It aims to look at war as a social phenomenon that is built through violence, symbols and culture that can then become linked to phenomenological understandings of identity and self.

As will be explained in Chapter 6, the situation in Colombia has changed significantly since I completed my fieldwork and began writing this book. Since then, the FARC has entered into a demobilisation process following long peace talks that took place in Havana, Cuba, of which will be explored in greater depth in Chapter 6. Most of the FARC have come out of the jungle, handed over their weapons and agreed to enter into a civilian life. After more than 50 years of civil war, the FARC officially no longer exist. However, even though some changes have occurred, there still much about the situation in Colombia has remained much as I observed it. The conflict with the ELN persists even though they have also recently agreed to enter into peace talks. Violence from the many armed criminal gangs in the cities also remains a problem as does rural poverty, corruption, inequality and discrimination.

This book ultimately argues that the militarisation of a child can be done by shifting the child between civilian worlds and military worlds or, in the

case of Colombia, by blurring the lines between the military and civilian worlds through violence. That militarisation is achieved through the very distinct process of adaptation in both becoming a soldier and becoming a child again after their return home. Thus, through providing a multi-faceted and cross-cultural understanding of the conflict using anthropological tools, I aim to contribute to understanding the socio-structural factors that have generated, shaped and given meaning to violence in Colombia and more specifically, how this violence is meaningful to children recruited into the FARC.

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CHAPTER 2

Children and War: A Global Perspective

INTRODUCTION

Throughout history, conflicts over food, territory, riches, power and prestige have been an almost constant recurrence. Indeed, much of human history has been shaped by warfare (Singer 2006). The world as we know it today has largely been shaped by violent struggle. The nature of warfare and the tactics used by various armed groups have, however, changed significantly since the end of the Cold War. Whereas wars were once previously fought almost entirely between soldiers, in more recent times the victims of wars have become primarily civilian as tactics of ethnic cleansing and genocide have become more commonplace. During World War I, it is estimated that 5% of the casualties were civilians, as battles were fought far away from civilian areas (Singer 2006, p. 5). By the end of the same century, war was increasingly being fought in areas populated by civilians. Consequently, civilians came to constitute 80–90% of those injured and killed (Boyden and Hart 2007, p. 238). The 1996 report on the Impact of Armed Conflict on children, by Graca Machel, which has served as a template for virtually all human rights reporting on child soldiers, described modern warfare in post-colonial states as involving the abandonment of all standards, which has resulted in a sense of dislocation and chaos and a breakdown of traditional societies caused by globalisation and social revolutions. The report suggests that war combatants are no longer able to distinguish between combatants and civilians, which has led to particularly

high levels of violence and brutality including the recruitment of children into armed groups.

Throughout the world tens of thousands of people below the age of eighteen are currently associated with armed groups (Drumbl 2012). Images of young children with AK47s on television screens have sparked global debate and moral outrage. These images are disturbing because they confound two fundamental assumptions of society: one is that children are innocent and should be protected, and the other is that children should not be involved with war. So when we see children as soldiers, we assume that something is wrong (Rosen 2005). Expert on children in war, Peter Singer (2006), argues that this perspective that children should not be involved in war has emerged from taboos globally, from ancient Chinese philosophy and traditional African tribal societies to the state signatories of the modern-day Geneva Conventions. Throughout the world distinctions have been made between soldiers and civilians where those who are allowed to fight are given honour and power in exchange for their fighting, and in return, civilians are given protection. This concept of the law of the innocents has been one of the most enduring rules of war. It states that civilians should not be involved in war and that special protection should be given to certain groups, in particular the old, women and most specifically, children. Up until recently, much of the literature as well as policy and law have been centred around this perspective that children should not be involved in war.

In this chapter, I give a detailed review of the current literature on child soldiering, drawing on a wide range of examples from both academic literature and the work of international humanitarian organisations. By showing how children are militarised within different contexts, this chapter will argue that child recruitment is dependent on the local environment in which the recruitment is occurring. I argue that there is need for further research on child soldiers that goes beyond current perspectives. Research should contextualise the nuances that shape children's decisions to become involved in armed groups and more importantly why they stay there. This chapter is therefore an exploration of the various contexts in which young people are brought into conflict in different parts of the world and provides a broad analysis of the many cultural, social, political and economic elements that draw young people into armed conflict.

CHILDREN AND WAR

Throughout the world, millions of young people have been seriously affected by armed conflict and displacement. As of 2015, around 21 million children have been directly affected by violence in the world's five most conflict-affected countries: Syria, Iraq, South Sudan, the Central African Republic and Yemen (UNICEF 2015). Groups such as the Islamic State and Boko Haram deliberately disregard international humanitarian law by using children as soldiers. In 2017, it was estimated that there were as many as 300,000 children under the age of 18 serving as combatants around the globe in armed forces, rebel groups and terrorist organisations (Steinl 2017, p. 2). As of 2006, children have served as soldiers on every continent but Antarctica (Singer 2006). That statistic remains unchanged. In 2016, the United Nations reported that more than 50 parties to armed conflict were using child soldiers in 17 countries around the world (Becker 2017). Each year the UN Secretary-General publishes a list of shame, showing the state armed forces and non-state armed groups who recruit and use children. The 2016 list includes the armed forces of seven countries: Afghanistan, Central African Republic, Colombia, Democratic Republic of the Congo, Mali, Myanmar, Nigeria, Philippines, Somalia, South Sudan, Sudan, Syria and Yemen. According to this list, at least 43 state armed forces train children for armed conflict but do not normally use them as active combatants until they turn 18. Child soldiering is clearly a global phenomenon.

Defining a 'child soldier' is a complex issue, however. Who is a child? And who is a soldier? As defined in several UN treaties since World War II, a child is anyone under 18. However, the definition of who is a child is not always so clear. The Convention on the Rights to the Child defines a child as anyone under the age of 18 while the UN World Programme of Action for Youth identifies youth as 15–24 (United Nations 2005). The World Health Organization and the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) define adolescents as 15–19 years old, youth as 15–24 years old and young people as being 10–24 years old (World Bank 2007). The first universal definition of a child soldier was established by the NGO Working Group on the Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC) and UNICEF in 1997:

Any person under 18 years of age who is part of any kind of regular or irregular armed force or armed group in any capacity, including but not limited to cooks, porters, messengers and anyone accompanying such groups, other

than family members. The definition includes girls recruited for sexual purposes and for forced marriage. It does not, therefore, only refer to a child who is carrying or has carried arms. (Steinl 2017, p. 5)

Phillipe Aries (1962) argues that the concept of childhood is largely linked to Western societies, as is the idea that youth is a period of liminality, lack of responsibility and education. He argues that such ideas suggest that child development and well-being are based on biological and psychological factors that are thought to be understood in the same way across classes and cultures everywhere. They also assume that the progression towards adulthood occurs in the same way universally, where by the time a child turns 18, it is assumed that they have become an adult (Boyden and de Berry 2004). However, globally this is not always the case and within different cultural groups and countries definitions of 'child' and 'childhood' can vary significantly, as do ideas about the transition to adulthood. Nevertheless, much of the discourse on child soldiering to date has used the universalist definitions adopted by international, non-governmental human rights/humanitarian organisations (HROs). They typically follow the 'straight 18' position, where childhood begins at birth and ends at 18 (Rosen 2005). Within this framework, an ideal childhood is assumed to be a period of innocence, so child soldiering is considered to be immoral and an abhorrent abuse of children's rights.

As a result, HROs have called for a universal ban on the involvement of anyone under 18 years in armed groups (Rosen 2005). They have called for international law to recognise that children should not be involved in war and have been highly influential in shaping international treaties on child soldiering. The Geneva Conventions of 1949, which define the laws of war and are concerned with the problem of international aggression between the armed forces of sovereign states, were the first to emerge and provide protections for children (Dupuy and Peters 2010). The 1977 Protocols Additional to the Geneva Conventions and the provisions of the 1998 Rome Statute and the new International Criminal Court (ICC) make the use or recruitment of children under fifteen a war crime (Singer 2006). While these treaties have proven to be difficult to enforce, they serve a purpose in setting standards for children's involvement in war. Such treaties have been backed up by the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC) (1989) which is the principal framework that underpins all international guidance in relation to children. The CRC sets universal and non-negotiable standards and obligations and minimum entitlements and

freedoms to be respected by governments. The Convention has played a critical role in defining the role of the child and declares that children should grow up in a family environment, in an atmosphere of happiness, love and understanding, and that adults and governments play an integral role in fulfilling the rights of children. The CRC has been almost universally ratified, bringing children's rights and protection to the forefront of the international development and the humanitarian agenda (Pupavac 2001). The CRC also provides specific protections for children in war. Article 38 proclaims: 'State parties shall take all feasible measures to ensure that persons who have not attained the age of 15 years do not take part in hostilities'. However, children over the age of 15 but under the age of 18 are still able to take part as soldiers voluntarily (Coalition to Stop the Use of Child Soldiers 2000).

The 1977 additional protocols were added to the Geneva Conventions. These amendments, known as Additional Protocol I and Additional Protocol II, were the first attempts to directly address the issue of child combatants in armed conflict, and Additional Protocol II addresses the issue of child combatants in non-international conflicts such as civil wars, rebellions and insurgencies. The protocols created two categories of children: younger children, below the age of fifteen, and older children, between fifteen and eighteen. The protection afforded to children by the protocols is linked to the type of conflict and the particular age category involved (El-Haj and Hamilton 1997). Additional Protocol I imposes only minimal requirements on sovereign states and does not actually prohibit child recruitment. Instead, it discourages recruitment of younger children into national armed forces and requires state parties to take all feasible measures to ensure that children who have not turned fifteen years old do not become directly involved in armed conflict. It also requires that they do not recruit them into their armed forces (Rosen 2015). The term 'direct participation in hostilities' generally means active combat, such as firing at an enemy or blowing up a bridge, but does not include other important military activities such as intelligence gathering or transportation or supplies. The term 'feasible measures' subordinates the protection of children to the goal of ensuring the success of military operations (Rosen 2015).

While it is easy for nation states to agree that rules should be placed upon insurgent groups, the enforcement of these rules has been another story. While many nations have agreed that armed groups should be subject to criminal liability, there was the problem of having an international legal system for putting offenders on trial and punishing those found guilty.

In 1977, when the protocols were put in place, there had been no international war crimes trials since the Nuremberg Tribunals following World War II. Even after Nuremberg, enforcing international criminal law required the creation of tribunals established after particular conflicts (Boczek 2005). These included the 1993 International Criminal Tribunal for Rwanda and the 2002 Special Court for Sierra Leone (Rosen 2015). Thus, the creation of the ICC in The Hague in 2002 was a key event for the issue of child soldiers. The court's jurisdiction is grounded in the 1998 Rome Statute of the ICC which consolidates many of the traditional laws of war into a single international criminal statute. It makes the recruitment of children under fifteen years old a war crime and provides for both the trial and the imprisonment by the ICC in The Hague of persons charged and convicted of recruiting children (Sivakumaran 2012). This treaty gives the newly created court jurisdiction over war crimes when committed as part of a plan or policy or as part of a large-scale commission of such crimes. The ICC is the only permanent international court where individuals charged with war crimes can be brought to trial (Rosen 2015).

In 1999, governments negotiating the International Organization's Worst Forms of Child Labour Convention agreed that the forced recruitment of children under the age of 18 for use in armed conflict was one of the world forms of child labour and should be prohibited (International Labour Office, Geneva 2011). In 2000, the United Nations adopted an optional protocol to the CRC on the involvement of children in armed conflict, raising the minimum age for all direct participation in hostilities to age 18. The protocol prohibited government forces from conscripting or forcibly recruiting children under the age of 18 but allowed voluntary recruitment from the age of 16 with certain safeguards, provided the child did not take part in hostilities. The protocol states that non-state armed groups should not recruit children under the age of 18 for any purpose, whether voluntarily or otherwise (Becker 2017). International courts have also begun to prosecute individuals for using child soldiers. Between 2005 and 2008, the ICC issued arrest warrants against six individuals from the Congo and Uganda for the enlistment or conscription of children under the age of 15 (Human Rights Watch 2009). In March 2012, the ICC found the Congolese warlord Thomas Lubanga guilty of recruiting and using child soldiers in the armed conflict in that country, making him the court's first convicted war criminal (Human Rights Watch 2009). The statute for the Special Court for Sierra Leone also treated the recruitment and use of children under the age of 15 as a war crime. The court convicted nine

individuals for recruiting and using child soldiers, including Liberia's former president, Charles Taylor (Becker 2017). Such condemnations, which have largely been driven by the international humanitarian community, have set an international standard that child soldiering is unacceptable at all times.

The humanitarian approach to children in war has, however, been criticised by anthropologists, sociologists and political scientists as lacking an understanding of cross-cultural understandings of childhood, war and violence. In more recent times, academics, in particular anthropologists, have drawn attention to the idea that understandings of violence, war and children's involvement may not be understood in the same way globally. They instead put forth the argument that ideas around childhood and children's involvement in war are contextual and are based on the cultural environment in which they are taking place and, therefore, cannot be understood in any one homogeneous way (Denov 2010). Boyden and Levinson (2000) define childhood using a number of different criteria, including when one begins to work, when school ends or when one can get married, all of which may vary according to the child's social class and cultural group. As anthropologist Susan Shepler (2014) argues, a 'child's best interests' are therefore a matter of cultural interpretation and concepts such as the 'rights' and 'needs' of the child may in fact not be in line with the dominant humanitarian discourse on childhood.

In Afghanistan, for example, after years of war, poverty and lack of social infrastructure, Jo de Berry (2003) argues that the labour of young people is considered to be an essential survival strategy for Afghan households. Boys may be sent to work on the street or travel abroad to find work to send money home to their families. In such a context, a young man does not have time for education. Thus, in societies where childhood is not bound by the 'straight eighteen' rule or it is not considered to be a period of innocence, soldiering may in fact be considered a legitimate activity for children under 18 years. Jo Boyden (2007) further argues that there are many cases around the world where the young are regarded as especially suited to warfare. Similarly, David Rosen (2005) cites a number of accounts such as those by Boyden and Rosen who show that there are cases around the world where children and the military life are not necessarily understood as incompatible. Child soldiering may in fact be considered a necessary and fundamental part of the functioning of society.

Another theme in the humanitarian narrative that has faced criticism is the assumption of the inherent vulnerability of children who are used

as child soldiers. This perspective argues that children do not yet have the cognitive developmental skills to be able to fully assess the risks of becoming a child soldier and therefore lack the capacity to make their own choices. Child soldiering is assumed to be an abhorrent instance of children's victimisation. However, this notion is also increasingly being challenged by academics. Rosen (2005) argues that while there are certain situations where children are taken by force by armed forces, research is showing that young people often consciously create ways to make the best of their situation during armed conflicts. Boyden (1999) also cautions the international community about making assumptions about how children respond to war and argues that while children suffer during conflict, many children do have the capacity to act on their own. Graca Machel (1996) makes the argument that to view child soldiers as only victims is to ignore children's agency and their ability to make decisions and choices in regard to their actions during times of war. What these researchers are claiming is that despite adverse circumstances, children are often able to exercise agency and be aware of the consequences of their actions. For example, young people may consciously choose to rebel against dominant political and economic institutions (Denov 2010). As Krijn Peters (2004, p. 30) writes: 'child soldiers are for the most part, knowledgeable young people who take rational and active decisions to maximise their situations under difficult circumstances. It is dangerous to overlook the agency of youth'. Young people in armed conflict often find ways of appropriating and subverting it (Argenti 2002). Thus, for many young people war may be a means by which they can gain agency, as opposed to losing it.

Mats Utas (2003) found that in Liberia, children took advantage of the war situation by looting in raids, taking bribes and receiving payoffs for protecting locals. For males, a direct advantage would include being able to acquire power in local communities, being able to have girlfriends and to rape at will. For women, taking up arms or using ties with boyfriends, civilians or peacekeepers in 'girlfriending' was a means to survive. Angela Veale's (2003) study of female child ex-combatants in Ethiopia's Tigray People's Liberation Front also highlights how girls were politically aware and that being an ex-fighter was something that women perceived to be a positive part of their identities. Similarly, Harry West (2004), who conducted research with former female combatants from Frelimo in Mozambique, found that women reported their experiences with the armed group to be both empowering and liberating as it freed them from patriarchal structures of dominance in Mozambican society. In this way, young girls were taking

advantage of the war situation in order to gain power as opposed to losing it. Boyden (2004) also shows how in Palestine and Afghanistan children are often more politically aware than adults may assume and can play a transformative role in the production and reproduction of culture, particularly during and following war. Such studies show that young people can have a remarkable understanding of the political causes of wars. Young people can be political actors who have the capacity to make conscious decisions in armed conflicts.

It should be noted, however, as Anthony Giddens (1984) argues that action is not always guided with a clear purpose but rather is often a reaction to circumstances in which those people find themselves. One needs to be cautious about considering how choices are made. Considering the socio-economic circumstances of many child soldiers around the world, it is difficult to know to what extent children make decisions that are not a result of their economic situation. Structural features like forms of power and domination may place young people in situations where their choices are limited (Denov 2010). Economic restraints may also severely restrict young people's ability to make choices in life, and they may see joining an armed group as the only means for survival and protection. Indeed, children, particularly very young children, may not be able to fully grasp the long-term consequences of becoming part of an armed group. Thus, while in many cases children do in fact exercise agency either by choosing to join an armed group or by using the armed group as a means to gain personal advantage, they may do so in a context where their opportunities are limited. Despite this, much of the recent scholarly work on child soldiers does agree that the dominant humanitarian notion that child soldiers are only vulnerable needs challenging as it arguably does not provide a holistic, globally relevant understanding of children in war. Child soldiering should be understood in relation to the social, political and economic context in which is taking place, which can vary considerably. The following section aims to demonstrate the global nature of child soldiering and why there is a need for contextual studies of why children become involved in war.

THE HISTORICAL GLOBAL CONTEXT

The use of children as soldiers in war is not a new phenomenon, as much of the current discourse on child soldiers suggests. Peter Singer (2006) demonstrates that throughout history children have been involved in war. For example, in medieval Europe, boy pages helped arm and maintain the

knights of medieval Europe, while drummer boys and ‘powder monkeys’ (small boys who ran ammunition to cannon crews) were a part of many armies in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. Beginning in the Middle Ages, boy soldiers were routinely recruited into the British military and in 1765 in Great Britain the Royal Military Asylum was founded for the children with some of its earliest recruits being only twelve and thirteen years old (Rosen 2005). Perhaps the most well-known use of child soldiers in history was the famous ‘Children’s Crusade’ where thousands of unarmed boys from northern France and western Germany marched towards the Holy Land thinking that they would take it back with the power of their faith. In the United States in the early nineteenth century, the US Navy was permitted to recruit boys as young as age 13, while the US Marine Corps was allowed to recruit children as young as 11 (Rosen 2012). While they were not the majority, children throughout the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries were regularly present in military life (Rosen 2012). More recently, the Hitler Jugend (Hitler Youth) was a group of young boys who had received quasi-military training as part of a political programme to maintain Nazi rule through indoctrination (Singer 2006). Thousands of British soldiers who also fought in World War I were under the age of 18. They were regarded as ‘brave young men’ who responded to their historic call, such as was seen on inscriptions typical of many gravestones: ‘ONLY A BOY BUT A HERO; Killed in Action 30th August 1916, aged 17’ or ‘O SO YOUNG & YET SO BRAVE; Killed in Action 9th September 1916, aged 16’ (Rosen 2005, p. 8). Such examples show how children were involved with war but were viewed in a fundamentally different way from today.

In more recent times, there has been extensive use of children in conflicts and the following is an overview of the many cases of ‘child soldiers’ documented by researchers, NGOs and international organisations. It is difficult to find accurate figures of the extent in which child soldiers are used in armed conflicts around the world so the accounts I give below are an indication of the numbers. Africa has been considered to be at the epicentre of the child soldier phenomenon. Many of the conflicts in the last century on the African continent have used child combatants. In Angola, a survey revealed that 36% of all Angolan children had either served as soldiers or worked alongside soldiers (Singer 2006, p. 19). In the conflict in Mozambique, Renamo, one of the armed groups, is thought to have used up to 10,000 child soldiers (Honwana 2006, p. 29). Similarly, in Liberia children have been a prominent feature in two wars over the last decade (Felton 2008).

During the civil war in the Democratic Republic of the Congo between 1998 and 2003, there were more than a dozen guerrilla groups, who have been accused by the UN of forcibly recruiting hundreds, and possibly thousands, of children (Felton 2008, p. 15). In the Central African Republic, there are several armed groups who have reportedly recruited child soldiers, most of whom are attached to the Seleka coalition, a largely Muslim alliance (Rosen 2015). Sudan has also experienced several major conflicts in recent years, where children were used by the government's Sudan Armed Forces as well as by the pro-government militias known as the Janjaweed, the Justice and Equality Movement (JEM) and the Sudan Liberation Army (SLA), which have both splintered into factions. The Sudan People's Liberation Army (SPLA) also used child soldiers in their war for independence from northern Sudan (Child Soldiers International 2007).

In Uganda, child soldiers have been used by the Lord's Resistance Army (LRA). The United Nations estimates that nearly 25,000 children were forced into the army by Joseph Kony between 1986 and 2005, while researchers at Tufts University in Boston estimate that the LRA have abducted at least 60,000 boys and girls (Felton 2008, p. 18). Chad's persistent outbreaks of armed conflict since the 2000s have included the widespread recruitment and use of children, by all parties, including by the Chadian National Army (Armée Nationale Tchadienne/ANT) (Child Soldiers International 2012). In Mali, Ansar Dine or the Defenders of the Faith, a militant Islamic group with reported ties to al Qaeda, have recruited child soldiers although the numbers are unknown (Rosen 2015). Amnesty International (2016) estimates that in Somalia, up to 5000 child soldiers have been recruited by al-Shabaab and other militia groups. In Rwanda, thousands of children are thought to have participated in the 1994 genocide and in Burundi, up to fourteen thousand, many as young as twelve, fought with Hutu rebel groups (Singer 2006). Large numbers of Ethiopian youths fought in their country's war with Eritrea and in Sierra Leone as many as 80% of fighters in the Revolutionary United Front (RUF) were aged between seven and fourteen years (Singer 2006).

The use of children in war has not been limited to Africa however. In the Middle East, Palestinian Islamic Jihad and Hamas have recruited children as young as 13 to be suicide bombers and children as young as 11 to smuggle explosives and weapons (Felton 2008, p. 19). In 2010, Pakistan experienced attacks by armed groups influenced by the Taliban or Al-Qaida, in which children were used to carry out suicide attacks (UNICEF 2011). In Yemen, about 20% of Al-Houthi and 15% of the tribal militia

affiliated with the government, Al Jaysh Al-Sha'bi, are children. Children have been observed working as security for both the pro-government militia and Al-Houthi (UNICEF 2011). Child Soldiers International (2016) reported that in Afghanistan, the Afghan National Army and the Afghan local police have recruited children. The Haqqani network, Hezbe-Islami of Gulbuddin Hekmatyar and Taliban forces are also reported to be recruiting children. In January 2011, Afghanistan's National Directorate of Security asserted that more than 80% of the 112 would-be suicide bombers detained in the country in 2010 were boys aged between 13 and 17. The majority of Afghan child soldiers are male, though some girls have reportedly been forced into marriages with fighters in factional and clan-based militias and armed groups. Girls may also perform the same military functions as the men and in some cases may be preferred as they raise less suspicion. Male children have also been recruited for sexual purposes, and in recent years, young boys have been used for sex and entertainment by older male soldiers (Boutin 2014).

Saddam Hussein's regime in Iraq trained specialised child soldier units, most notably the Ashbal Saddam, Saddam's Lion Cubs, which involved boys between the ages of ten and fifteen (Singer 2006). Since 2010, there have been consistent reports received by the United Nations, civil society groups, national authorities and security forces, as well as the United States Forces in Iraq (USF-I) that Al-Qaida in Iraq operates a youth wing for children under the age of 14 called 'Birds of Paradise' (also referred to as 'Paradise Boys' or 'Youth of Heaven') to carry out suicide attacks against military, government and civilian targets (UNICEF 2011). In more recent times, Human Rights Watch (2016) has reported that tribal militias in Northern Iraq have recruited children to join the Iraqi Security Forces (ISF) to fight against ISIS in Mosul. ISIS has also systematically recruited minors. Children have featured in the social media feeds of foreign fighters such as when an Australian jihadi in the ISIS-held territory of Raqqa posted a photo on Twitter of his 7-year-old son holding up a severed head with the caption, 'that's my boy'. The abducted children of Yezidis and other opponents have also been added to the ranks of ISIS (Dettmer 2015). Many of ISIS's reinforcements sent to Kobani in northern Syria were reported to be Syrian and Iraqi children. The militants have reportedly issued registration papers to local parents requiring them to send their children to schools in areas controlled by the group and have forced them to swear allegiance to the group and teach the curriculum given by the militants (Dettmer 2015).

Children are also reportedly being indoctrinated inside mosques and are being encouraged to join the ranks with payment.

In Asia, numerous human rights organisations and other organisations have reported that the government of Myanmar as well as non-state military groups have used children in their armies and the country and is widely reported amongst human rights groups to have one of the highest numbers of child soldiers in the world (Child Soldiers International 2016). The government began recruiting children in the 1990s to fight against rebel movements in Karen state in south-eastern Myanmar. Responding in part to pressure from the UN, the government in 2004 created a committee to prevent the military recruitment of under-18-year-olds (Felton 2008). However, then Secretary-General of the UN, Ban Ki-moon, wrote in a report in November 2007 that recruitment was continuing (Felton 2008, p. 16). The Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), better known as the Tamil Tigers, also reportedly recruited thousands of children during the civil war with the Sri Lankan government. A breakaway rebel group, known as the Karuna group, which has been associated with the government, also reportedly has used child soldiers (Coalition to Stop the Use of Child Soldiers 2008). In India, a number of left-wing revolutionary groups in Kashmir have reportedly used children in their groups (Coalition to Stop the Use of Child Soldiers 2008). In the Philippines, Abu Sayyaf, Bangsamoro Islamic Freedom Fighters and the Moro Islamic Liberation have all reportedly recruited child soldiers (Rosen 2015). In Cambodia, the Khmer Rouge became known for their use of young soldiers (Honwana 2006). In Thailand, according to Child Soldiers International (2015), children as young as 14 have been recruited and used by the Barisan Revolusi Nasional Melayu Patani (BRN) and other armed groups operating across southern Thailand. In Nepal, the Communist Party of Nepal and its armed wing, the People's Liberation Army, recruited boys and girls who were mostly under 16 years old (Coalition to Stop the Use of Child Soldiers 2008). It is estimated by Human Rights Watch (2007) that tens of thousands of Nepali children were forced to flee their homes to escape forced recruitment.

The majority of child soldiers in Europe have fought in Chechnya, Daghestan, Kosovo, Macedonia and Nagorno-Karabakh. In Bosnia, many children were recruited into armed groups during the civil war that began in 1992 (Coalition to Stop the Use of Child Soldiers 2001). In Kosovo, many young teens fought in the Kosovo Liberation Army, KLA, in the war against the Serbs in 1998–1999. Paramilitary groups were also reported to have recruited children into their ranks (Coalition to Stop the Use of Child

Soldiers 2001). In Chechnya, a large number of youths aged between 14 and 16 have joined separatist bands (Coalition to Stop the Use of Child Soldiers 2004). In Turkey, where the highest number of child soldiers in any European country is found, the Kurdish separatist group the PKK began the systematic recruitment of children aged as young as seven years old. Ten per cent were girls (Singer 2006, p. 108).

In the Americas since the 1990s, child soldiers have fought in armed groups in Ecuador, El Salvador, Guatemala, Mexico (in the Chiapas conflict), Nicaragua and Paraguay. In Peru, young children fought with the Shining Path (Honwana 2006). During Guatemala's civil war between 1960 and 1996, many children were forcibly recruited by armed opposition groups including the Unidad Revolucionaria Nacional Guatemalteca (Coalition to Stop the Use of Child Soldiers 2004). During the civil war in El Salvador from 1980 to 1992, it was reported that the Farabundo Martí National Liberation Front used children (Coalition to Stop the Use of Child Soldiers 2001).

In Latin America, the largest numbers of child soldiers have been in Colombia, the focus of this book. Children have been a definitive feature of the Colombian conflict and in recent times held the fourth place in the world with the highest number of children in the illegal armed groups, after the Democratic Republic of Congo, Rwanda and Myanmar (Pachon 2012, p. 10). The presence of children in conflict in Colombia is not new, however. Since independence from Spanish colonial rule, children have been soldiers in the civil wars of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. They have been called 'bells' by paramilitary forces for their use as sentinels or alarm clocks and 'beehives' by the guerrillas because they sting their enemies before they know they are under attack (Pachon 2012, p. 15). They were also called 'carts' or 'wheelbarrows' by urban militias in Antioquia due to their ability to hide weapons and pass through the checkpoints without suspicion (*ibid.*). Children continue to play a considerable role in the armed conflict in Colombia, and it is estimated that before the peace agreement with the FARC was signed in October of 2017, there were 11,000–18,000 children involved with the FARC (Reed 2014, p. 6). A study from the University of Externado in Bogota, Colombia, places the number at 15,000 children involved with armed forces—9000 with the FARC, 3000 with the ELN and 3000 with *bacrim*. Natalia Springer, who has conducted significant research on child soldiers in Colombia, places the highest estimate at 18,000 (Reed 2014, p. 6). Over 50% of FARC members are recruited while under 18 years of age and the majority of Colombian child soldiers (80%)

report entering the forces voluntarily (Reed 2014, p. 6). While throughout the world there are numerous cases of children choosing to join armed groups, Colombia is relatively unusual in that it has such a high number of child voluntary recruitment.

WHY DO CHILDREN JOIN ARMED GROUPS?

One of the most frequently considered questions in the literature on child soldiers is why do organisations recruit children? Children can be undisciplined, their body and psychology are not prepared for the sustained hardships of war, and they do not have the physical capabilities of an adult so, why enlist children? Since the humanitarian discourse began to focus on the child soldiering phenomenon, a wide range of research has emerged to try and answer this question. During her fieldwork in Sierra Leone, anthropologist Shepler (2005, p. 112) was told that ‘the rebels only want young boys and girls because they are more easily controlled. If you tell them to kill they will’. Similarly, a Congolese rebel officer said that children are such good soldiers because ‘they obey orders, they are not concerned with getting back to their wife and family and they don’t know fear’ (Macomber 2011, p. 16). An official of the Chadian military explained the advantages of using children: ‘child soldiers are ideal because they don’t complain, they don’t expect to be paid and if you tell them to kill, they kill’ (Felton 2008, p. 13). Advances in weapons technology leading to the availability of small, light weapons have also widely been identified as a critical component in the expansion of children’s involvement in hostilities across the globe (United Nations News Centre 2008). In many cases, children are approached directly by armed groups and asked to fight while in some cases they are taken by force. The following is a discussion of the commonly cited reasons for children choosing to join armed groups.

Poverty and Powerlessness

Poverty is a major factor pushing children and young people to join armed groups. The breakdown of societal structures can have a serious impact on children. In the case of failed states and the associated widespread poverty, access to adequate shelter, safe water, health and social services, nutrition and education and employment activities often become limited (UNICEF 2008). This can lead to families pressuring young people to join an armed group as a means of survival (Honwana 2006). In Afghanistan, for example,

government corruption and the lack of opportunities have led to excessive poverty. Military groups offering access to physical protection, housing, food, medical care or opportunity for employment that otherwise would not be available provide attractive options for young people living within such contexts (Boutin 2014). The possibility of personal advantage may also motivate children to join an armed group (Utas 2003). In contexts of extreme poverty, the ability to acquire power in local communities can be attractive for many young people. Alcinda Honwana (2006) calls this ‘tactical agency’. For instance, she reports that a boy from Congo-Brazzaville said: ‘there I knew that I was going to take up weapons to feed my family, because at this time I knew that the Ninjas gave some manioc to their recruits. They even gave money’. A girl from the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) stated: ‘The army, it’s the only job here, so you stay in the army to stay alive’ (Brett and Specht 2004, p. 67). Studies in Sri Lanka have also shown a link between the decision to join armed groups and abusive situations, which result in feelings of extreme powerlessness, especially for girls (Boutin 2014). An armed group offering status, a gun as well as a sense of power and a means of survival could be highly attractive in such contexts (Wessells 2006).

The youth bulge theory has also gained prominence in the literature on children in war. It suggests that in places where there are large groups of young people, particularly where there is a large amount of unemployment, recruitment into armed groups is more likely (Boyden 2007). In 2003, British MP David Willetts claimed that most of the political and criminal violence throughout the world today is instigated by young people and that the most unstable countries globally are ‘wrestling with the social consequences of dramatic demographic change’ as ‘they can’t handle youthfulness’ (Boyden 2007, p. 256). Thus, the nations with the youngest populations are the ones that are the most likely to experience war. The Center for Strategic and International Studies in Washington, DC, also has suggested that the 25 countries with the most youthful populations have all experienced major civil conflict since 1995, with armed groups in countries such as in Iran, Afghanistan, Iraq, Syria and Pakistan having an average age of under 19 during times of conflict (Boyden 2007, p. 256).

According to the 2014 UNFPA report on the state of the world’s population, our world now is home to 1.8 billion young people between the ages of 10 and 24, which is the largest ever number of young people; it also showed that they typically live in areas of low economic growth. The youth bulge theory suggests a link between these two factors and the involvement

of young people in war. This could explain why in sub-Saharan Africa, where there is a high proportion of youth and economic problems, there have also been high levels of conflict in recent decades. Boyden (2007) says that there exists a clear point where communities reach a 'critical level' of youth and become prone to violence due to restricted economic and social opportunities for the young, especially the case where there is a high population of unemployed males. Certainly, many of the conflicts taking place throughout the world are occurring in economically fragile environments. In such situations, young people, particularly males, may feel unable to achieve a socially desired social status. Joining an armed group may be seen not only as a means of survival but also may be a means to attaining power and social status that would not be available to them otherwise. Thus, the idea of linking poverty with recruitment of youth into armed groups has become increasingly influential.

Ideology

Marci Macomber (2011) argues that amongst the major reasons that children join armed groups are for ideological reasons or a desire for revenge. Brett and Specht (2004) also show that children join armed groups for ideological reasons. They give the example of a boy in South Africa who said he chose to join the revolutionary army because he wanted to fight against racism in education. He stated: 'we must be aware of what is happening in the country, what happened in our education, and how can we change this education to the People's Education' (Brett and Specht 2004, p. 28). In Pakistan, a child said, 'I fought for the sake of my belief and for Islam.... It was our Islamic duty against infidelity. It was also a national duty upon us to fight against foreigners and occupiers' (Brett and Specht 2004, p. 28). Children may also demonstrate political agency by their decision to defend their community from tyranny. This was demonstrated by a boy from Northern Ireland who said, 'I wanted to be fighting for the cause of the Protestant people. I didn't like the way Sinn Fein/IRA ran about and shot innocent Protestant people' (Brett and Specht 2004, p. 28). Similarly, a child combatant from Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) stated: 'I joined after having seen the sufferings of the population. I decided to drive out Mobutu's men, who maltreated us' (Brett and Specht 2004, p. 28).

A desire for revenge for oneself or relatives can also motivate a young person to join an armed group. A Sri Lankan child who became a rebel combatant at age eleven stated: 'the killing of my mother and my little

sister that happened before my eyes made me decide to join the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Elam (LTTE) immediately and I made up my mind to take revenge' (Macomber 2011, p. 29). In Afghanistan, joining an armed struggle is a way for children to fulfil their ideological beliefs related to martyrdom, which has deep cultural roots in Afghanistan and is often seen as a way in which one can receive glory. Children may feel that to die for an ideology, which is attached to an armed group, is a worthy cause, making joining an armed group seem attractive (Boutin 2014). Thus, ideology can be a strong motivator for young people to take up arms with an armed group. However, ideological motivators are highly contextual and shaped by the local environment. Children are often motivated by ideological beliefs because of influences around them that have convinced them that they can attain social worth for themselves and those around them by fighting against an oppressor.

Replicating Social Structures of Peacetime

Children may also join an armed group as a means to reinforce or replicate structures in their society prior to the outbreak of war. Throughout many parts of the world, adolescence may be seen as a period of responsibility in which child labour is seen as important. Children may be expected to engage in domestic labour from an early age and undertake activities such as farming or errands. Thus, in such contexts a child's participation in conflict may not be seen as unusual as their contribution to the war effort may be interpreted as culturally appropriate labour. In Sierra Leone, Shepler (2005) found that the sociocultural context of child labour and practices of patronage influenced the way people understood military recruitment. In accordance with the traditional role of the child in Sierra Leone, children should work, so it was considered usual that the armed groups were recruiting children to conduct tasks such as fetching water, cooking, cleaning and military activities.

Utas (2003) shows how in Liberia during the civil war, Liberian youth saw opportunities to become initiated into adulthood through joining rebel armies. Youths largely would rise through the ranks by being daredevils and emulating the war chiefs of Liberian history, allowing them positions of power that were not available otherwise. In her study of the Mozambican National Resistance (RENAMO) combatants in Mozambique, Jessica Schafer (2004) shows how commanders recreated patriarchal structures of kinship as a way of socialising their soldiers into the armed group.

The commanders took on the role of fathers and positioned the troops as children. Through these ties, feelings of loyalty were established which motivated the children to serve on the battlefield. In his autobiography, Ishmael Beah (2007), a former child soldier from Sierra Leone in the RUF, recounts how the commander of his armed group carried out similar practices to establish feelings of loyalty. In such contexts, entrance into an armed group can be a means of children attaining a social or cultural status that would be unavailable to them otherwise.

Initiation Rites

In some societies, military participation is a means of becoming an adult. Ingunn Bjorkhaug (2010) argues that children may join armed groups as a way of acting out rites of passage or as an opportunity for social mobility. The concept of adolescence as a transition period is crucial here. In many eastern African communities, experience, courage and the capacity for aggression are strongly associated with the attainment of adult masculinity. The Dinka of Sudan, for example, traditionally initiated adolescent boys into warriorhood between the ages of 16 and 18 in order to attain social adulthood (Lee 2009). In some African societies, the inter-generational transfers of knowledge that occurred through initiation rituals are done now through soldiering, as when a young man is handed down knowledge of what is expected of him and how he should participate in war (Richards 1996b). In Sierra Leone, cultural practices including initiation have involved young people becoming involved with armed groups (Denov 2010). Caspar Fithen and Paul Richards (2005) also describe how in Sierra Leone the making of a 'hunter' in civil defence militia drew on local male initiation rites associated with the local hunting tradition.

Stephen Ellis (2005) also shows how the *Mouvement des Forces Démocratiques Casaman Caises* (MFDC) or the Movement for Democratic Forces in Casamance in Senegal, the *kamajoisia* in Sierra Leone, the Lofa Defense Force in Liberia, the Dozos in Côte d'Ivoire and the Bakassi Boys in Nigeria all used traditional initiation rituals within their military groups. Utas (2003) describes how in Liberia and Sierra Leone, the state crisis made it increasingly difficult for young people to transition to adulthood so many chose military recruitment as an alternative route for attaining social adulthood. Henrik Vigh (2010, p. 12) also explores the ways that youth from the Aguenta in Guinea Bissau created possibilities through the navigation of social ties. The prolonged periods of instability stopped the flow

of resources between generations, which would typically allow males to transition out of youth and into adulthood. Vigh (2010) argues that conflict and war give youth the opportunity to receive patronage in return for defence. Boyden (2007) also argues that amongst the Iteso in northern Uganda, warfare has become a means through which young men are able to become adults. After years of cattle raiding by neighbouring tribe the Karamajon, Iteso herds were depleted to the point where young males no longer have sufficient animals to pay bride price. They thus choose to go to war in order to retrieve their cattle so that they can marry and fulfil their social obligations. Mobilisation into armed groups in such contexts is a way of surviving a violent situation as well as fulfilling social obligations, such as being able to raise one's social status or achieve the social status of adulthood.

Enjoying Violence

One of the least explored reasons for children joining armed groups is that some may simply enjoy being involved in violence or have a desire for a gun. Michael Wessells (2006) suggests that children may perpetrate human rights abuses for several reasons, one of them being just simply because they enjoy it. At a seminar on child soldiers organised for US Marines by the Center for Emerging Threats and Opportunities (CETO), Major Gray, a Royal British Marine, observed:

The egocentric nature of children, the fact that when a child is a child, they don't have the ability to think about other people. They have a one step requirement that they fulfill. As you get older you understand about morality. They kind of fight like this. On a playground, they are harsh to each other, they fulfill their own needs all the time. You give them an AK 47 and it's a whole different story. You combine the fact that they are on drugs, you give them a weapon and they behave as if they were on a playground and it's terrifying. (Borchini et al. 2002, p. 18)

A sixteen-year-old was quoted by Krijn Peters and Paul Richards (1998, p. 194) as stating, 'I liked it in the army because we could do anything we liked to do. When some civilian had something I liked, I just took it without him doing anything to me. We used to rape women. Anything I wanted to do I did. I was free'. Such statements indicate that there is still much that is not known about children's motivations in war. Children

may in fact be able to enact considerable agency in times of war and enjoy participating in acts of violence, a fact that has been largely overlooked by the humanitarian agenda.

Normalisation of War

In many cases, the young people who become involved in warfare do so simply because the war exists. This is so obvious that it is often not considered to be a factor for the involvement of children in war. Where it is commonplace to have armed police or soldiers guarding the streets, where military staff hold top positions in government and have public curfews and armed checkpoints on roads, joining the military or an armed group may seem like normal step for a young person to take. In Israel, for example, the military has become a natural part of daily life and is understood to be an important part of citizenship. Levy and Sasson-Levy (2005) show how militarised socialisation in Israel begins in pre-school settings, where Israeli children are exposed to themes of persecution, heroism and war. By studying Israel's wars and taking field trips to learn about warriors and important battles, the role of the military is normalised in Israeli daily life. In other cases, where children have grown up in contexts of violence, entrance into an armed group may not be that much of a transition from where they have come from. Paul Richards (1996a) emphasises how young recruits during the war in Sierra Leone were no strangers to violence, as many had spent much of their lives on the streets, where personal and political violence were commonplace. Entrance into a violent armed group was not that different from the life to which they were already accustomed. Therefore, just the presence of a conflict may be enough of a motivating factor to draw young people into armed conflict.

COLOMBIA

Before discussing briefly whether the above-mentioned reasons are relevant to the Colombian context, it is important to first establish the context of violence and conflict in the country. Since gaining independence from the Spanish in 1821, Colombia's history shows that violence has played a consistent role. The first one hundred and fifty years of Colombian independence were characterised by a number of major periods of violence, most of which were over power, resources and land (Tate 2007). Political divisions have also had a strong role to play in the production of violence in

the country. The Colombian political system has traditionally been a closed bipartisan system in which the interests of the country's elite have dominated. In 1938, a shift to the right involved the reversal of land and labour laws which consequently had many negative effects for Colombia's rural poor. The liberal politician Jorge Eliecer Gaitan emerged at this time as a popular leader and offered an alternative to the traditional bipartisan system. He gained support from many of Colombia's working class who felt exploited by the conservative party (Borch and Stuvoy 2008). However, on April 9, 1946, he was killed by a lone gunman. The shooter was killed before his motives could be identified, but the suspects include leaders of the Liberal and Conservative Parties, US spies and the Communist Party (Dudley 2004). His supporters were outraged, and his death sparked the next wave of violence in Colombia.

Between 1946 and 1965, an undeclared civil war known as La Violencia began which was fought between the Liberal and Conservative Parties. Terror, violence and scorched earth policies were deliberately used to suppress leftist supporters of Gaitan (Hylton 2006). By its end, there were over 200,000 victims, who were mostly illiterate peasants (Pachon 2012). The situation in Colombia did not improve following the end of the civil war. The working class remained disempowered as the government was unable to improve problems with lack of food, proper sanitation and access to health care and education, all of which created a fertile ground for recruiting the rural poor. By the early 1960s, the Communist Party controlled five small municipalities in the department of Tolima inhabited mostly by peasants. In 1964, the Colombian government, with assistance from the US military, began a bombing campaign on these areas causing the survivors to flee into various parts of the countryside in the mountains where they began to rebuild their armed organisation. The Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (FARC) was born (Hristov 2009).

Children were also very much part of the military and political events during La Violencia. Accounts can be traced in some of the texts that have been written about the period and especially in the book *The Violence in Colombia*, by Monsignor Guzman, Orland Fals Borda and Eduardo Umana Luna (Pachon 2012, p. 5). During this war, children also worked as messengers, pointers and spies as well as fighters (Pachon 2012, p. 6). Women mostly prepared meals and sewed uniforms; however, some girls were also involved as soldiers. One of the most famous fighters of the middle of the twentieth century was Teofiol Rojas, better known as Sparky who at 13 years old and after only six months of school was reported to have taken

refuge in the mountains after witnessing the conservative police violence against his family. Sparky met with other peasants, some of his same age or younger as well as others who were older and began to organise a defence group (Pachon 2012). Sparky became the commander of a powerful group who were mostly the children of labourers. By the time he was 22, he was accused of having committed 400 crimes, including crimes against women and children (Pachon 2012). Child soldiering has therefore long been part of Colombia's history.

The FARC declared themselves as a peasant self-defence group, composed initially of liberal families and operating predominantly in rural areas. Their primary goal was to take over the government of Colombia and install a Marxist-based government that would work for the interests of the country's peasants as defined by the agrarian programme of 1964 (Sanin 2007). The political project of the FARC has arguably moved away from their Agrarian Program of 1964 as they have become involved in a number of illegal and violent activities, which have played a large role in contributing to the production of violence in the country. The group first started to expand outside of rural areas into cities in 1966 and began a violent process of territorial control. In the 1980s, the political party the Patriotic Union was formed, which had affiliations with the FARC: However, many of their members were killed by the conservative party. The FARC responded with an expansion of their military structure and began a full campaign against the government. They also became involved in a wide range of criminal economic activities, including extortion and kidnapping. According to the Israel Institute for Counter-Terrorism, kidnapping accounted for 65.8% of the FARC's total violent activities between 1980 and 2002 (Mendez 2012, p. 75). They began to extort rural landowners, plant bombs in the country's main cities and shoot state officials, policemen and politicians (Sanin 2007). They also began to recruit children.

Children were also used as soldiers at this time. Ximena Pachon (2012) extensive historical overview of children's involvement with conflict in Colombia shows how for over a century, the daily life of children unfolded amid widespread conflict where power and violence shaped their daily life-worlds. Some of the first reports of children involved with armed conflict in Colombia were from the Thousand Days' War. From a young age, children were already part of one of the two political parties in Colombia and in school would divide themselves into factions, making war their favourite game (Pachon 2012). The children were aged mostly between 10 and 17 years and performed roles as spies, informants and messengers and were

assistants to higher officers. They were also soldiers and in some cases were forcibly recruited or sent by their parents. Others went to seek revenge, and some were enticed by the thought of war and joined voluntarily (Pachon 2012). Children were valued because of their agility, quickness, compliance with orders as well as because of their fearlessness. One child said, ‘the big boss reached us and, watching the young soldiers that made up the Fifth Company told me, Major, how dare you bring these boys who are so small they are swallowed by their own pants to fight with men with hair on their chests’. A little soldier, saluting and hitting his rifle butt with the palm of his hand, observed, ‘yes general, our pants are too big on us, but we tie them tight’. ‘Bravo my little lad’, said the veteran, ‘I will make you official and spurred his mule’ (Pachon 2012, p. 3).

The Ejercito de Liberacion Nacional (ELN) also emerged at this time and is the second largest guerrilla group in Colombia. Inspired by the Cuban Revolution, they claimed to also want to construct a socialist government (Henderson 2015). The ELN is smaller than the FARC and has mostly been populated by peasants and university students. They primarily rely on kidnappings and extortion of protection money from landowners and large organisations such as oil companies as a central means of obtaining funds (Human Rights Watch 2003). The ELN has operated predominantly in the north of Colombia, particularly in Santander, Antioquia and Bolivar (Curtin et al. 2008).

Since the fieldwork for this book was conducted, the situation in Colombia has changed considerably. The Colombian government and the FARC came to a peace agreement after lengthy talks in Havana, Cuba. The FARC agreed to lay down their arms and come out of the jungle to rejoin the civilian world in return for a number of agreements which will be explored in greater depth in Chapter 6. They are now going through a demobilisation process where the many children coming out of the jungle will now go through one of the reintegration centres and enter into a civilian life. However, they are doing so in a context of ongoing violence. There have been reports of acts of unlawful killings, extortion and other abuses such as kidnapping, torture, human trafficking, bombings and use of landmines, restriction on freedom of movement, sexual violence, recruitment and use of child soldiers as well as the intimidation of journalists, women and human rights defenders by armed groups and drug traffickers (US State Department 2018). The Office of the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) documented the killings of 53 prominent rights advocates and community activists from January through October 2017.

The Foundation for a Free Press that monitors press freedoms reported that 1 journalist was killed and 136 suffered threats between January and October 2017 (Human Rights Watch 2019).

The end of the FARC marks a significant moment in Colombia's history and what will follow next in terms of the reintegration process of the FARC's many recruits will be significant for peace in Colombia. The many armed criminal gangs and drug traffickers that remain active throughout the country, however, continue to pose a threat to this process as they offer lucrative option to young recruits who have few skills and only know war and violence. All of which will be explored in greater depth in Chapter 6.

The ELN is still active, however, recently agreed to enter into peace talks with the Colombian government. In February 2017, the government and the ELN started peace talks in Quito, Ecuador, after more than two years of negotiations. In September, the parties agreed to hold a bilateral ceasefire between October 2017 and January 2018. The ELN also agreed to stop certain abuses, including recruiting children under 15 and using antipersonnel landmines (Human Rights Watch 2019). In May 2018, the peace talks were moved to Cuba, after Ecuador said that they would no longer host the talks (ICC 2018). Despite these moves towards peace, there have been reports of the ELN continuing to commit serious abuses against civilians, including, for example, killings, forced displacement and child recruitment and using antipersonnel landmines (Human Rights Watch 2019).

In Colombia, there are various factors that have contributed to high levels of voluntary recruitment into armed groups, which will be explored briefly here and in greater depth throughout the book. Of the reasons considered in the previous section, poverty and insecurity are some of the main causes of voluntary child recruitment in Colombia (Parra et al. 2012). Niousha Roshani (2014) found during her fieldwork in Colombia that social inequality and poverty were strong factors leading to child recruitment, particularly for those who were living in close proximity to the armed groups. Structural inequalities that have resulted from weak governance have led to high levels of poverty, violence and insecurity in all areas of social life throughout Colombia. The economic disparities have resulted in many of the country's rural and urban poor looking for alternative means of survival. Many have chosen to become involved in illegal economies such as drug trafficking or to join an armed group which has led to an increase in insecurity and criminality in everyday life. Roshani (2014, p. 17) spoke of how children told her that *el rebusque* or 'the hustling', the struggle to make money using any means available, both legal and illegal, is common.

She refers to a 17-year-old boy in Cali who stated, 'it is a matter of money and making it with what one has'. Many of her participants in Cali were or had been involved in some manner with one of the armed groups as a means for survival and financial income.

Social pressure, relationships and regular contact with armed groups can also entice young people into joining an armed group. The camaraderie of friendship groups may motivate a young person, or romantic attachments to soldiers may draw a young person into the conflict. In Colombia, some girls reported joining an armed group because they fell in love. One girl said, 'I made up my mind to go to a group because of him, I mean, I was so in love with him, if someone else had asked me to join the group, I wouldn't have gone' (Parra et al. 2012, p. 764). In Colombia, the mere presence of the armed groups operating around the homes of young people has also led many of them to make the choice to join an armed group. In much of the country, armed groups continue to exercise control, particularly in rural, mountainous or jungle regions where government influence has been weak or non-existent (Curtin et al. 2008). There have also been a number of campaigns conducted by the Colombian army as a way of attempting to engage children in educational and recreational activities to generate trust and establish a bond between the civilian population and the armed forces. Armed forces have also reportedly used schools as a base for operation against guerrillas, which has resulted in attacks from guerrilla groups and led to police flirting with girls or stealing food from the school canteen (Kemper et al. 2012, p. 29). Thus, the everyday regulation of life by the armed groups has played a significant role in socialising the population and normalising violent practices (Aguirre and Alvarez Correa 2001). In such contexts, it may seem normal for a young person to make the choice to join an armed group.

The youth bulge theory also has some legitimacy in relation to child recruitment into the armed conflict in Colombia. Youth unemployment is high, and for many young people, there are few opportunities due to the widespread poverty throughout the country. Violence has caused high rates of displacement where civilians, terrified of torture, selective assassinations, massacres and the destruction of farms have been forced to flee their homes (Nora-Christine 2012, p. 68). As a result, some 6.7 million people have been displaced inside Colombia since the beginning of the conflict, generating the world's second largest population of internally displaced persons (IDPs) after Syria, with an estimated 230,000 of them being children (UNICEF 2016). Some 35,000 people were displaced in 2016, a

significant drop from the more than 140,000 displaced in 2015 (Human Rights Watch 2017). The majority of the displaced have fled to Ecuador and Venezuela where an estimated 360,000 are living (Edwards and Gaynor 2016). Many Colombians are facing their second or third wave of displacement. Lisa Alfredson (2002) notes that countries with the greatest extent of child recruitment also tend to have large populations of IDPs. In Colombia, where there is a high number of children living in contexts of uncertainty, with few belongings and often no access to basic sanitation, clean water, health care and schools, joining an armed group may appear as an attractive option (Hristov 2009). In this way, poverty and structural inequalities have played a significant role in pushing children to join armed groups in Colombia.

There are a number of other factors that have played a role in children's decisions to become involved with armed groups in Colombia. Ideology has also played a significant role, once the children have joined the armed group. Initiation rites have not played a significant role in young people's decision to join armed groups, but, as I will argue in this book, joining an armed group provides children with a means of social becoming whereby young people can achieve the social roles expected of them in contexts of poverty where it is not possible otherwise. I also argue that children choose to participate in violence because they enjoy it or at least have a desire to own a gun or become a feared warlord which, as I will explore in this book, is linked to attaining social status. As stated above, this is one of the least explored reasons for children joining armed groups. Replicating social structures that existed in times of peace has not played a significant role in children becoming involved with armed groups, as all children in Colombia today have been born during the conflict, so there have been no structures from peaceful times to replicate.

However, perhaps one of the most defining factors that have brought children into armed groups has been the long-running nature of the Colombian conflict. The conflict has affected all aspects of society and as a consequence the reasons children join an armed group are deep-rooted, as are the factors that lead children to take on the identities of armed groups. During long-running conflicts such as that in Colombia, cultures and social processes become shaped by war and this has played a fundamental role in child recruitment, which is one of the less explored reasons. Already adapted to the presence and use of violence, for many of Colombia's children who have grown up in war-affected areas, entrance into an armed group is seen as relatively normal. In the case of Colombia, the conflict

should not be observed as a distinct period in which social processes are suspended, but rather as the primary backdrop for social existence (Lubkemann 2008). The factors that have led children to join armed groups in Colombia therefore require a special focus. By looking at warzones as sites of social reproduction rather than simply of social interruption, we can explore how social relationships emerge through conflict and how these draw children into conflict.

What is therefore needed to understand child recruitment is an analysis of the social and cultural environments child combatants come from and the way that meaning is threaded through those complex environments. We can then work towards understanding what the Israeli researcher Ben-Ari (2009, p. 9) refers to as ‘folk’ or ‘lay’ assumptions and images lying at the base of what people perceive as common-sense knowledge; the unquestioned knowledge that ‘everyone knows’ that shape children’s choices to join armed groups. This is what Geertz (1973) has termed the ‘of-courseness’ of common-sense understandings which serve as basic points of reference for ‘what we are’ and ‘what we are trying to do’ in the world. Thus, in order to know about the world in which we live, we must understand the specific bodies of knowledge that make up our worlds. We must understand how they define ‘how to be’ in the world and how they inform us about general rules of behaviour, boundaries and how we should conduct ourselves (Berger and Luckman 1966). Through an understanding of how these common-sense or lay understandings are understood in military and non-military environments, we can begin to understand what motivates children in specific contexts to join armed groups and what makes them stay there. This means understanding the lifeworlds within which children live.

CONCLUSION

The literature on children in war, which has largely been dominated by the humanitarian perspective, while extensive, is yet to delve deep into the very specific structural, cultural and social factors of specific environments that propel young people to become involved in war. By reducing children’s involvement in war to simply being a case of victimhood, the humanitarian perspective fails to consider the diversity of children’s experiences and motivations in wartime. Furthermore, it fails to explore *how* children attach to armed groups and build identities around the armed group. What is needed is a move away from homogenised understandings

of child recruitment and recognition of the culturally diverse environments in which child recruitment occurs. Anthropologists have a key role to play in the process. We need to develop greater understandings of the cultural, social, economic and political contexts in which children choose to join armed groups and the ways in which war affects the institutions, political structures, economy and communication systems in which children live. It is important to explore how aspects such as weapons, violence and, in the case of Colombia, narcotics shape warzones. In addition, we need to understand how politicians, military and armed groups negotiate war and how cultures where militarisation, violence and humanitarian aid have become the norm ultimately create an ethos of war (Nordstrom 1997). The ways in which war causes psychological and emotional harm and how it attacks the most fundamental conditions of sociality, social allegiances and trust are also crucial to understand (Boyden and de Berry 2004).

We essentially need to understand the lifeworlds of young people living in warzones. This requires listening to the voices of the children who are returning from conflict and allowing young children agency to express their perceptions and experiences and create understandings that are based on lived experiences rather than a theorised reality. By exploring the complex cultural nuances that run deeply through the social fabric of the very diverse environments in which children are recruited into armed groups, we can work towards understanding the specific factors that push children into joining armed groups throughout the world. This book intends to explore all of these issues through the case study of Colombia, and the following chapter describes the methods I used during my fieldwork and the challenges I encountered in researching ‘child soldiers’.

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CHAPTER 3

Entering the Field

INTRODUCTION

War is never a simple terrain to navigate. Rather, it is complicated, dangerous and filled with uncertainty. As Linda Green (1995, p. 131) writes, ‘chaos abounds in war and in fact may be one of its defining characteristics’. It plays itself out not just in the realm of extraordinary physical violence but also in the realm of symbols of the every day (Shepler 2014). Conducting fieldwork in such environments therefore comes with certain challenges and must be conducted with great care. Such was the case in Colombia. The long-running nature of the Colombian conflict has generated an intricate and complex web of social relations that are fraught with suspicion and fear. The result has been a conflict that is complex and difficult to understand. As Stathis Kalyvas (2003, p. 476) writes, ‘ambiguity is endemic to civil wars’. This is the case in Colombia. I commented on this to a participant in Florencia, Caqueta, a region bordering the Amazon jungle and one of the most dangerous areas for armed conflict. He replied: ‘you don’t understand the conflict, neither do we and we have been here our whole lives’. In this chapter, I explore the process of conducting fieldwork in Colombia and how I navigated the complex social environment. I will explain how I conducted fieldwork with children from the FARC and the ELN as well as numerous other actors, some of whom had been directly involved with the armed conflict. I also describe how I learned to navigate the intricate ways in which the conflict has infiltrated the daily lives of Colombians and

specifically, Colombia's children. I will outline some of the challenges I encountered and the strategies that I employed to manage them.

THE RESEARCH TERRAIN

Extreme geographical diversity has played a significant role in Colombian politics and in the conflict itself (Hylton 2006). Colombia is bordered to the north-west by Panama, to the east by Venezuela and Brazil, and Ecuador and Peru to the south. The Andes run as three corridors through the centre of the country while the Amazon jungle covers the south-east of the country and the Darian jungle in the north-west on the Panamanian border, all of which have become notorious for the presence of armed groups. Colombia also has two deserts, rich farmland, various bustling cities and two coastlines that span the north and west coasts. The south-east opens out onto a vast expanse of tropical lowlands that straddle the equator with a number of rivers coming out from the Orinoco and Amazon basins. Most of the centres of government authority have been built around the rough, rugged terrain or what Civico (2016) describes as 'hostile territory' making population settlement widely dispersed throughout the region. This has had tremendous implications for the spatial dimensions of the conflict.

Much of the conflict between the guerrilla groups, the government and the paramilitary groups has taken place in the countryside, largely due to its proximity to natural resources and fertile land for growing coca to produce cocaine (Curtin et al. 2010). The dense geographical landscape and rugged terrain have also allowed the armed groups to operate their covert activities without being detected. According to Richani (1997), if there is an epicentre, or flashpoint, of the creation of conflict in Colombia, it would be the tension surrounding the distribution of land since independence. Issues of land tenure have shaped Colombian history since the colonial era and continue to shape the nation's political economy today. Understanding the Colombian conflict thus requires an appreciation of the country's historical trajectory of agrarian change and the violence that has followed (Thomson 2011).

Beginning in the late 1970s and early 1980s, an emergent agrarian narco-bourgeoisie based in the cities of Medellín and Cali started to launder drug profits through the purchase of some of the best, most fertile properties in the countryside. As the massive amounts of money made from trafficking drugs lured many, violence over land in rural areas increased. This provoked tensions between drug traffickers, cattle ranchers and peasants,

leading to a long-term agrarian crisis which then resulted in the decline of subsistence agriculture. With many small farmers left with few other opportunities, they began to form alliances with the guerrilla groups to protect their interests, which led to further violence (Gill 2009). Since then the lucrative profits from the illegal drug trade and mining have become a primary means for the guerrilla groups to finance their military operations and control territory.

The violence from drug trafficking has also spilled into Colombia's neighbouring countries Ecuador and Venezuela, which has led to strained diplomatic relations (Kemper 2012). It has also led to strained relations with foreign companies working inside Colombia as they have become primary targets for extortion by armed groups. Energy firms in particular have been known to pay off whatever armed group holds power locally (Gray 2008). Thus, the conflict over land and resources has all led to an environment conducive to violence.

While the conflict has no specific ethnic dimensions, certain groups within Colombia have been disproportionately affected by the conflict. Choco, for example, a department in the north-west of Colombia and heavily populated by Afro-Colombians, has seen much violence. The many indigenous groups living in rural areas throughout the country have also been heavily affected by the armed conflict. The coastlines, in particular the Pacific coast, have also become sites of much violence (Amin et al. 2011). As Ulrich Oslender (2008, p. 79), who writes on violence in Colombia, says: 'in some places unprecedented levels of violence have begun to turn entire regions into landscapes of fear, radically breaking existing social relationships and life patterns'. This has made Afro-Colombians and the indigenous populations, who have a history of political, social and economic exclusion in the country, bear the brunt of the armed conflict. Living with the constant threat of massacres, tens of thousands of people have fled to the cities, while those who have stayed have been exposed and subjected to regimes of terror by the various armed actors (Oslender 2008). Those living in rural areas of Colombia and along the coastlines have had to bear some of the worst violence of the Colombian conflict.

The areas which have seen the least armed conflict have been the urban centres which are for the most part under the control of the government army. However, violence also exists in the cities and is mostly perpetrated by the numerous armed gangs or *bacrim*s that can be found throughout the cities, particularly in the poorer neighbourhoods. Social and economic inequalities are highly visible in Colombia's urban settings. The cities' neighbourhoods are organised by what are known as *stratas* with

the wealthy located in the highest *strata* and the poorest in the lower. The highest *stratas* pay more taxes and billing rates than those in the lower *stratas*. The wealthy areas have beautiful homes and well-manicured gardens, such as in Poblado in Medellin. There are large shopping malls as well as luxury restaurants and well-paved streets. The quality of everything looks better whether it is the houses, the roads, the shops or the clothing that the people wear in the street. The homes in the poor areas are made up of ramshackle buildings of red brick and tin with little cafes where men can often be found sipping beer early in the morning on plastic chairs. Cheap clothing is sold in little makeshift stores on the side of the road and motorbikes speed through the rough streets. Some of the *barrios* or neighbourhoods that are particularly notorious for violence are run by local criminal gangs who control areas that are defined by invisible borders. People are not allowed to cross unless they have special permission from one of the armed groups and violations of these rules can result in death (Human Rights Watch 2015). Thus in Colombia, strong regionalism and geographical fragmentation have all contributed to the production of violence throughout the country.

Given the importance of geography to the conflict and the differential experience of conflict, it produces the selection of field sites was crucial to my research. The spatial dynamics of conflict zones have had a significant impact on how individuals experience conflict. Oslender (2008) refers to the subjective and experiential dimensions of place and the ways in which both individuals' and groups' perceptions can be shaped through place. Using the terms 'geographies of terror' and 'landscapes of fear', he argues that in times of conflict and war, one's sense of place can be transformed and people begin to feel, think and talk in different ways as the places where they live become filled with traumatic experiences, memories and fear. Laban Hinton (2010) demonstrates how such forms of spatialisation took place in Cambodia, with the Khmer Rouge, who created different spatial zones between what they defined as failing cities and an enlightened countryside. Nadjé Al-Ali (2010) shows how the spatialisation of conflict can also take on a gendered element, as in the case of Iraqi women, whose movement has been increasingly restricted by insecurity and gender boundaries imposed by Islamist groups. Certain areas (such as marketplaces) and activities (such as driving or attending classes) are off-limits for Iraqi women unescorted by a male. Thus, space and spatial limitations can have a dramatic impact on the way in which one experiences conflict.

To this end, it was essential to choose field locations in areas of Colombia where I would be able to find individuals who had been affected by the conflict, and who would be able to reflect on children's experiences within it. The importance of this was illustrated by Marilly,¹ a young woman living in Bogota, who had grown up in the north of Colombia amongst the ELN and paramilitaries:

Johanna if you want to understand our conflict you have to speak to people who have lived it. The people here in the cities have no idea. They don't know what's going on like somebody who has grown up with the conflict. They criticise the FARC or the ELN or the paramilitaries really easily. People who have lived with the conflict will have a very specific perception, for them it's something normal because you live with it every day. There are many people who have lived with the conflict that don't realise that it is a problem.

Based on Marilly's advice I chose field sites based on how they had been affected by the conflict. Medellin was chosen as the first primary field site as it was where a demobilisation centre was located, discussed below, so I could work closely with former child combatants. Medellin also proved to be a useful location to learn about the nature of the violence within the cities. While the situation has considerably improved, Medellin was once considered one of the most violent cities in the world. Many of my participants from Medellin were therefore able to offer informative reflections on the nature of violence in Colombia and specifically on the nature of violence in the cities.

For the second phase of my research, I chose multiple field sites. Anthropologist Carolyn Nordstrom (1997, p. 10), who conducted fieldwork in conflict areas in both Mozambique and Sri Lanka, writes that an ethnography of a warzone should be a fluid process rather than one that is fixed to a specific location. This is necessary, as in conflict areas battle lines and situations can change and violence can, as Nordstrom states, 'distort reality, generate confusion, paralyze and misinform' (1997, p. 10). For this reason, research in dangerous fields should not be approached in a rigid or fixed manner but rather should be kept as elastic, incorporative and integrative to fit in with the shifting social complexities unique in conflict areas.

Nordstrom (1997) refers to 'runway anthropology', that is, conducting research in various sites of recent violence for short periods of time.

¹Throughout this book pseudonyms are used for my research participants.

She argues that when conducting fieldwork in sites wracked by violence, by staying in multiple field sites for shorter periods of time, the ethnographer has a greater chance of conducting fieldwork without the fear of raising suspicion amongst armed groups. The researcher also has the opportunity to gain a more holistic view of the conflict itself by exploring the various ways in which the conflict has affected the country. I chose to use Nordstrom's 'runway anthropology' as part of my methodology and as such, chose multiple research sites that had been affected by the conflict. By conducting fieldwork in such a way, I was able to gather diverse perspectives on children's involvement in the conflict as well as gain a deep understanding of the many complexities that have shaped the Colombian conflict.

The field sites that I chose for the second phase of the research included Apartado in the department of Uraba, Minca in Sierra Nevada, Popayan in Cauca, Santander de Quilichao in Cauca, Villavicencio in Meta and Neiva in Huila. I also travelled to Florencia in Caqueta, San Jose del Guaviare in Guaviare and Leticia, all of which are located in the Amazon region, and Buenaventura and Valle del Cauca. I spent three to four weeks in each of the locations. All of the field sites were in villages and cities that were under the control of the government, which meant that they were safe enough to carry out fieldwork as the risk of kidnapping or extortion was significantly less than in some other areas. Several field sites were chosen because I had contacts living in these areas, including some of the former guerrillas with whom I had worked in Medellin. Throughout the first stage of my research, I also made contact with a number of people throughout Colombia who put me in contact with others who provided valuable insights into my research. Villavicencio was chosen, for example, because there were two former hostages of the FARC living there who were key participants in my study. Neiva was also chosen as a field site because two former child combatants had returned home from the demobilisation centre in Medellin and had agreed to meet with me. Within all the field sites I was able to recruit a number of participants, all of whom were able to provide me with unique and varied insights into the dynamics of the Colombian conflict (Map 3.1).

ENTERING THE FIELD

As I have indicated, the research was conducted in two six-month phases during which I worked with two separate participant groups. The first phase was with the former child combatants of the FARC and the ELN in a



Map 3.1 Colombia Physiography Map. Washington, DC: Central Intelligence Agency: 2008. Accessed 19 April 2019

demobilisation centre in Medellin called Centro de Atencion Especializada or Specialised Attention Centre (CAE). The demobilisation centre was one of several projects for children in Medellin run by Ciudad Don Bosco, a church-based organisation run by Salesianos. The second phase was conducted in the above-mentioned field sites and the participants were general community members who ranged from university students to ex-hostages of the FARC. All of the fieldwork was conducted in Spanish so language proficiency was essential. I already had a working knowledge of Spanish before arriving in Colombia; however, I improved this with a month of intensive study before beginning the fieldwork. In CAE, I was given the formal role of volunteer and was allowed to conduct daily activities with the children along with other volunteers at Don Bosco. I was given signed consent to use my discussions and observations with the children in my research. The children were informed that I was a volunteer and also a researcher. I did not record any of my conversations with the children from CAE and instead wrote down field notes throughout the day and each evening. However, during the second phase of the research where I was able to meet several of the children who had left CAE, the interviews that I conducted with them were recorded. While a number of my participants gave permission for their names to be used, I have only used first names so that none of my participants are identifiable. The exceptions to this are public figures who are well known throughout Colombia where I have therefore used both names.

The former child combatants in CAE were primarily under the responsibility of Instituto de Bienestar Familiar (ICBF), or the Colombian Family Welfare Institute, but were cared for by the staff at CAE and Don Bosco. A multilevel network worked alongside CAE including the International Organization for Migration, the Human Rights Ombudsman and the Colombian Agency for Reintegration. I found CAE through the organisation Developing Minds, which is a Miami-based NGO in the United States that provided financial support to CAE and other activities. I gained informed consent for my research by Developing Minds as well as by Padre Rafael, the head of Don Bosco, who was in charge of all of the activities run at Don Bosco. The staff at CAE were all fully informed about my role as a researcher and they also gave permission for me to be at the centre.

Age was important not only for participation in the research, but also in terms of recruitment into the armed groups. To participate in the research, children under 18 years old required permission from the staff members of CAE and Don Bosco while those over 18 were free to give their own

consent. As explained in Chapter 1, there has been much discussion in recent humanitarian literature about the definition of a child. International criminal law makes the recruitment of children under 15 a war crime. However, the UN Convention on the rights of the Child (CRC) uses the term child to mean any person under the age of 18 and most human rights and children's advocacy groups use this definition (Rosen 2015). Colombian national law also establishes 18 as the minimum age for voluntary or compulsory recruitment into the armed forces (Kemper 2012, p. 16). The Colombian government ratified the CRC in 1991, and in 2005, it ratified the Optional Protocol on the involvement of children in armed conflict (Reed 2014, p. 5). Under Colombia's Victims Law and the Peace and Justice Law, children associated with the illegal armed forces who are under the age of 18 are considered victims and are therefore subject to different treatments when demobilising than somebody over 18, even if they were under 18 when they were recruited (Reed 2014, p. 9). In accordance with these definitions, I have chosen to refer to former combatants of the FARC who are under the age of 18 as children. The majority of the former combatants living in CAE were under the age of 18 at the time of the research.

ETHNOGRAPHY WITH FORMER CHILD COMBATANTS

As Jackson (1996, p. 8) reminds us, ethnography remains essential to anthropology, not only because ethnographic methods help generate knowledge about others but also because it brings us into direct contact with others, giving us opportunities to engage in an intersubjective process of sharing experiences and ideas. Ethnographic methods focus on fieldwork, first-hand participant observation, in-depth case studies and interviews that usually take place over a period of time during which the researcher establishes trust and understanding with participants. It involves ongoing interaction with participants and places a focus on different levels of individual and local meanings around specific processes and elements of daily life. Geertz (1973, p. 10) describes doing ethnography as like trying to read 'a manuscript, foreign, faded, incoherent and written with examples of human behavior'. For Nordstrom (2004), ethnography is the ability to follow a question, to be able to capture not only what is learned in a field site but also the smell, feel and taste of what those of a specific group share. It is a way of gaining a sense of what gives meaning to people's thoughts and lives and bringing to life a people and a place for those who

have not been there. Ethnography is, in a way, an intervention, a way to 'manufacture sense' about that which is being explored and to take the time to be immersed into the worlds of others and explore the 'realities' and constructs of 'knowledge' as understood by those who live within these realities (Nordstrom Ibid.). Ethnography is a means to show the invisible.

Ethnographic research offers one of the best means of conducting research in a conflict zone and gaining insights into child soldiering. As a method of inquiry, it is able to address the sensitive nature of doing research in conflict zones by allowing the necessary time that is needed to do research. It also allows for indirect methods to be used such as conversation and observation as a means of obtaining information. In conflict areas, where the movement of information may be sensitive and armed actors may be present at any time, such methods are essential. Furthermore, anthropological methods are better able to capture the diverse perspectives and meanings of children's experiences of armed conflict as the time allowed in anthropological enquiry allows sustained and meaningful relationships to be built. Boyden and de Berry (2004) have argued that research instruments such as questionnaires are extremely limited in their ability to capture the true nature of wartime experiences or the meanings for those who are affected by war. Instead, they argue that understandings of war are best shown through qualitative approaches. Through her fieldwork with children affected by war in Sierra Leone, Susan Shepler (2014) also found that she was the most successful in gaining insight into their lives when simply hanging out with the children and participating in their activities. Anthropologist David Rosen (2005), who has conducted extensive research on child soldiers in both Sierra Leone and Palestine, also points out that observing and listening to the voices of children in natural settings, where children are not disempowered by formal interviewing, provide the clearest description of children's experiences.

I took a similar approach to my research with the children at CAE. Most of my time was spent participating in daily activities with the children. These activities included teaching English, helping with their homework as well as offering computer and art classes. I began a mentor programme with Marc, an American contractor who was held hostage with the FARC for five and a half years, who participated in our activities via Skype from the United States. With one of the team's psychologists, we chose three boys and had weekly mentoring sessions with Marc. I also conducted a girls' club where I spent many hours drawing pictures, playing games and discussing our frustrations and difficulties in life, particularly those that centred on

boys. It was during these conversations where they began to share many of their perspectives and experiences with me. It was also during the many casual conversations with the children that we had at different moments around CAE that I began to learn about their lives.

LIVING IN MEDELLIN

Ciudad Don Bosco was my home for the six months I was in Medellín. Set up high on one of the mountains surrounding Medellín, Don Bosco was located in one of the *comunas* or neighbourhoods that have been the main theatres of violence in Medellín. CAE was just a 10-minute bus ride away from Don Bosco and each day I would take the bus that would hurtle down the winding streets between CAE and Don Bosco. At Don Bosco there were staff offices and a volunteer house where I lived in a small room, which was enclosed by bars, which I believe in part was for my security, to provide a barrier between myself and the volunteers and the 300 boys who were also living there. Besides the many projects Don Bosco ran with youth around the city, it operated an orphanage for marginalised youth from Medellín. Don Bosco offered dorm rooms, food and basic education classes to the boys who were mostly aged between 12 and 17 years old. The boys were from a mix of ethnic backgrounds and came from some of the poorest parts of Medellín. Most of the boys either did not have parents or had parents who could not afford to take care of them and came to Don Bosco as a means of survival and an alternative to becoming involved with the many armed gangs in the city who provided tempting offers of money and prestige to the city's many disenfranchised youth.

Violence in Medellín reached its height in the 1980s when Medellín's drug lords gained power by building support in the poorest neighbourhoods. After the fall of the Medellín cartel in 1992, power began to shift to smaller groups of criminal gangs who formed new territorial divisions in the barrios (Riano-Alcala 2006). Violence became a part of daily life in Medellín's poorest neighbourhoods, with death, bombs, crime and terror becoming the norm (Sanchez 2006). Death became a commodity and armed gangs regularly used assassins or *sicarios* to kill perceived enemies. Operating as private security networks throughout the poorer neighbourhoods, armed groups have sold themselves as security to whoever will pay. In these areas, the strongest prevails, which has often meant that state power and legitimacy in these areas has been diminished by armed groups (Sanchez 2006). The armed gangs have drawn invisible borders around

areas that they claim to be their own. Within these territories, they extort local businesses and run their drug trafficking routes. This was the case in Medellin and many cities throughout Colombia.

Children in vulnerable situations are often recruited into these gangs in the cities (Roshani 2014, p. 17). A large number of the victims of gang violence in Medellin have been young males from poorer social classes and between 1987 and 1990, more than 78% of victims in Medellin were youth between 15 and 24 years old and 8 out of 10 were male (Riano-Alcala 2006, p. 2). Violence has been the order of the day as gangs have vied for control. One can become a leader of a gang by showing an ability to perpetrate extreme violence, which could be as callous as shooting a random stranger on the street. One informant in Medellin explained how his friend had been blown up by a grenade in the centre of Medellin after being in the wrong place at the wrong time. Another informant said there was a time when nobody would stand on street corners out of fear that they could be the next victim of gang violence. High-profile politicians were targeted as were judges, ministers and political activists. Private justice and revenge became accepted as legitimate means of dealing with conflicts at any level or realm of society (Riano-Alcala 2006, p. 11).

Medellin became recognised as the most violent city in Colombia and in all of Latin America. While violence in Medellin has decreased in recent years, it is still certainly prevalent, particularly through the country's poverty-stricken areas. Similar observations of the neighbourhoods in Medellin were made by the boys in Don Bosco early in my fieldwork. While living at Don Bosco I spent many of my evenings with the boys discussing the dynamics of the violence in the cities. Each evening after dinner, I would sit outside the main dining hall where I would engage in discussions about their lives and life in the cities. It was during these conversations that I got some of my most interesting perspectives on the nature of urban violence. While the children at Don Bosco were not my primary research group, their insights into the nature of the violence in the cities were of great significance to my research as it was within these contexts that the children at CAE were demobilising.

THE SECOND PHASE

The second phase of the fieldwork was conducted over six months, when I left Medellin and travelled to the various field sites listed previously. I had numerous informal conversations with people during this second phase of

fieldwork. I spent time in family homes, in universities, and with displaced families, mothers whose children had been recruited into one of the guerrilla groups and teachers living in guerrilla-controlled areas. I spoke with coca pickers, lawyers and young people who had grown up in the areas held by the armed groups. I also spoke with several former hostages of the FARC who had been held in jungle prison camps for many years including police, politicians and an American contract worker. Considering the sensitive nature of the research, this approach allowed the participants to speak more freely and openly. I recruited the majority of my participants using snowball sampling, where friends or participants introduced me to others who they felt would be useful to my research. This method allowed me to recruit a number of participants I could ensure were safe to talk to, as they had been referred to me through somebody that I trusted. It also helped assure the participants that any information that they shared with me would be confidential. I also recruited participants by visiting local organisations and government offices working in the field of child recruitment in Colombia. For example, through an adult demobilisation centre in San Jose del Guaviare I was introduced to demobilised guerrilla by one of the staff members. I also kept in contact with a number of the former combatants from CAE through Facebook and travelled to meet with several of them in their homes after they left the centre. Away from the constraints of CAE, the children spoke much more openly of their experiences, as did many of the staff members from CAE with whom I also continued to keep in contact.

Much of the second phase of my fieldwork was spent sitting on back verandahs of ramshackle houses, in dark offices and in the privacy of my hotel rooms conducting interviews, often in stifling heat. Some of my most interesting insights of the Colombian conflict and how children become involved with it came from this phase of fieldwork as I was able to meet a diverse range of Colombians who had experienced all sides of the conflict. Their testimonies and perspectives gave me a range of understandings of the specific dynamics that had shaped the conflict and how these dynamics varied across the country. Most importantly, they allowed me an in-depth insight into why so many children had become involved with the conflict.

BUILDING TRUST

As mentioned briefly above, fieldwork in conflict zones requires time. As Mats Utas (2003) notes in his work with former combatants in Liberia,

to deeply understand the motives of youths who participate in civil wars, researchers need long-term personal contact with their research subjects. For young people who have grown up in an environment of severe adversity where cultures of fear and aggression dominate, learning to trust can be a difficult task, particularly when reflecting on the more personal aspects of their experiences. Spending time in the field with the former combatants was therefore essential. Jason Hart (2006), who has conducted extensive fieldwork with children in conflict zones, says that in such areas there is often suspicion, uncertainty and danger lurking and the identities of young ex-combatants often hang delicately in the balance. Ethnography is therefore ideally suited to such fieldwork as it provides the time to slowly immerse oneself, to build trust and become part of the lives of those who are being observed. Boyden (2004) highlights the difficulties of doing fieldwork with young people in conflict areas and speaks of Burma and Sri Lanka where building trust was essential in order to do fieldwork. I found as much to be true with the former child combatants at CAE. Many had difficult lives and had been let down more than once. Many had grown up amongst networks of suspicion and violence, and so building trust was necessary as I knew that before they would begin to share with me, they would need to trust me.

The children's lack of trust became evident numerous times throughout my fieldwork. For example, one afternoon I was sitting with Frieman, a 15-year-old boy at CAE who had grown up San Vicente de Caugan in Caqueta, previously one of the hotbeds for guerrilla activity and also the location of the *despe*, land given to the FARC by the Colombian government where they were allowed to operate autonomously. He explained that where he was from, no one thought anything of killing a little boy. When I asked him what he thought about this he shrugged his shoulders and said, '*no se*', (I don't know) and refused to say more. His refusal to speak more, I believe, was not because he did not know but rather because he was afraid of giving too much information, which in Colombia could have significant repercussions. Thus, when I first arrived at CAE I spent the first four months conducting activities and engaging in general discussion in order to build trust before beginning to ask any specific questions. As we shared stories I made an effort to ensure that I shared as much about myself as I asked them to share. It was during these moments of conversation in the garden or in their dorm rooms that they began to share parts of their lives with me. For example, one afternoon I sat down with Mariana and Daniela to write an essay about women in Colombia as part of our girls' club.

Mariana came from the south of Colombia, Cauca, a region that has seen heavy fighting in the conflict. She joined the FARC out of frustration with the lack of opportunities available to her. She identified with the FARC's ideology and felt that by joining the FARC she could fight against what she perceived to be the many injustices in Colombia and be able to improve her life opportunities. Daniela had decided to join the FARC as a means of escaping sexual abuse from her stepfather. As we started our conversation, both the girls started straight away to talk about abuse. Mariana started the conversation:

Many girls are abused by their families or someone who is close to their family, that's something very common in Colombia. Men will abuse newborn babies and there is no punishment for this. There would be more punishment for someone who killed an animal than there would be for sexually abusing a girl. (Former child guerrilla, age 16, Medellin)

Daniela then addressed her experiences:

We've known since we were very young that girls are trafficked into sexual slavery, it is something normal in Colombia. I was first sexually abused when I was 9. I was first raped by my cousin and then my stepfather tried to rape me. I decided to run away from home at this point and join the FARC, as a way of escaping the abuse. There are a lot of single mothers because there is so much sexual assault from fathers. Many women are forced to turn to prostitution as a way of providing for their kids, because the fathers are not around to help.

I asked her if this is something that she felt was normal and she told me '*oh siii, most of the girls here have been abused*'.

I believe that the girls opened up to me about their experiences of sexual abuse in this moment because after having spent several months together and having shared many conversations in our girls' club meetings where we often spoke about women's rights, they had begun to trust me. After several months in CAE, many of the boys also began to open up about their experiences in the armed group. They would describe the differences between types of military planes and types of weapons they would use in the armed group as well as what their roles were. They also began to speak of their families and it was in these moments that the children often became emotional. It became evident that in many cases, broken families were a key factor in their decisions to join an armed group. Many of the children also described home lives that were shaped by violence and told stories of

growing up in the countryside where armed groups were prevalent and where regular firefights would take place outside their homes. It was the time that I was able to spend with them, I believe, that made them comfortable to share these parts of their lives with me and gave me an insight into some of the factors that had shaped their lives before and after joining the armed group.

‘*ME QUEDO CALLADO*’, NAVIGATING THE SILENCES

Me quedo callado, I stay quiet. It was a phrase that I heard numerous times during my fieldwork in Colombia. Almost all of my participants explained that their way of managing the violence in Colombia was just to stay quiet. The phrase is illustrative of how deeply the violence has entered the social fabric of Colombia and has frayed social relations. Conducting research in Colombia therefore came with a number of challenges, the largest being that armed groups were still active throughout the country. This meant that there was a great unwillingness to speak about matters related to the conflict or any of the armed actors, largely out of fear. In Colombia, giving information to the wrong person or even being suspected of giving information to a perceived enemy can have very serious ramifications, which often include death. The fear largely came from not knowing who was part of an armed group and who was not. There is a very large and complex system of informers for the various armed groups operating throughout the country.

Stathis Kalyvas (2006) notes that in conflict situations armed groups often form alliances with local civilians in order to obtain information, which can give civilians power to advance their personal agenda such as jealousy or revenge. Armed groups may also pay for information about wealthy neighbours who can then be extorted or kidnapped. This creates a high level of fear amongst the civilian population as one does not know who is an informer and who is not. In such environments, social relations can become strained as people worry not just for themselves, but for the safety of their families as well. Jackson (2002) describes the dangers of violence as being intersubjective, as the violence does not just affect individuals but affects the fields of interrelationships that constitute lifeworlds. In such contexts, fear for the safety of one’s family and friends may be more damaging than an attack against oneself. One may choose to employ silence as a means of survival, as speaking may be a matter of life and death for one’s self and one’s family. In this way, silence becomes a language of war.

Jason Hart (2006) writes about similar difficulties of conducting fieldwork with children in conflict areas in Burma. The widespread violence and forced recruitment of children by the various armed groups made the possibilities of conducting fieldwork extremely limited as many were too afraid to speak. Cordula Strocka (2008) who conducted fieldwork in Peru in areas where the most violent fighting took place between the Sendero Luminoso or the Shining Path and the government describes the difficulties of conducting research where suspicion is linked to memories of violence. The memory of what would happen to informants often made individuals silent, too terrified to speak.

Throughout Colombia, I noticed that there was a general unwillingness or at least a sense of caution amongst many Colombians to speak about the armed groups. This was especially notable amongst those who had directly been involved with or affected by the armed conflict. I would be able to tell who had directly been affected by the armed conflict and who had not simply by their willingness to talk about it and the manner in which they chose to do so. Often, people from the richer parts of the cities, who were distanced from the conflict, would speak openly about their opinions on the armed conflict, perhaps because they were less afraid of repercussions. People who had been directly affected, or who were living in areas where the conflict had taken place, were much more discrete. I learned early in my fieldwork that particularly in the countryside where much of the armed conflict had taken place, speaking out loud about the armed groups was taboo. It was necessary to use code words when discussing armed groups. For example, participants in the countryside used terms like ‘the people from the mountains’, or ‘the friends’, as they were too frightened to utter the term FARC. This influenced with whom I spoke and when I spoke to them, particularly in the case of participants who had directly been affected by the conflict.

The silences and unwillingness to talk affected my fieldwork in a number of ways, as fear often made participants unwilling to share information or at least wary of sharing too much. While this did at least initially pose a challenge with finding participants who were willing to speak with me, I came to learn that the silence I was encountering was in fact meaningful. There was much that was being said in the silences even if it was not heard. Antonio Gramsci et al. (1971) observed through his work in Italy in the early twentieth century that as sociopolitical violence became deeply embedded within social institutions, silences and secrecy would often speak more powerfully than words. The fear of repercussions or reprisals from those who wield the

guns would often render silent those living in such situations. This silence was what Taussig (1992) refers to in his work on violence in Latin America as ‘public secrets’: that which everyone knows but does not dare speak of publicly. I became aware throughout my fieldwork that there were many ‘public secrets’ in Colombia. There was much that seemed to be collectively understood by those around me but was not spoken about. These ‘public secrets’ were extremely important because they spoke of power structures that were dictated by violence and those who were in control of the violence. It became a central goal of my fieldwork to discern what these ‘public secrets’ were, as they influenced daily life in Colombia and how children were drawn into armed groups.

As I came to learn, the reluctance to speak about certain issues related to the conflict spoke volumes about the nature of violence in Colombia and how it had affected lifeworlds. In this context, silence was almost like a language in itself, one that needed to be learnt in order to conduct fieldwork. Silence has become part of the metalanguage, the unconscious way of communicating with others in Colombia. Silence communicates a passive compliance, a submission to the will of the present armed group by not speaking or informing. Silence in Colombia is largely the non-sharing of information. It is the guarding of what one knows and an agreement to not inform on those who have the guns. Silence in this context is extremely meaningful. I thus came to learn early on in my fieldwork that knowing what not to know, or at least appearing to not know, was a large component of social knowledge in Colombia and the fieldwork would need to be adapted around this knowledge.

LIMITATIONS

As mentioned at the beginning of this chapter, entering into the war world required acceptance. Utas (2003, p. 52) discusses the politics of inclusion during his fieldwork with former child soldiers in Liberia, saying: ‘entering the field for the first time, getting in or gaining acceptance is generally a delicate business. Researchers tend often to see inclusion as a permanent state one can reach’. However, Utas sees the promise of inclusion as continually threatened by the possibility of exclusion. In conflict settings, the legitimacy of the researcher could be contested for any number of reasons on a day-to-day basis. Utas’ observations were similar to my own. One such challenge was gaining acceptance from the staff at CAE. While the other volunteers and I were able to conduct activities with the children,

they were reluctant to allow us to ask questions about the children's lives in the armed groups or to know some aspects of what was happening in CAE. I felt the lurking sense of exclusion.

I suspected that this exclusion was because there was information that the staff at CAE were guarding and did not want us to know. This may have been for several reasons but was most likely because the staff were trying to protect the children. One of the key goals of the staff at CAE was to discourage the children from thinking about their past lives with the guerrillas and encourage them to move towards a non-violent future. As already discussed, the sharing of information in Colombia came with the danger of great consequences. As there were a number of children at CAE who could be killed by the guerrillas if caught, it was essential that the identities of the children be kept confidential. The staff at CAE had little control over whom I spoke to outside CAE and so it was likely they were concerned about with whom I was sharing information. By limiting the dissemination of information on the identities of the children, they could be better protected.

The pressures on the staff were no doubt great. Although not discussed with me or the other volunteers, I also believe there was a certain amount of fear amongst the staff for their own safety. The fear generated by the FARC has permeated the country and the staff at CAE were not immune. Indeed, one of the staff members, Rosalba, indicated during our many discussions that she felt afraid. She had grown up in Cauca, a region of Colombia heavily affected by the conflict, and some of her family members had been personally affected by the violence. One afternoon after a fight broke out between a group of the boys, Rosalba pulled me aside and warned me that I should not come to CAE while no staff were present, as there would be nobody to protect me if a fight broke out again. Her fear was obviously related to the fact that the boys fighting were former members of the FARC. Thus, the sense of exclusion that I experienced at CAE was likely related to protecting the children's reintegration, their safety and my own.

While the limitations on what I could directly ask about were most likely in part due to the concern of staff for the well-being of the children, it created barriers between the children and me. How would I be able to learn about the children's lives in the armed groups when I was not allowed to speak to them about these experiences? Although I was limited in some of the information that I was able to attain, at least while I was at CAE, some of the children voluntarily offered information about their

experiences, without any prompting from me. My time at the reintegration centre therefore gave me a strong understanding of the role of children in Colombia's conflict and how children become involved in armed groups as well as the nature of violence in Colombia. It also allowed me to be in contact with former child guerrillas, many of whom I have stayed in contact with since leaving the field. I eventually left the reintegration house after six months to travel through Colombia for the second phase of the research.

During the second phase of my fieldwork, I was able to meet with a number of the children and staff from CAE. I kept in contact with many of them on Facebook and while it was a challenge to find many of them, I was able to meet with several of them in various parts of Colombia after they left CAE. Free from the constraints of CAE, they were much more open and able to speak during these encounters. In some cases, they took me to meet their families and showed me their homes where they grew up, though these experiences were limited. Most of the children asked to meet me outside of their homes in cafes or in parks and it was in these moments that they opened up much more about their lives before they had gone to the reintegration centre. I have continued to stay in contact with many of the children and we regularly share conversations where they update me on their lives and their perceptions of the peace process as it currently unfolds in Colombia. I was also able to meet with some of the staff outside the reintegration centre. We met in cafes and I found that they also spoke far more openly than they ever did while at CAE. Thus, while the limitations proved to be a great challenge, they also proved to enable considerable insight, allowing me to see, from a distance, some of the great challenges facing those who are trying to navigate the very treacherous waters of the Colombian conflict.

SEXUAL HARASSMENT

One of the most significant challenges that arose during my fieldwork was the culture of machismo and prevalence of sexual harassment in Colombia. Machismo, as it was commonly referred to by my participants, is a cultural system that is widespread throughout Latin America in which women are considered inferior, designated to work in the home and are expected to be submissive to men. Mendez (2012, p. 60) describes machismo in Colombia as 'a popular term that makes reference to Latin American masculinity that is constructed based on an image of a male who is caring, responsible and strong

but also emotionally insensitive and promiscuous'. Within this cultural framework, men are expected to demonstrate a number of attributes such as pride, courage and responsibility as well as negative aspects such as aggression, power and control over women to reinforce their masculinity. Male participants frequently explained that women are just considered sexual objects in Colombia and the entitled behaviour of the large majority of the men I encountered in public spaces in Colombia reflected this view. Take the following conversation with Gustavo for example:

Gustavo: Some years ago Colombia was very machista, now women are saying that they are the same, there are women in high positions, in the government. It's good because we are learning, slowly the mind is changing.

The older people think that a woman is less than a man. You think this because your father thought that, your grandfather thought that.

Johanna: What do women think about that?

Gustavo: Well the opinion is divided, there are women who think that it's bad but there are also women who agree. Colombia is a very Catholic country and the Bible says this and so because women are afraid of God they think that they have to think this. But people's minds are changing because of the internet, you read many different opinions and so you realise that this is wrong. The internet is helping a lot. (Computer engineer, age 30, Cali)

Diana, a teacher who grew up near Villavicencio but is now living in Bogota, explained that the machismo in Colombia causes many problems for women. She said there are many cases of men controlling women in relationships and women being killed because of a jealous husband. 'Men think of women as being possessions', she said. 'Some women still think it's normal for men to beat them or to cause psychological harm'. Sexual violence is also a problem and women are often blamed for sexual violence committed against them:

Women who are assaulted don't talk because they will feel embarrassed or ashamed. It is so sad that you have to feel scared walking down the street because someone might harm you. It's exhausting. (Teacher, age 32, Bogota)

One of the consequences of such attitudes is the belief that women can be publically treated as sexual objects and that it is acceptable to sexually harass women. Mendez (2012) notes that acts of domination over women

largely take place in public spaces because it is there that men can publically demonstrate their domination over women. Meger (2016, p. 19) also argues that sexual violence is an effective instrument to assert the perpetrator's dominance and masculine power. By treating women as merely 'sexual objects' in public places, men are able to sustain a gender hegemony which is a manifestation of the larger patriarchal system in which men dominate women (Thomas and Kitzinger 1997). In this way, sexual harassment is a social control mechanism that reasserts and recreates masculine dominance over women (Kloss 2016). It is largely an expression of male power that is designed to control women's behaviour.

Sexual harassment was a regular occurrence throughout my fieldwork and made it a highly uncomfortable experience. My physical appearance drew attention everywhere I went. I looked very different from the other women and girls in Colombia, tall with blonde hair and green eyes, which attracted unwanted attention. When in the street in Colombia during both the first and second phase of my fieldwork, I faced persistent leering and disparaging remarks. During the first phase, leaving my room at Don Bosco was difficult and uncomfortable as sexual harassment was also pervasive there. The boys there had clearly observed the expressions of hegemonic masculinity prevalent in Colombian society, as moving throughout the compound I was met daily with aggressive stares and lewd comments. At times I felt reluctant to leave my room, as I knew wherever I wanted to go was likely to be an uncomfortable journey. On several occasions, the harassment became physical and I was grabbed inappropriately by one of the boys in Don Bosco. On one occasion, I was talking to a group of young boys. One of them grabbed me and as I spun around and demanded to know who it was, everyone remained silent. The next day, a young boy approached me and asked me if I had found out who it was. I felt embarrassed as I realised that the boys must have been discussing the incident and I felt the effects of the imbalanced power structures that such behaviours bring. I regularly made complaints to directors at Don Bosco and while they listened, they took no action. It seemed that sexual harassment was simply something that I was expected to tolerate. On one occasion, one of the educators, the young men who were in charge of the boys, said, 'what do you expect?' after I complained about the harassment. It was regularly explained to me by the male educators that because I was blonde, I therefore should expect to be harassed. Undoubtedly, the entitlement that the boys felt to harass me, which seemed to be shared by the older male

educators, was part of the wider system of machismo in Colombia in which I, as a female researcher, was expected to endure.

At Don Bosco, without support from the staff, my tactic for dealing with the harassment was to ignore the perpetrators. If they made sexual innuendos or lewd comments, I would try to swallow the discomfort and walk away. However, this occurred almost every day and throughout the day, I began to feel as if, at least in Don Bosco, I would have to ignore the boys completely. This then presented another problem for me as I was then accused of being *creada* or 'stuck up'. I also realised that they probably assumed that I considered myself better than them. Coming from a 'developed' country, the unspoken global hierarchies that dictate value depending on race were at play. I wondered if this added to my position and made me more of a target than the Colombian women. My experience in Colombia was largely informed by what I represented to them by being blonde, white, Western and female.

Sexual harassment has been a problem for a number of female researchers. Henrike Donner (2012), for example, noted that sexual harassment was a regular occurrence that affected her fieldwork in India. She found it difficult to recruit female research assistants, as women were concerned about travelling on public transport or interacting with unknown men. The sexism and machismo in Colombia inhibited my research in similar ways. It made me wary of whom I spoke to as I was aware that speaking with men could be potentially uncomfortable or even dangerous. I was also aware that they could misunderstand my interest in speaking with them and assume that I had some sexual interest in them. I was therefore limited in how I was able to recruit participants and from where I could recruit them. A male Dutch journalist explained that he spent time in local eateries to gain information, but I was very aware that this was something that I simply could not do. Many of the local eateries were filled only with men so this would most likely have meant uncomfortable staring and unwanted advances. There was a high chance that any attempt to speak with these men would have been taken the wrong way so it was a situation that I preferred to avoid. These issues can create gaps in information around the lived experience of women and girls in war and lead to an over-representation of male perspectives. It also has very serious ramifications for the safety and well-being of female researchers.

However, while uncomfortable, my experiences of sexual harassment did provide insight into the nature of gender relations in Colombia and some of the very difficult realities that women and girls face. These attitudes and the

resulting behaviour reflect greatly on the way in which women are viewed in Colombia. The boys at Don Bosco were obviously aware that as males they were entitled to express their domination over women in public spaces through acts of communal humiliation that were intended to display women's subordinate role. They were aware, as Meger (2016) describes, that by sexually harassing me, they were feminising me as a victim with the wider audience and the other boys at Don Bosco, were intended for the spectacle. By harassing women, they were not only reinforcing their dominance as males but were also denying the women authority, by demonstrating to all those who inhabit that space, that it is acceptable to denigrate women and represent them as inferior (Kloss 2016). So while there were greater structural issues at play, it was clear throughout my fieldwork that entitled and sexually predatory behaviour by males was broadly acceptable throughout Colombia.

By being subject to this degrading treatment, I was in essence living what would have shaped many, if not all, of Colombian women's experiences. As shown in the above narratives with Mariana and Daniela, sexual violence is a pervasive part of the lives of women and girls in Colombia and joining an armed group was a way of escaping abuse in the home. While there have been reports of machismo and sexual abuse within the FARC, all of the ex-combatants with whom I worked denied that sexual violence was a problem inside the FARC and said that gender equality was part of the FARC's ideology. So the pervasive levels of violence and discrimination permitted against women and girls push many women to seek protection that they do not receive from their communities or their government. The sexual harassment I experienced was therefore part of a larger system where the objectification and degrading treatment of women and girls are permitted culturally. The constraints placed on women and girls by this culture of machismo cause great harm in Colombia and affect the lives of women and girls in a multitude of ways and, ultimately, play a significant role in pushing girls to join armed groups.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter, I have highlighted some of the complexities specific to conducting fieldwork in Colombia. I have outlined the key themes that emerged through my fieldwork as well as some of the challenges that I encountered. I have shown how I sought to overcome these challenges as I navigated the country's vast geographical terrain and negotiated spaces

of violence. Through these challenges, I was able to gain unique insights into the lives of the children who had been in armed groups. Some of these included learning about how violence has shaped power structures as well as the importance of understanding the meaning of silence. I lived the unequal gender relations in Colombia including public displays of machismo and aggression, which gave me a significant insight into the lives of women and girls in Colombia. I learned how conflict penetrates families, in some cases breaking them apart and in other contexts, giving freedom to those escaping abuse by joining armed groups. I learned how violence had shaped the lives of former combatants of the FARC. Thus, it was through the six months I worked closely with former child combatants, living in close proximity to the boys of Don Bosco, and the many informal conversations with Colombians affected in one way or another by the conflict throughout the second phase of my fieldwork that the complexities of armed conflict were brought to light.

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CHAPTER 4

The Lifeworld

INTRODUCTION

As individuals, we all live within lifeworlds: within social spheres that influence our understandings of the world and the ways in which we see ourselves. These worlds direct us, they motivate us and they inform us. They are made up of a number of factors that exist within our environments that are often unquestioned, shaping our sense of reality. Essentially, it is through our engagement with the lifeworlds in which we live that we come to an understanding about what exists within the world and how it is meaningful. Through understanding our lifeworlds, we learn about morals and values and what we should and should not do. They inform our behaviour, the choices that we make and how we can achieve social worth. It is through these lifeworlds that we begin to understand who we are. By understanding the basic structures of lifeworlds and how they are made meaningful to those who live within them, we can begin to understand how young people are militarised, how children are led into armed groups, why they choose to join them, why they stay in them even when forced into the group and how their identities are formed while they are in them. This chapter will be an exploration of the concept of lifeworlds, how they are formed and how individual identity is derived through one's lifeworlds. In this chapter, I will also show how the first processes of militarisation begin, which I argue is in the children's homes. By drawing on a number of narratives from former child soldiers aged between 14 and 18 years old, I will also

show in this chapter how their experiences of violence in their home lives led to a worldview conducive to joining an armed group and consequently initiating the beginning of the process of militarisation in Colombia.

LIFEWORLDS IN COLOMBIA

One morning I sat with some of the boys from CAE looking at my photos from different parts of the world. As we browsed through my albums, they were especially interested in the pictures of the jungles that I had visited. Much of their guerrilla life had been spent traversing Colombia's jungles and so the images of dark, dense trees and winding rivers appealed to them. After having already spent several months with these young people, I had become aware that for them, much of the world as they knew it was full of bombs, bullets and armed groups. Many of them had grown up in homes where there was a prevalence of violence both inside and outside their homes. Their time in the armed group had also been filled with violence and then the reintegration house in Medellin was located in an area where criminal gangs and violence were commonplace. There had been little in these children's lives to teach them that violence was not the norm.

As one of the goals of the reintegration process was to help the children learn that violence was not normal, I was attempting to teach the boys that there was more in the world than just war. I had been showing them the small globe I had bought for them and was telling them about the many different cultures around the world in an attempt to teach them that there were places in the world where violence was not the norm. One of the boys, Julio, who had spent a number of years with the Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (FARC), picked up the globe and spun it around. He stopped it suddenly with interest and pointed at Russia. 'A lot of guns come from there', he explained, 'that's where the FARC buys them'. Indeed, in the late 1990s the Russians brought weapons in their thousands for the FARC and in return the Russians were given planes loaded with cocaine (Hesterman 2013, p. 86). After having already spent considerable time with Julio, who was only 16 years old, I was aware that he knew little about the world beyond Colombia, yet this conversation illustrated that he had an awareness of the FARC's transnational relations that enabled the movement of weaponry and drugs.

Yahir, another former child combatant with the FARC, sat at the table with us. Yahir claimed to have been born in the FARC in the north of the country, where he spent most of his time with the guerrilla. Typically it is

not allowed for FARC members to have children however he explained that as his father was a commander he was able to have a child. He asked me to look for his home on the interactive map on my computer, which was one of the favourite activities of the youth at CAE. As we found his home, he pointed to an area nearby and said, 'there are a lot of paramilitary in that area. There was a big massacre there by the paramilitary'. He then asked me to search for pictures on the Internet about the massacre, and I found a gruesome selection of photos with people lying on the ground, massacred. 'This is horrible', I said to the boys, slightly shocked. They all just looked at me and stayed silent, not showing any evident emotion. I asked them why the paramilitaries did this and the boys shrugged their shoulders. 'Because they felt like it', one of the boys replied. My conversation with the boys that afternoon was telling about the lives of these children. For Julio, an exploration of the global map elicited images of guns and warfare. The first thing he thought of when he saw Russia was the arms trade. Home, for Yahir, signified massacres by paramilitary groups and death. From my conversations with these young boys and the other child combatants, it certainly seemed that the worlds in which they had lived had largely been shaped by violence. Guns, bombs and warfare had been the norm in their everyday world for their entire lives.

Another conversation with a young boy at CAE was similar. We were doing puzzles and as we struggled together to make all the pieces fit, James started to talk about war and the guerrillas.

There's conflict in every country in the world, he stated.

He proceeded to explain that the whole world was at war and refused to believe any suggestion that this was not the case. He continued,

Foreigners can't go to my hometown because if they do, then the guerrillas will kill them. Gringos kill a lot of Colombians so it's okay for the guerrillas to kill them.

He smiled as he said this and then looked at me. He was undeterred and refused to listen to my suggestions that there were indeed many *gringos* or foreigners around the world that were not killing Colombians. He refused to believe what I was saying and continued to argue. The educator sitting at the table with us shrugged her shoulders and told me to leave him; 'he was lost in the violence'. For her, it seemed that the violence had already

done significant damage. Most of the children that I worked with at CAE described a world filled with such violence. They described their homes with tales of poverty, bullets and armed combatants that were often narrated with a casual shrug of the shoulders. Paul, one of the boys at CAE, explained one afternoon during a conversation in the garden how people would not even look up from what they were doing when fighting broke out amongst the armed groups and bullets whizzed by. He too expressed shock when I told him there was no war in Australia; it seemed that the concept of a country not being at war had never occurred to him. To what extent these young people enjoyed violence or felt that it was a necessary component in their lives is difficult to discern, but what was certain was that violence was part of their lifeworld.

However, beyond CAE, not all my participants believed that the entire world was at war. Some had not joined an armed group and had instead become university students or taken up a professional career. When I asked them why they had not gone into the mountains to join the revolutionary fight with the guerrillas, almost everyone I spoke to laughed as if it was a ridiculous idea. They would often make a comment along the lines of, 'well I had other opportunities'. They spoke of strong connections with their families and of the guerrillas as being 'bad' people. They associated the children who joined the guerrillas as coming from places far out in the Colombian countryside, where there was no government presence, high levels of poverty and no other opportunity other than to become involved with war and violence. They described the children who joined the armed groups as an 'other'; people who were clearly different from them. For example, when I asked Perly, a young teacher who grew up in the city of Neiva, Huila, why she had not joined the guerrillas she laughed and said:

Oh god. For some strange miracle. I guess if I had been born in the mountains I would probably be a guerrilla. I guess they don't have anything else to choose from. I can't judge them. If they don't have anything else to do. I had plenty of choices, I went to university, I had a good score on my test so I could choose anything. But if I had been born in the mountains then probably I would be one of them.

Emmanuel, a 21-year-old student who grew up in one of the poorest areas of Cali, also linked the recruitment of young people into armed groups to the social and economic environment in which they had grown up:

It's a big problem because they are children who haven't had very many opportunities. I imagine that they enter into these groups because it's the only option for them. In the countryside of Colombia the presence of the state is very weak, there aren't very many opportunities. I think it's just about luck. The people who were born with opportunities, who had options. They could plan and make other decisions. If I was born in the countryside, I don't know where I would be.

Pamela, who grew up in a small town in the countryside of Cauca, also explained why she chose not to join an armed group. She said that she had not been directly affected by the conflict with the guerrilla yet they had been present within the region that she was living:

Because of the way I grew up. Everyone in my family has studied, everyone has been to university. The way I grew up there were other options. I feel like here in the city there's no understanding of the war, it's almost as if the war isn't happening. Everything seems normal, there are luxuries, everything that you need. It's almost as if the war doesn't exist here. You see it happening on television but you feel as if it is something that is happening really far away. We can't see it.

It was evident from comparing the testimonies of young people who joined armed groups and those who had not, that there were distinct factors that influenced their life choices. Diego, a psychologist with whom I worked at CAE, noted this during a conversation one afternoon. He explained that there were two different 'worlds' in Colombia. He described one as having been heavily affected by war and violence, and the other as far less violent. What Diego was referring to was the spatialisation of the conflict in Colombia as briefly described in Chapter 2. The conflict with the armed groups has primarily taken place in the countryside where the dense jungle and mountainous regions have given the armed groups plenty of space to operate undetected. The presence of the guerrillas in addition to the high prevalence of poverty and inequality in the countryside has led to a higher prevalence of violence in these areas than in the urban centres. While the urban centres have certainly seen their share of violence and poverty, they are also where the upper classes typically live and therefore have relatively different social dynamics from the countryside. It is within these spatial zones that the two distinct worlds Diego was referring to have emerged: the world of violence and the other as the world of relative non-violence.

The concept of lifeworlds is therefore particularly relevant to understanding how children have been militarised in Colombia. Ben Mergelsberg (2005, p. 12), who conducted fieldwork at an IDP camp in Pabbo,

northern Uganda, also noted that similar forms of spatialisation played a role in how children were militarised into armed groups. He found that children who were abducted by the Lord's Resistance Army (LRA) from the Acholi ethnic group would talk in Acholi about two worlds. His informants referred to *kit kwo ma ilum* and *kit kwo ma gang*: the world in the bush and the world at home. He identified the new abductee's life with the LRA as a process, characterised by two main influences: 'growing in and growing out' (ibid.). The abductees could either separate from the community in the bush where their homes are located by and resist the order, or try to survive the horror of being in the rebel group by identifying with the LRA and the world in the bush. Most children accepted the order out of fear and learnt to live within the group. Mergelsberg found that the children differentiated between the worlds of the LRA and home by the different rules and regulations within each. The boundaries seemed significant in how the children differentiated between the two. He found that this concept of 'worlds' was identified by the very distinct process of adaptation in both becoming a soldier and becoming a child again after their return home (Mergelsberg 2005, p. 25).

This thesis therefore focuses on the premise that there are two broad collective 'worlds' within Colombia, as Diego and many of my other participants defined them: the world of violence and the world of non-violence. I argue that it is primarily in this 'world of violence' that the recruitment of children into the armed groups has taken place in Colombia. By understanding the lifeworlds that children come from and the lifeworlds of the FARC and how they transition between them, we can begin to understand how processes of militarisation operate. So how are these lifeworlds formed? How does a child living within the world of violence become pushed into joining an armed group while a child living in the world of non-violence does not? After discussing lifeworlds theory, I will draw on a number of narratives from former child soldiers to show how their experiences of violence initiate the militarisation process and lead them to become involved with armed groups.

THE LIFEWORLD, THE SUBJECTIVE AND THE SOCIAL

As mentioned in the introduction of the book, lifeworlds theory has its roots in the work of Edmund Husserl (1982). The Husserlian perspective of the lifeworld links consciousness and meaning to the lifeworld and argues that it is where the ground is laid for shared understandings of a spe-

cific social context. Husserl explains that the lifeworld is a variety of objects, which could include both physical and non-physical aspects such as clothing and housing as well as concepts around gender, legitimacy and communication. These are typically arranged within a specific social environment by a group of individuals and form the basis for all shared experiences. Husserl recognised that even at its deepest level, consciousness is already embedded in a world of meanings and understandings that are socially, culturally and historically situated. Husserl argued that the lifeworld is pre-reflective; it is what we understand without conscious reflection. Consciousness here is defined as an experience which is subjective, an awareness of oneself and the ability to experience feeling and wakefulness (Ventegodt 2011). To be conscious is to experience something or to have attention or an awareness of one's own mental state (Gennaro 2017). The lifeworld, according to Husserl, is therefore the world of lived experience as inhabited by conscious beings; it is the way in which phenomena appear in our conscious experience or everyday life. We essentially embody that which is in our worlds and that which is shared with others. His approach was largely phenomenological and posits that it is through this collective intersubjective way of perceiving what is around us, that we arrive at what is perceived to be the objective truth, or at least as close as possible.

In what follows, I have not placed a significant focus on critiques of the theory for several reasons. The first is that the theory itself has not faced significant criticism, at least of the early theorists such as Husserl. Further, as lifeworlds as a theory are complex and far ranging and have been used in a number of different fields including psychology, sociology and business, the critiques that have emerged are not relevant to the specific aspects of lifeworlds theory that I have chosen to use. For this reason, I have placed a greater focus on showing how the theory has developed with each emerging theorist, and how it is related to other approaches in phenomenology, some of which emerged long before Husserl's theory was developed.

Martin Heidegger (1962) was the first to develop an alternative to Husserl's original concept of phenomenology. For Heidegger, we are as human beings inseparable from the world in which we live and exist. However, rather than focusing on how we know what we know, as Husserl did, Heidegger was more interested in exploring what it meant to live in a world subjectively. Heidegger saw our experience in the world as being always situated within a specific context and that in order to understand a person's specific reality, we need to understand the specific factors that have shaped his or her experiences such as language, history and culture. Heidegger's

work inspired the work of Maurice Merleau-Ponty (1964) who also argued that humans are embodied beings and the self and the body cannot be separated. Merleau-Ponty's approach was also phenomenological, but he placed a greater focus on the role of sensation in acquiring identity and the importance of recognising the social, as opposed to individual, construction of space.

Jurgen Habermas (1991) further developed the concept of the lifeworld and argued that it is the background environment of people's competences, practices and attitudes. He placed a greater focus on communicative practices and argued that the lifeworld is grounded in social and cultural understandings of communication. Much of his work focused on the idea that the lifeworld is made up of socially and culturally sedimented linguistic meanings which are the lived realm of informal, culturally grounded mutual understandings. These communication processes are further informed by events and experiences within a specific place that come together to form a shared understanding of the world. Thus, while for Husserl lifeworlds are intersubjective, dynamic and based on shifts in consciousness, Habermas's approach focused more on the way in which communicative practices form lifeworlds through transmitting the meanings of the symbolic understandings of the intersubjective. Despite the slight differences in what each of these theorists saw as most relevant to the construction of lifeworlds, there were commonalities in their understandings. They agreed that a lifeworld essentially can be thought of as the background of all our experiences, the background in which all things are made meaningful. It is not static and is not unchangeable but rather can shift and move in relation to the social conditions that make up the lifeworld.

Since the work of these first lifeworld theorists, numerous studies have emerged within various disciplines using lifeworlds as a theoretical construct to show how people make sense of their lives and draw meaning from the worlds around them. Anthropologist Michael Jackson (2017) in his book, *How Lifeworlds Work*, argues that individual well-being and social viability depend on the important relationship between inner and outer realities, the self and the other. In asking how lifeworlds 'work', Jackson aims to explore how individual and collective lives are produced while also looking at how people create meaningful lives. Bjorn Kraus (2015) also argues that individuals and their reality are influenced by the social and material conditions of their environment and it is this that comes to form their lifeworlds. Kraus's assumption is that one's reality is one's own

subjective construct; however, it is not random and is linked to the wider environment in which one lives.

Burnett et al. (2001, p. 536) also draw on the idea that an individual's identity is built through the wider environment in which that person is living. However, they focus on the concept of 'small worlds', which draws on the idea that social environments and individuals are bonded together by shared interests, expectations, behaviour, economic status and geographic proximity. These 'small worlds' are the worlds that individuals living together within a small geographic proximity construct. Through these worlds, they understand social expectations, behaviour and often factors such as economic status which determine the normative behaviours of those who live within that world. Within these worlds, even if they are small, everyday activities and modes of communication are considered to be the natural way of the world and are assumed to be practised in other worlds. Chatman (1999) also discusses the concept of small worlds and argues that the individual members of a small world will observe and follow the norms within a specific space. It is from these norms that they gain meaning about specific information. It is also through these understandings that, as Chatman argues, normative behaviours emerge. These social norms give a sense of what is right and what is wrong and what behaviour is acceptable. Through these worldviews, its members begin to build a sense of what is important, what is not and where value should be laid. It is within these normative understandings of the social world that an understanding of others and oneself is built. It is also through these understandings that worldviews and sense of normality are established.

Lifeworlds can be both singular and plural. There can be a lifeworld of a small community or group of people and then also a bigger social lifeworld in which they are all living. Within a broader lifeworld, there can be multiple smaller lifeworlds. An individual may experience multiple lifeworlds such as that of the local community and that of their country; or their home or workplace. A country such as Colombia can also be seen to have multiple lifeworlds that people inhabit and experience. There may be specific lifeworlds such as the lifeworld of the FARC; however, there are also multiple other lifeworlds within Colombia. It is for this reason that I chose to use lifeworlds theory as it is an effective theory to show the multiple realities that young people can be exposed to, that can affect their decision to become part of an armed group.

Intersubjectivity is at the centre of lifeworld theory, which could be likened to what Hannah Arendt (1958) refers to as a web of relations

that bind together people across a shared social life. Arendt speaks of the public realm as, phenomenologically, being a space where the experiences of individuals are understood in ways that make them real and recognisable. In essence, lifeworlds are the interaction between environment and self. They exist as a means by which, as Nordstrom (1997) suggests, people can learn about themselves through being in the world: they are in the world and the world is in them. In this way, humanity and the social are inextricably intertwined (Berger and Luckman 1966). As social creatures, we seek to interact with others, to belong to and be accepted in groups (Fornas 1995). The lifeworld is therefore inherently social. The term 'social' derives from the Latin word *socius*, friend and companion, and is concerned with the way that human communities are shaped by intersubjective relations of nearness, belonging and solidarity (Fornas 1995). The social is essentially built through the ontological understandings of the collective meaning that we find in the physical, geographical and cultural elements around us. It is through these social groups and our interactions with others that we learn about what exists within the world and how we should behave while we are in it. This learning, for the most part, begins in the home but also takes place within the public space. The public space is at the centre of the lifeworld and it is through our interactions with others living within this space that we build up a common local identity and form a locality (Peleikis 2001). As Jackson (1995, p. 118) states: 'no human being comes to a knowledge of himself or herself except through others. From the outset of our lives, we are in intersubjectivity'.

Exploring the concept of lifeworld is therefore best done through a phenomenological lens. The term 'phenomenology' first emerged in philosophy texts in the eighteenth century. Kant made the most prominent use of the term when he wrote '*Phenomenology of Spirit*' in 1807 (Moran 2000). Phenomenology is essentially the scientific study of experience and attempts to describe human consciousness as it is lived by individuals. In the words of Paul Ricoeur (1979, p. 12), 'phenomenology is an investigation into the structures of experience that precede connected expression in language. Phenomenology attempts to uncover beliefs, intentions and what people hold to be true'. For Merleau-Ponty (1964), it is a way of describing how human beings actively make the world around them. It allows humans to know, in some way or another, both what they are doing and why they are doing it. Michael Staudigl (2014) explains that phenomenology aims to explore the ways in which consciousness makes sense of what is experienced objectively by making sense of the structures that exist within social

environments. It is through building an understanding of the structures of lived experience that we can begin to understand an individual's world as it is shared with others. A phenomenological approach therefore offers a comprehensive view into the lifeworld as it attempts to uncover the deep unknown that what is not seen but understood by all of those who inhabit the world. Below, I will explore the key themes of the lifeworld, drawing on the key lifeworld theorists, to explore my construction of the lifeworld.

One of the most essential elements of understanding the lifeworld involves understanding the key phenomena and structures that exist within that world. Phenomena can include anything that appears to be real and is experienced through aspects such as seeing, hearing, feeling as well as believing, remembering, wishing, deciding, imagining and evaluating. A structure is a thought pattern or behaviour that has become firmly embedded in the habits, social relations, economic activities, institutions and laws and policy of a specific group. Giddens (1984) defines structures as being the rules and resources that individuals draw upon as they reproduce their society in their everyday lives. These could include language, religion, technological developments, institutions and kinship structures (Durkheim 1984). Social structures may also include sexism and racism (Ho 2007). Ways of dressing, concepts of right and wrong, symbols, jokes, taboos and values could also be included as social structures. Religion is perhaps one of the most prominent examples of social structures throughout the world in which individuals gain meaning. Durkheim (1984) argues that religion can draw people together through symbols and rites to make individuals aware of their common dependence on the society of which they are part.

The shared understandings that are built through the collective codes of meaning and symbolic patterns that we learn from the phenomena and structures within our environment, in turn, make the world meaningful and allow us to find specific positions in it (Fornas 1995). The structures within a specific place and the way in which they have been shaped by the specific social and cultural intricacies of that place are therefore essential in understanding how a specific lifeworld has been formed. These could include cosmology, knowledge, communication, morals and boundaries, gender, symbolism, shared histories, common identities, place and legitimacy. The following briefly describes the broader structures that I argue form the lifeworlds of young people in Colombia.

Knowledge

Constructs of knowledge are at the centre of society. Every institution, organisation or social group is made up of a body of knowledge, which is used to convey to its inhabitants the appropriate rules of conduct. Knowledge is essential to the construction of lifeworlds as it is what individuals perceive to be the body of generally valid truths about reality.

Communication

The everyday lifeworld is filled with forms of communicative activity. One of the primary ways in which we reach understandings with others who share our lifeworlds is through communicative practices. The cultural themes and constructs of knowledge within our environments are made meaningful to us in the ways in which they are transferred to us through communication.

Gender

Gender roles play a central role in social constructs throughout the world. Social behaviours for both males and females are largely dependent on their social and cultural environments and are therefore intrinsic to understanding lifeworlds.

Memory

Identities are largely constructed through the sedimentation and accumulation of knowledge from the past. We understand ourselves through our histories. For individuals to understand the worlds in which they live they must be able to understand how they were produced. This largely occurs through making sense of collective memory, that is, the memory that is shared by others in the social group.

Place

The concept of place generally refers to the environment in which specific actions, experiences, intentions and meanings of an individual or community are brought together spatially. One therefore understands how one's world is meaningful through one's experiences within a specific environment.

I recognise that these are complex and intricate subjects; however, it is beyond the scope of book to go into detail about all of the components that form these specific structures. However, it is essential to acknowledge them as they are a central part of lifeworlds theory. It should also be noted here that the intersubjectively shared patterns found within lifeworlds may overlap or coincide with other lifeworlds (Beck 2012). These different worlds may have shared symbols or language where the meaning of the specific structures or phenomena within those worlds is shared or in other cases where the meaning differs. The boundaries of lifeworlds may also be redrawn as new situations emerge (Jackson 2002). This is certainly the case in conflict areas. As Kalyvas (2003) points out, civil wars are not binary but complex processes that have a mix of identities and actions where individuals may be affected differently depending on their proximity to the violence. In such cases, a multitude of lifeworlds may exist that may overlap with each other.

In Colombia, this is undoubtedly the case, where there is not just one lifeworld, but rather there are particular lifeworlds that people experience according to their particular contexts. However, there are two distinct broad spheres that characterise the country: the civilian sphere and the militarised sphere. Within the civilian sphere, there are multiple lifeworlds that have been shaped in relation to specific social and cultural contexts. The dynamics that shape these various lifeworlds include ethnicity, social class, socio-economic status and proximity to the violence. However, due to the long-running conflict, most places within the civilian sphere have been characterised by some form of violence. In some places, the violence has been extreme whereas in other parts of Colombia, such as in upper-class urban settings, there has been far less violence. This explains why from the perspective of my participants, such as Diego who was discussed earlier, their society is divided into two ‘worlds’: those of violence and relative non-violence.

The militarised sphere in Colombia, part of what my participants see as the ‘world of violence’, is made up of the various armed groups throughout the country as well as the national army. The lifeworlds of each of these groups are also different, which is largely due to the ways in which they have defined themselves and the social environments within them. The FARC, for example, define themselves as a social revolutionary armed group who are fighting the government on behalf of the rural poor in the countryside and mountainous regions of Colombia. The *bacrim*s have no particular ideology that they adhere to and are more centred around extortion and

controlling drug trafficking routes in the cities. As a result, the social identities of the individuals emerging from these groups are often different. This was particularly notable when comparing the boys at Don Bosco with the children at CAE, who did not identify with each other despite the fact that they were all Colombians. So while both of these groups of children come from lifeworlds that were defined by violence, their social identities are different because the lifeworlds they came from also were different.

Most of the children who join the armed groups in Colombia come from one of the areas that have been characterised by violence. This plays a key role in the militarisation process as one of the key tenets of militarisation is acclimatising recruits to violence. For children who have grown up in areas where violence has been commonplace, this process of adapting to violence has already begun for them. So when they enter into the FARC, the process of shifting into the guerrilla identity is not as significant as it would be for a child from an area in Colombia that has not been so definitively shaped by violence, such as the upper-class areas of the cities. However, entering into an armed group still requires a process of shifting, as there are still distinctions between the civilian and military spheres, even if both have been shaped by significant violence.

It is beyond the scope of this book to explore all of the complexities in the various lifeworlds that exist throughout Colombia. Instead, this book follows the premise that the process of militarising children who join the FARC begins in the civilian sphere that has been shaped by violence and finishes when they enter into the lifeworld of the FARC. The rest of the chapter will therefore focus on what I argue is the most relevant parts of lifeworld theory to show how child militarisation occurs. I have drawn from the above-mentioned theorists to build a concept of the lifeworld that can demonstrate the ways in which children can be militarised through the lifeworld that they live within.

CONSCIOUSNESS, IDENTITY AND THE LIFEWORLD

Husserl (1970) shows there is a relationship between human consciousness and the physical and material elements that exist within our environment. He explains that as the information in our environments becomes linked to our consciousness an identity is formed. How the specific information from the social environment becomes connected to one's own consciousness is beyond the scope of this book. However, it is important to provide a brief overview of my position, which aligns with Husserl. For Husserl, individuals

first observe phenomena and then go through a process of learning how they are meaningful in relation to their social environment. As these constructs of meaning are reinforced through repetition, a social process of sedimentation begins. The concept of sedimentation has been used widely in lifeworlds theory and refers to the way in which the phenomena from one's social environment becomes part of one's consciousness to be seen as a natural part of the world. Much in the way as Jackson (1996, p. 12) points out, how objective reality or the phenomena of human experience, are interlinked with subjective reality. Berger and Luckman (1966) too argue that realities are formed by apprehending the 'objectivated' social reality and then continuously producing that reality. As individuals are able to make sense of the world and the meaning from that world sediments within their consciousness, they are able to begin to comprehend themselves and, as Rainbow (1977) notes, a self is made. I will describe here in greater detail how this occurs.

Observing and Learning About Phenomena

One of the primary ways of receiving information is visual. Merleau-Ponty (1968, p. 4) emphasises that perception is not an instinctive bodily practice. He writes 'that the world is what we see and that, nonetheless, we must learn to see it'. Just as habits orient our movement, perceptual habits orient our perception of the world. We in part obtain the world just by seeing it. Thus, the process of phenomena entering into our consciousness first begins through visual observation (Luckman 1983). It is also through the observation of the norms in our world that we learn about the constructs of knowledge, systems of beliefs as well as the various skills, practices, norms and values of our given societies (Mesoudi 2013). We observe social norms, concepts of right and wrong, boundaries and how to interact with others by seeing how others behave (Boxer et al. 2009). Watching how others are punished is also a means of learning as we learn what we should not do, simply just by seeing Mace. This could include observing the ways in which practices of honour are carried out within a given community. For example, when one sees another being punished for going against a specific practice of honour, this then reinforces the code of honour. Another would include structures of legitimacy, as one observes how boundaries are formed around structures of legitimacy certain codes of conduct are then reinforced. It is through the observation of specific phenomena that they become real to

the social group (King 2004). Thus, it is through the visual observations of our lifeworlds that we first begin to understand them.

We also learn about the lifeworld by being told about it. As Habermas (1987) argues, the everyday lifeworld is built upon a network of communicative actions which are based on the mutual recognition of situations that take place against a background of unquestioned presuppositions. Through language, we learn about the knowledge structures within our environments which, along with our visual observations, can then be incorporated into a larger body of knowledge (Berger and Luckman 1966). Some of the ways in which we may learn about our environments may include imitation, imprinting, telling and teaching (Vygotsky 1978). We may also learn about them through moral instruction and religious guidance. Narratives and myths are also forms in which collective knowledge can be transmitted through language. Places can also become vessels through which stories are held and kept and then shared through narration (Van Gelder 2008). It is therefore through language that we can objectivate our experiences and make them real to others and part of the collective stock of knowledge (Berger and Luckman 1966, p. 85). Through communicative practices, information from one's own consciousness can be transferred to others and a collective consciousness is formed (Habermas 1987). Thus, one of the primary ways in which we learn about lifeworlds is simply by being told about them.

Entering Consciousness and Sedimentation

One of the major implications of Husserl's work was to draw attention to the 'bodiliness' of human existence. To be in the world is to be physically in the world but the world is also in us. We embody our worlds. Much work has explored the notion of embodiment which is the relation between human subjectivity and sociality. Vivian Sobchack (2004) situates the notion of embodiment as a condition of being human that involves both the body and the consciousness, objectivity and subjectivity. Geertz (1973) also suggests that individuals gain access to their world through embodying the cultural practices in their environments. It is the meaning that we take from our external worlds that comes to define our internal worlds. Paul Connerton (1989) explores the importance of bodily practice and social memory. According to him, there are two dimensions to embodiment, one that highlights the importance of ritual and ceremonial performances as commemorative acts and the other which is habitual memory.

Nicolas Argenti and Schramm (2010, p. 23), who writes on embodiment and violence, also argues that memory may be sedimented in bodily practices through performance, ritual and possession. Performative memory may be transferred from one to another through initiation, apprenticeship and other rites of passage and allows individuals to understand historical situations by using deep wells of cultural knowledge to interpret the past. As Berger and Luckman (1966, p. 134) write, ‘reality is socially defined and always embodied, that is, individuals serve as definers of reality’. While the phenomena from one’s environment might be embodied in a variety of different ways, we can define that embodiment as essentially the merging of the subjective experience of being human with objective reality and sociality.

Merleau-Ponty (1976) developed the notion of ‘the living body’ as a philosophical concept to understand the body as opposed to it just being physiological. He explored the way in which the body acts as the mediating interface between the individual and the world and emphasised the important role of habits in this relationship. To act habitually is to respond to a particular condition in the environment with a particular form of behaviour. As these behaviours are repeated they then become incorporated into knowledge structures that unconsciously direct everyday life activities (Berger and Luckman 1966). Over time, they become embedded in the social relations and institutions such as governments and school systems (Moser and McIlwaine 2005). Thomas Fuchs (2008), who draws on the work of Merleau-Ponty, argues that habits and habitualisation are understood through unconscious memories that are repeated in everyday life, otherwise known as habitual memory. The French philosopher Henri Bergson (1911) also argued that habitualised patterns of behaviour create memories in the mind as well as the structures of the body. In this way, the past is not only remembered through images or narratives but also through the body. As Fuchs (2008, p. 43) writes, ‘we could say that as subjects we have our past, while in our bodily existence we are our past’. As the structures of our worlds become fixed in our minds, as Adam Smith (1973) describes, through habitual reflection we then begin to understand how to behave within specific situations. As they become recognised patterns, they begin to take on an appearance of normality.

As we learn about our worlds, through observation and communication, whatever exists within that world comes to be seen as the natural, everyday norm for individuals. They form the everyday metaphysical assumptions of individuals about what is in the world. Husserl called this ‘the natural atti-

tude', being the attitude under which we live our lives and the belief that reality is the way that we perceive it to be (Hermberg 2006). This reality is shared with the others who live in the same social environments and it is these shared realities that bind us together. Durkheim (1984) refers to this process as mechanical solidarity where groups are drawn together through the homogeneous beliefs and sentiments common to all the members of that group. In a type of symbolic interactionism, the norms, rules and expectations of a particular place or society create shared realities in everyday life (Beck 2012). The relationship between habitualisation, the body and consciousness is essential in understanding why individuals behave in certain ways and in understanding lifeworlds.

It is through this entire process that our individual selves, or our identities, are formed where environmental phenomena and consciousness merge to form a self and 'what everybody knows' (Sen 1985). For Berger and Luckman (1966), our experiences in environments are made recognisable and memorable within the self through a process of sedimentation. In other words, as social integration, or sedimentation, occurs, social actors are able to connect the social conditions, cultural meanings and values within their world to their own identities (Boucher 2014). This could be understood through the concept of transitivity which refers to a stream of information to the consciousness (Beck 2012). Such ideas that experience results from pre-reflective habitualised behaviours into a transitive flow of consciousness can be found in Bourdieu's (1989) theory of habitus as well as in Foucault's (1977) discourse analysis. Geertz (1973) also makes reference to such ideas in his discussion of ideation which is the process of individuals interpreting and making sense of the vast stream of information in their environments. They share the view that the individual understandings of the world occur in an unconscious, pre-reflective manner. The concept of pre-reflective refers to an individual's reaction to a specific event or phenomena that takes place before reflection or rational thought occurs. It is a term used widely throughout lifeworlds theory that aims to show how phenomena from a social environment have sedimented within individuals to the point where they can react to something without giving it conscious thought. In order to subjectively understand oneself, one must come to terms with and understand one's experiences within the environment in which one lives (Biehl et al. 2007). Thus, as individuals make sense of the information that they receive from their environments they begin to make sense of themselves.

The lifeworld is therefore where individuals ‘know’ with confidence that the characteristics in that world are real (Berger and Luckman 1966, p. 33). As McGuigan and Popp (2016) suggest, it is the many general rules of conduct within our environment that form the deep underlying logic of our worldview as well as the behaviour, principles and natural laws that we come to accept. It is through these understandings that what Geertz (1973) describes as the ‘ethos’, or the cognitive, existential aspects of what becomes one’s worldview are formed. This worldview operates much like ‘a cohesive narrative of existence, or mental map which functions, in much the same way as a geographic map, as a guide to the terrain of life’ (Geertz 1973, p. 11). Lifeworlds can therefore be likened to a bundle of individual structures or networks of social relations that inform our everyday interactions and give us meaning on which to base our behaviour (King 2004). The intersubjective norms of a given community could be likened to threads that link the social reality of the collective and individuals (Staudigl 2014). In this way, the environments that surround us are not just part of human existence, but are an essential condition for it (Das and Kleinman 1997). These structures that make up our ‘mental maps’ in essence work as threads that link social reality and how individuals understand themselves and their experience within the world in which they are living.

MULTIPLE WORLDS, SHIFTING WORLDS

Lifeworlds cannot be understood as being static; they are not unchangeable but are, rather, always shifting and have the ability to change. As humans, we are malleable, always open to influence and change, and so are our worlds. The Kuranko in West Africa see worlds as ‘something that is never static, something merely given which the person then “accepts” or “adjusts” or “fights”’. It is rather a dynamic pattern in which, so long as I possess self-consciousness, I am in the process of forming and designing’ (Jackson 1988, p. 194). Etymologically, the Indo-European root of the word ‘experience’ is to venture. It is to move to and fro in the world in both spatial and temporal terms (Jackson 2002). Such a metaphor implies that through experience we can make shifts in our identity, which can occur as there are changes in our environments. By this formula, we always have the propensity to change our perspectives as we move through different social environments and as we encounter new constructs of meaning (Vygotsky 1978).

Such ideas of shifting identities have been found in the work of Thomas Schmid and Richard Jones (1991) who show how individuals, when entering into a new social situation, may suspend their previous identity in order to take on a new one that is relevant to the new social situation. In his work on war and apologies, Barry O'Neil (1999) also draws on similar ideas and writes about the concept of 'face' where members of a specific group behave in accordance with what they understand to be acceptable. Similar ideas have been found through work done on the concept of masking. David Napier (1986), who writes on masking and transformation, suggests that the concept of masks is related to the idea of transitioning identities. A mask metaphorically represents a different identity and a different way of behaving and once the mask has been put on, it permits the appearance of a shadow self where individuals can distance themselves from their own actions and transgress boundaries, allowing them to more or less pretend that they are somebody else. Such examples demonstrate the ways in which individuals can shift their perceived identities in accordance with their environments.

For Berger and Luckman (1966), shifts in consciousness can be likened to the way that a curtain rises and falls. As the curtain rises, individuals can be transported to another world with its own meanings and then as the curtain falls, individuals return back to another reality. As the contexts of meaning within a certain social environment change, so can an individual self. Experience in this sense, as Jackson (1996, p. 29) suggests, evokes the metaphor of journeying, a going forth, a venture. Identity can move, it can go backwards and forwards, be fluid and multidimensional. As the conditions of our lives are remade, so too can be the boundaries of our lifeworlds. As the social environment shifts, so can our identities. Our most intimate inner processes, emotions, memory and our deepest sense of self can always be remade (Kleinman 2007). As Enloe writes (1990), our worlds have been made and therefore can be remade.

Our identities, how we see ourselves and the world around us, are therefore directly related to life's changing social conditions. Our worlds are, as King (2004) describes, a complex web of never-ending social relations, which are mutually binding and always transforming. Jackson (1996, p. 27) writes: 'lifeworlds are never a seamless, unitary domain in which social relations remain constant and where the experience of self remains stable. Nor is it ever Arcadian, it is a scene of turmoil, ambiguity, resistance, dissimulation and struggle'. Our worlds or mental terrains, both individual and collective, are not always steady and clearly defined. They are rocky, they

can move and shift. As Husserl (1970, p. 107) observes, they ‘hold sway in consciousness’. The meaning that we find through the phenomena within our environments is therefore always infinite, contextual and expandable. Should the essential meaning or essence of those phenomena change in a certain way, how individuals see that phenomena may change too (Merleau-Ponty 1968). The lifeworld is then something that is always in the making and reforming itself in relation to the social environment and the way in which one sees oneself is therefore never fixed, but can always be reimagined, reconstructed and re-embodied (Halilovich 2013, p. 1).

GROWING UP IN THE WORLD OF VIOLENCE

As I have shown, the theory of lifeworlds is useful for understanding how our identities can be formed in relation to the social worlds in which we live and this is particularly relevant to show how processes of militarisation work. As Burnett et al. show, specific lifeworlds can be formed amongst small groups and this is relevant when looking at armed groups. While the FARC has certainly been shaped by the broader social, cultural and historical factors specifically relevant to Colombia, it has formed a lifeworld of its own. My argument for the concept of lifeworlds is similar to that of Kraus (2015), however, I also take into account the work of Husserl and Habermas and recognise the great importance of understanding the way in which consciousness has been influenced by communicative activities. I argue that we all live within our own subjective reality, or lifeworld, as the specific conditions that have come to shape our specific understandings of ourselves are just that: specific to ourselves. Culture plays a fundamental role in our understandings of how we should behave and what we should do, particularly in accordance with our gender and our social standing within a specific group. While our own individual identities are indeed our own subjective constructs, they are also intersubjective.

By understanding the lifeworlds in which children grow up and the lifeworlds of the armed groups they join, we can begin to understand how children are militarised. If we assume that an individual’s self is formed through his or her social environment, then we can assume that when a social environment is militarised, it is likely that the individuals within that environment will become militarised as well. This is not to assume that all children who grow up in militarised environments will join armed groups; however, it certainly increases the chances that a child will become involved with one.

In order to understand the way in which children who join the FARC in Colombia are militarised it is necessary to explore both the civilian lifeworlds in which they have grown up and the guerrilla lifeworld they move into and the specific structures and phenomena of those lifeworlds. It also involves understanding how they move between these two worlds. This in part involves understanding the ways in which violent conflict has impacted children's environments and identifying the ways in which habits and structures have been formed in response to armed conflict. Teresa Koloma Beck (2014), who writes on violence during the civil war in Angola and the link between violent armed conflict and body memory, argues that in order to understand the impact of violence on an individual one must unpack the communicative and knowledge structures that have been prevalent in that person's environment and what specific habitual practices have been normalised within it. This might include exploring the difficulties brought on by war that can have deep effects on habitual behaviour. It might also include individuals finding ways to manage the stress and difficulties that come with the destruction of infrastructures and hunger during times of armed conflict.

In Colombia, the world of violence, where the majority of the children that have joined the armed groups come from, could correspond with Nordstrom's (1997) concept of the 'warscape'. A warscape is the intersection of landscapes of war and the lifeworlds of ordinary people. These are reterritorialised scapes that have been transformed from everyday sites into places of violence, uncertainty and fear. They are sites where historically built social relations and cultural meanings have been shaped by violence (Richards 2005). In warsapes, violent social processes become the normal, expected context for unfolding social life (Lubkemann 2008). In this context, what is seen as 'normal' is directly related to the social processes and structures of a particular environment that are continuously reproduced (Beck 2012). It is these factors found in Nordstrom's warscape that could best define the world of violence where recruitment predominantly takes place in Colombia. The long-running nature of the conflict has certainly had a large impact on both the civilians and the armed actors involved. The broader structural and social factors that have shaped the world in which children have grown up will be explored in Chapter 5. However, in order to begin to understand how children have been militarised, it is necessary to understand where the militarisation begins, in the home. It is in the home where children first learn their values and morals and where their first understandings of the world are formed.

In Colombia, insecurity and violence have shaped the lives of many of the country's young people and have done so in a number of ways. Whether it is armed groups knocking on the door demanding one of their children or a mother trying to survive alone with five children because her husband was murdered by the guerrillas, violence in Colombia has had a profound effect on children, including in their home lives. One afternoon in CAE I asked Marlon, one of the former combatants, if life in the guerrilla was difficult. 'No', he replied, 'not as difficult as home'. He then looked away in embarrassment. In a later conversation, he described his home life in greater detail and explained how he grew up on a farm in poverty where violence was frequent. Marlon came from the mountains in Neiva. His father was a member of the FARC but he grew up on a farm with his mother and brothers and sisters. He reported that life was hard on the farm and this was one of the factors that influenced him to join the guerrilla, as well as being attracted to having a gun. He also spoke of poverty and this was one of the most common themes in the narratives of the children who joined armed groups. Eduardo's story is a demonstration of this. Eduardo was 13 when he entered the FARC in the countryside of Tolima. He joined the armed group because of problems in this family and with few opportunities to do anything else he saw the FARC as a means to escape a violent home life:

It is common for families to have a lot of children, though this is starting to change. The problem is that there are many separated families in Colombia and it is often in these cases that you see children becoming involved with the conflict and the armed groups. When children do not get a lot of attention from their parents, they often become involved with armed groups. There isn't access to education, there are no universities and there is also no presence of the government. The military are sometimes there but when they are there they are often starting fights which creates an environment of hate. So psychologically this creates a difficult environment for the people living there. Women have been raped and people have been killed. So it is in these situations that people get involved with the FARC. (Former guerrilla, age 27, Florencia)

What Eduardo was describing, as did many participants, was a home life where the earliest observations of life were filled with notions of violence that were both physical and structural. Social breakdown, poverty, cracked family structures were common and had played a significant role in influencing young people to take up arms (Pachon 2012).

Tales of family abuse in the home were frequent amongst the children in CAE. On another occasion, I was sitting in the office at CAE when one of the girls came into the office where I was working. She stood in the doorway and hesitated for a moment. I asked her what was wrong and she burst into tears. As she knelt on the floor and put her head on my lap, she eventually managed to tell me through her sobs that she had been on the phone to her parents and they had told her that they did not want her. She was devastated and as she sobbed it became clear why she had joined an armed group. At a very young age, she had been rejected by her family and with few other opportunities or alternatives, the FARC offered her a means of survival. On another occasion at CAE, I sat with Daniela and we were speaking about her home life when, with embarrassment, she showed me scars on her legs which had come from her father beating her. She later explained that she had run away from her home to join the FARC after her stepfather tried to rape her. Her mother refused to believe her and so with few other opportunities to escape from the violence, she decided to join the FARC.

Daniel, a former child guerrilla who had become an educator at CAE in Medellin, also demonstrates the role of poverty and violence in influencing children's decisions to become involved in Colombia's armed groups:

There were a lot of armed groups where I grew up. My family has been really affected by the conflict. My grandparents were killed by the government army and so my father grew up alone with another man. Where my dad grew up there was a big presence of the armed groups which was a really big problem for the campesinos. So if the FARC arrived for example, they would have to do whatever they asked or else they will be killed. If the government army arrived then the same thing would happen. In the countryside the guerrillas are the law, if you work with the army then you a collaborator of the army, if you work with the FARC then you are a collaborator with the FARC.

So for a long time we had to live in very difficult conditions. We would have to go out onto the street and ask for money so that we could eat. The government didn't help these people very much. So we were really affected by the conflict.

All the armed groups were where I grew up. I had 8 brothers and sisters, we were 6 boys and 2 girls. I grew up in the streets, selling things on the buses, I had to do these things to be able to get food and so did my brothers and sisters.

Johanna: *So how old were you when you joined the armed group?*

Daniel: *I left my home when I was 7 years old and I went with my brother. We packed up bags in the night and we woke up really early and we went. We went to Ibagué, I was only 7 years old, he was 14 and we began to work on the buses. So I went to look for a friend that we knew living there with his wife. He would come every night drunk and he would beat his wife. It really wasn't nice for me to be living in this environment. So I left. I lived three years in the street, I preferred to be there, sleeping in the street. I was really lucky that I didn't get involved with robbery or anything like that like my other brothers and sisters did. I always wanted to get things for myself.*

After a couple of months we met a man who had a coca farm and he offered us work and so we thought great. We went to the farm and when we arrived we saw some men who were up in the tree with AK47s and I thought that this was a little bit strange. We went into the farm and we started to work. After that this man came and offered us to join the ELN, I said that I didn't want to go but my brother was interested and so he went with them, he convinced me to go with him.

We slept the first night that we got there we had to sleep on a piece of plastic and there was a dog there with her puppies who had so many fleas and they bit us horribly. And for the first time I was given a gun and we had to do guard duty. They told me here is a gun, it's really big and heavy. I was 11 years old. (Former child guerrilla, age 22, Medellín)

Throughout Daniel's story, there is a narrative of a broken home, poverty and a lack of opportunities. The armed groups had been present in his world since he was young, as they had been in his parents' lives. The structural elements in his environment including the breakdown in his family structure and limited access to education and opportunities for work led him to a situation where joining an armed group seemed a viable option to escape his problems. For children such as Daniel, the violence displaced him in multiple senses. It quite literally pushed him out of his home and into an armed group whereas such a young child, there were few other opportunities for him. The armed groups offered an alternative source of survival away from the violence in his home and the lack of opportunities that his social environment offered.

In other cases, children had grown up amongst narco-trafficking networks which provided a gateway into the world of violence. Growing up in areas of poverty with few opportunities, drug trafficking offered a lucrative source of survival. Marlon, one of the ex-combatants from CAE, explained

how he had been involved with one of the narco-trafficking networks before joining the FARC. He said:

I used to grow and transport cocaine with my uncles. I would sell it to the person who was going to distribute it. I was about 11 or 12 when I was doing this, the police won't do anything to children so it's easier for children to do it. They gave me money. My cousins are still doing this because they don't know how to do anything else. It's because it's what their parents did. They didn't have an opportunity to study or to look for any other type of work. (Former child guerrilla, age 19, Nieva)

The presence of the armed groups around the children's homes, as well as exposure to violence outside of their homes, also pushed children into armed groups. This included witnessing combat, landmine explosions, bombings and kidnapping and not being able to attend school for reasons related to the conflict, such as landmines being on their paths to school, recruitment both in schools and on their way to school, the killing of teachers, forced displacement and cuts in investment for education to be invested in military operations which have pushed children into joining an armed group (Roshani 2014, p. 13). Andres, who had joined the FARC as a child, working as part of their militia in San Jose del Guaviare, was now living as a civilian in the same city where he once operated as an armed child combatant, he explained:

The guerrillas were living where I was from and so I went to join them. In the countryside we see them like the police or the military and you would find them everywhere. They were the law, when you leave San Jose del Guaviare practically everywhere are the guerrillas. So children join because it is what's close to them. It's the only option that they see themselves as having. They haven't been in the city studying or working so in that moment it's the only thing that they think they can do. So maybe they finish with their girlfriend and they're unhappy in their house so they say okay I am going to go to the guerrillas and they go. There was one boy who went because his parents were beating him and they were always making him work so he left, he was 10 years old.

I knew what I was doing when I entered the guerrilla. I really wanted to go and get a gun, its what I wanted.

Johanna: *Why not the police or the military?*

Andres: *Because they don't take children and there are a lot rules, the FARC no, you can just go and in the countryside there's practically no law. And we don't like the police or the military.*

Johanna: *Why not with the paramilitaries?*

Andres: *No, this was an area of the guerrillas. The military would enter but the guerrillas were in charge. I practically grew up with them. You saw them everyday. Where I grew up they spoke a lot with me.*

There were a lot of rules, there is a lot of discipline. So for example you can not take cocaine out of the town without paying a tax. The farmers also have to pay a tax. If there's a problem between some of the people then they would come to fix the problem. They would sometimes make the person leave the town and they would have to leave their land and everything, if not they would kill them. They would have war councils for this as well. Well the town would decide they would vote, like in election. I propose that we kill him, or that we make him leave. This was normal. For rapists they would always choose to do the worst because there is nobody who is in agreement with this. They would always choose to kill them. I agree with this as well.

Johanna: *Were there a lot of rapes?*

Andres: *No, few. I just heard a few cases of this and the guerrillas killed them.*
(Former child guerrilla, age 24, San Jose del Guaviare)

It is within such a context that we can see how children's behaviour and the decisions that they make are built through their engagement within the settings of everyday life. In such contexts, patterns of perception, cognition and action transform in order to systematically integrate the possibility of experiencing violence. For children living within the world of violence in Colombia, we can begin to understand how body memory and habitual behaviours have formed around understandings of violence. Living within weakened social environments and regularly being exposed to violence and armed groups, young people have been made vulnerable to recruitment due to breakdowns in family structures and lack of access to education or opportunities for work. As the continuous cycle of war, violence and poverty have become rooted in the culture of families and communities, fear and terror have become commonplace, creating feelings of powerlessness and victimisation. Military life and the use of violence have become part of the 'of courseness' of the everyday common-sense knowledge of children as everyday places such as the schoolyard, the home and playground have

become staging grounds for military activity. The breakdown of structural systems has left young people in a precarious situation where they are unable to achieve honour, recognition, status and a means of achieving power due to the environment in which they are living. In such a context, it becomes almost inevitable that children will become drawn into violent activity and see another means of achieving status, such as by joining an armed group. It is within such a context that militarised identities begin to be formed.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter, I have argued that lifeworlds are formed through the phenomena and social structures that exist within a specific social environment. The meanings that we take from these lifeworlds influence the way that we see the world around us and the way in which we see ourselves. As Merleau-Ponty (1962, p. xi) wrote, ‘there is no inner person, the person is in the world and only in the world do they know themselves’. No human being therefore comes to knowledge of himself or herself except through others. From the outset of our lives, we are in intersubjectivity (Jackson 1995, p. 118). Thus, in order to understand why children join armed groups, what makes them stay there and how they form their identities in relation to the armed groups to which they belong, it is therefore imperative to understand the civilian lifeworlds of their homes and the environments from which they come from and the lifeworlds of the armed group and how transitions are made between these two worlds as well as what overlaps might exist between them. It is through understanding this process of moving between the civilian lifeworld of violence and the military lifeworld that we begin to understand how children are militarised in Colombia. By looking at the specific structural, social and cultural factors that have been relevant to this process we can begin to understand how some of Colombia’s children end up in the depths of the Colombian jungles or traversing the rugged terrain of Colombia’s mountains with gun in tow while others choose to live with their families and go to school each day. I will show in the following chapters how this occurs. The next chapter will be an exploration of the specific factors that have shaped the world of violence in which the majority of the children who have joined armed groups grew up.

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The Militarised Lifeworlds of Children in Colombia

INTRODUCTION

If lifeworlds are the subjective experience of the social, what then happens to these lifeworlds when the social becomes wracked by war and violence? What happens when war and violence seep its way into the everyday? McSorley (2013, p. 1) writes, ‘war is not just political but is written on and experienced through the thinking, feeling bodies of men, women and children’. It has come to define Colombia as a nation. It has taken place in remote rural areas and cities and has affected the privileged elites as well as the socially forgotten (Castro et al. 2017). Violence has eroded social systems and destroyed opportunities for education, making survival all the more difficult. Violence, I argue, is a social force in Colombia and has played a defining role in creating, influencing and shaping structures and norms so that for many, violence has been given the appearance of normality.

In this chapter, I argue that violence has interlaced its way into the lifeworlds of many young people in Colombia and has played a fundamental role in drawing young people into armed groups. I will argue that there are two key forms of violence in Colombia. The first is extreme violence that has included massacres and widespread sexual violence, all of which has emerged from a long history of violence that has been generated by conflict over resources, drug trafficking and economic reform. The second consists of the severe structural inequalities that include poverty, a lack of opportunities and gender discrimination. I argue that the combination of

these two forms of violence has become part of the key social structures of many people's lifeworlds, as explored in Chapter 3, in Colombian society which has led to the formation of a very specific social world which is conducive to child militarisation. While there are both violent and non-violent contexts of life in Colombia, this chapter is an exploration of the civilian world of violence, as explained in Chapter 3, and ultimately aims to argue that living within an environment that has been shaped by violence pushes young people to join an armed group and also begins the process of militarising them into the identity of the guerrilla. It is an exploration of the first stage of how young people become militarised.

'THE WHOLE WORLD IS A WAR'

During the second phase of my fieldwork, as briefly mentioned in Chapter 2, one of my central goals was to find the children with whom I had worked at CAE who had returned to their homes. It was an arduous process as several of the children were quite elusive about their whereabouts. While I cannot be sure exactly why they were being elusive, I assumed that it was because some had returned to some form of illegal activity. However, I was able to meet with some of the children with whom I remained in contact through Facebook. This included Katerine, 16, and Marlon, 19, who were now living in Neiva. Katerine and I agreed to meet in one of the malls in Neiva, and when she arrived she was dressed beautifully, with carefully done hair and make-up. We went shopping together, browsed through the selection of make-up, discussed her new boyfriend and her dreams of becoming a lawyer. We then settled down to talk about her time with the guerrilla. It was one of the first moments that I was really able to delve into Katerine's past and her experiences with the guerrilla. Though we had spent several months together at CAE, as explained in Chapter 2, I was quite restricted in what I was allowed to speak to the children about. However, away from the constraints of CAE, we were able to talk freely. So as we sat at a table in the mall, with Colombians busily going about their activities around us, Katerine began to speak about her time in the FARC, which began when she was 13 years old and living with her grandmother in the department of Caqueta. It was an area that had been heavily dominated by the guerrilla and much violence, so it was common to see the guerrilla around the town and people would frequently interact with them. For Katerine, the guerrilla were a normal part of her daily life.

Katerine made the decision to join the FARC after she had a problem with her boyfriend. Interested in the guerrilla and frustrated with her situation, she was also attracted to the idea of taking up arms as they made her feel big and powerful, she said. Once she joined the FARC she began working as a *miliciano*, a spy operating inside the towns, in Caqueta. She was given a gun and told to extort businesses around the town. She then described some of her experiences, which included eating gunpowder, which was done ‘*so that you don’t feel afraid*’. Having heard that some recruits drink blood as a way of taking away the fear, I asked if she had done this. ‘Yes’, she replied. When I asked whose blood she drank, Katerine replied simply: ‘*A girl. I killed her*’.

I tried not to react. I found it difficult to reconcile with, sitting under the fluorescent lights of the brightly lit mall. She appeared to be like any other 16-year-old girl, which did not fit with the image she had just described. The casual way she spoke also took me by surprise. She did not have any visible reaction; her tone and body language were no different from when she had been speaking about her desires to become a lawyer or her new boyfriend. As she finished the story, she said that she had decided that to kill was no longer a good thing to do. I wondered what it was that had propelled her to make the choice to join an armed group at such a young age and what had led her to be able to recount this tale with such casualness? It was not just Katerine who spoke of violence in such a relaxed manner. All of the young combatants with whom I worked at CAE spoke of violence with a sense of normality. They spoke of their homes with tales of violence, gunfights and bullets, as if it was just the way the world is. All of the children at CAE expressed great surprise when I told them that there was no war in Australia; it was if it was a concept that they simply could not imagine.

When I met Marlon in Nieva he smiled warmly and as we wandered down to a nearby river where we would spend the afternoon together, we sat down by the water and he pointed to the mountains far in the distance where he grew up. ‘They’re full of guerrilla’, he said. As we settled down on the soft grass, ensuring that there was no one around to hear us, we began to discuss his experiences with the FARC:

Johanna: *When you were growing up did you understand that there was a war?*

Marlon: *Yes, but I thought it was like this in the whole world. When I was 15 years old I thought like this.*

Johanna: *So for you conflict is normal?*

Marlon: *Yes, if you grow up in that then you don't know peace so it seems normal for you. Where I grew up the guerrilla were walking around, we were friends with them.*

Johanna: *So do you think that most of the kids that go to the guerrillas have grown up in areas where there is a lot of war?*

Marlon: *Yes, because that's normal.*

This notion that war and violence were normal had been built through his life experiences which had led him to join an armed group.

It was these interactions with the former child combatants from the FARC and their belief that the entire world was at war, that led me to believe that understanding violence and the ways in which it had infiltrated the intricate layers of the children's lifeworlds were essential in understanding child militarisation. The casual way that they spoke about the violent worlds around them demonstrated that they believe that violence is a normal part of everyday life. The structures that made up their lifeworlds had been defined by violence. They spoke of their country's history as being filled with violence—a collective memory clearly shaped by the country's long armed conflict. It was evident that through the continuous observation of violent activities and hearing about violence through conversations in the family home, during their time with the armed group or amongst the other children in the reintegration home, violence had always been around them. Their objective worlds had shaped their subjective worlds and informed what was real. They had embodied the worlds around them and the meaning derived from that world was sedimented in their consciousness. It was through conversations with young former combatants of the FARC that I began to understand that the social environments of these children played a definitive role in understanding how children are militarised.

THE WORLD OF VIOLENCE

There's a phrase that says violence creates poverty and the poverty creates violence.
(Jose Daniel Avilez, former child soldier of the ELN)

Nancy Scheper-Hughes (1996) speaks about normalised violence in her book *Death Without Weeping* in which she explores the normalisation and institutionalised social responses to infant and child mortality in shantytown

favelas in Brazil. She writes about the invisible genocide of infants dying of hunger, where death unconsciously became part of life as legitimised by the town's inhabitants. Local political leaders including Catholic priests and nuns, coffin makers and even the shantytown mothers themselves left what they would call angel babies to die saying, 'well they themselves wanted to die'. The frequency with which death occurred led to desensitisation and death became an accepted part of daily life. Beck (2012) shows that ideas of normality are built around collectively shared ideas of how particular phenomena should be perceived. They are the result of historical processes where a particular reality has become known over others. Thus, what is normal is dependent on the events that have occurred within a particular society. As Scheper-Hughes shows, through repetition violence becomes invisible, embedding itself in normality. Philippe Bourgois and Scheper-Hughes (2003) also show that the more frequent the misery, violence and suffering, the more likely they are to become invisible.

My observations in Colombia were similar to those of Scheper-Hughes. Violence had embedded itself into what appeared to be the natural way of the world. The former guerrilla narrated their own violent actions and those of others as if they were normal, without the sense that violence was in any way morally reprehensible or unacceptable. Violent actions had been repeated so often in their environment that they had habitualised and become part of their lifeworld. This was evidenced by numerous examples, as when one of the boys came into the office where I was working one day and pointed a wooden gun at my head. I turned to him and said, 'that's not good'. He looked at me and smiled and said, 'it might not be good for you but it's good for me'. Violence was evidently something he felt he could gain from, that would be beneficial to him and this will be explored in greater depth later in the chapter.

Another afternoon I was in CAE preparing for a party with the girls. Wilson, one of the boys, came over and sat down with us. I was writing down the names of the girls for the girls' party and he asked whether I was writing down the names 'to kill them'. He was making a joke but it was embedded within a context of seriousness. The FARC are known for arriving into a town with a list of those intended to be killed. He then continued to complain that he was being sanctioned by one of the educators and was going to have a month without Internet. He declared that he was going to kill the educator and then go back to the guerrilla. The naturalness with which he made this joke exemplified its serious undertones. In his world, a list of names could indicate a list of people to be killed. It also

seemed out of context from the lifeworld of my civilian participants. During my fieldwork, I never heard any of my participants from the world of relative non-violence speak of killing in such a casual way nor did I ever hear them make jokes about killing people. Rather, when discussing violence their faces would display fear or disgust and their voices would often drop to a whisper. Their reactions to discussions of war and violence indicated an aversion to violence, where Wilson's did not. However, what I found most significant about Wilson's joke was that his references to killing were made without a moment's thought. He was reacting to what he had learned from his social environment; violence. As I progressed through my fieldwork and learned more about the life histories of the former child combatants and their social world, I began to understand how violence had become normalised in their lives.

A conversation with Andres, a former child guerrilla of the FARC, for example, demonstrated the nature of the violence in which many of these children had grown up. I said: 'I have heard this word 'kill' so many times in Colombia. It's extreme for me because I almost never hear this word in Australia'. He does not understand what I mean. I explain that to kill someone in Australia would be considered something not normal. He hesitated for a moment, looking confused, before replying:

Andres: It is really normal for us here for people to kill. There is a lot of violence here in Colombia with so many groups. The violence is always from the armed groups. (age 24, San Jose del Guaviare)

Andres had grown up in Guaviare, a region of Colombia that was well known for having a strong guerrilla presence and much violence. Throughout my time in the capital, San Jose del Guaviare, the whirling sound of military helicopters was regular and they could be heard daily taking off, I presumed in search of guerrilla. San Jose del Guaviare was under the control of the government and was surrounded by government military bases; however, the rest of the department was under the control of the FARC. Over the several weeks that I spent there I began to understand how the town had been deeply affected by the armed conflict. The many locals I met living within the town, including ex-guerrilla, coca pickers and teachers living in the guerrilla-held areas, explained how violence had threaded its way through the social life of the town. It had been heavily militarised and one could never be sure who was involved with which armed group. The result was a town marked by suspicion and fear.

In Guaviare, even government officials who wanted to travel outside of the urban centre required permission from the FARC. On several occasions when inquiring into which areas of Guaviare I could safely travel, it was government officials who advised me that I would first need to seek permission from the FARC. They appeared to be somewhat willingly sharing power with the FARC, who were supposed to be their enemy, suggesting that relations between them were complex and most likely corrupt. It was also a government official who told me of government soldiers involved in the rape of indigenous women in the rural areas of Guaviare. Other participants also spoke of this and explained that it was a result of lawless government soldiers who feared no punishment for their actions. This, combined with a culture of machismo and racism, meant that the rape of young indigenous girls was another form of violence that had become normalised. Indeed, when I asked the government official if anybody was trying to stop the sexual assault of these girls, he shrugged his shoulders, looked at me blankly and said, 'no'. The fact that anybody, anywhere, including government officials, could be involved with the violence or colluding with those who are, and operate with absolute impunity, has contributed greatly to the widespread violence, poverty mistrust that characterises Guaviare.

The influence of violence on social relations in Guaviare was evident in a number of ways. People spoke in hushed whispers and used code words such as *los amigos*, meaning the friends, when making reference to the guerrilla. There was evidently fear amongst those who lived there, and after spending several weeks listening to the many tales of violence, I began to understand why. One resident I spoke to was Ma Terasa, an elderly woman who had been displaced from her home in rural Guaviare. She was now living in San Jose del Guaviare and was introduced as a local women's rights advocate. We met in one of the local parks where she quietly whispered her story, glancing over her shoulder every few minutes to make sure that nobody was listening.

Ma Terasa: There's a lot of fear here to talk about things. I was displaced from Mira Flores after armed men arrived in our town. I arrived here in San Jose pregnant and had three kids. They also killed my brother when he came to San Jose to go fishing.

There are many kids here who have been raped by the guerrilla and the paramilitaries. Girls have had sticks put in their vaginas that have come out of their mouths. The paramilitaries did that. They have taken children to teach them how to use guns and to teach them how to do bad because that's what they do, they

take away the lives of others. A lot of children have died here in Guaviare, or they have disappeared. I am really careful with my kids because I was threatened in Mira Flores so I keep my children inside. They can go to school then I pick them up and that is it. I work at home to be able to help my family. There's a lot of people who have been killed, in whatever moment you can be killed.

Johanna: *Why do the armed groups kill so many people?*

Ma Teresa: *Well when you have land, where you have a farm they arrive and say well you guys have all of this, get out. So you leave. They take the land, they take the farms. They charge vacunas, taxes, for the cows and if you don't pay them then they kill you. The guerrillas do this and so do the paramilitaries. They rape our daughters without shame. They don't think about being humans, they don't have compassion for anybody. They kill people in cold blood. There was one woman and they cut her up into little pieces because they thought that she was carrying information to the police or the military.*

Johanna: *I have been hearing so many stories like this.*

Ma Teresa: *And you are going to continue hearing them. There are so many stories like this.* (Displaced, age 54, San Jose del Guaviare)

Indeed, throughout my fieldwork I kept hearing stories like Ma Teresa's, of violence that appeared to be all encompassing, filling narratives and defining action. It seemed that there has hardly been a single social sphere, geographical location or group in Colombia that had been spared from violence for any long period of time. Even the upper classes living in less violent areas would still be aware of the violence because of news reports and stories of family members. However, even in the upper-class areas, the threat of armed robbery and gangs was still very much an everyday reality, evident by the high walls around houses and security guards at front gates. The violence was in people's conversations, in the way that they used their words and in the long silences and uncomfortable shifting of eyes at the mention of the armed conflict. The reactions often came instantaneously, without thought or reflection. The nervousness, it seemed, was deeply embedded in their consciousness, a deep understanding of the danger around them that seemed to be known without any conscious reflection. It came from violence that had been part of their histories and collective memories for as long as they could remember and had formed a deep knowledge about the way of the world.

The forms of violence were numerous. Some of the most frequent accounts of violence involved tales of extortion and kidnapping by the vari-

ous armed groups. As of 2016, Colombia was estimated to have the highest rate globally of kidnappings (Cartner et al. 2016). Thousands of innocent civilians have also been victims of open economic extortion, where individuals are kidnapped to be sold back to their families. If the families are not able to pay, then the victims are often killed. Numerous members of the armed forces, police officers, politicians and foreigners have also been kidnapped for political leverage and hostage exchanges (Torres 2008). Marc Gonçalves,¹ an American contractor, was taken hostage after his plane crashed in 2003 on top of a group of FARC in the Colombian countryside. He had been working for the US-Colombian alliance with Plan Colombia that was focusing its efforts on the war on drugs. He was held by the FARC for five and a half years in jungle prison camps and returned to the United States in 2008 after a dramatic hostage rescue known as *Operacion Jaque*. During his time as a hostage, he was guarded by a number of children, one of whom described to Marc the process of executing hostages whose families could not pay the extortion fees:

He told me how sometimes the family members do not have the money to pay the ransom and the FARC does not hold those hostages for a very long time. So if the families can not get the money then they will dig a hole and go and get the hostage. Mono always said when the hostage saw the hole they would always start crying. (Ex-hostage of the FARC, age 44, United States)

Kidnappings spanned all social spheres in Colombia, but those who could be used for political leverage, such as politicians, police officers, military or foreigners, were held the longest. Economic hostages typically came from the middle and lower classes and were used to extort money. Thus, all of my civilian participants expressed a fear of kidnapping, regardless of their social class. However, there were possibly more kidnappings of middle and lower classes simply because they are the majority of the population in Colombia and have fewer financial resources to provide protection for themselves.

Kidnappers have also targeted other groups, such as businesses and large companies. Oil companies have paid over USD\$140 million to guerilla groups (Bartel 2011, p. 9). Human rights defenders, trade unionists, journalists, indigenous and Afro-Colombian leaders and other community activists who oppose the armed groups have also faced death threats (Human Rights Watch 2017). The Special Attorney Jorge Ochoa, who had

¹ Marc gave permission to use his full name.

several assassination attempts made on him after convicting notorious drug lord Pablo Escobar, claimed that more than 1000 members of the Colombian judicial system were in serious danger (Fukumi 2016). In the early 1990s, when the violence was at its height, there were more than 28,000 violent deaths and in 2002 the homicide rate was 66 per 100,000 people (Tate 2007, p. 33). Colombia was one of the most dangerous places in the world to be a trade unionist, with almost 4000 members assassinated between 1986 and 2003. The National Union School concluded that nearly 80% of the trade unionists killed between 1991 and 2002 were murdered for their labour activity (Aviles 2006, p. 403). Most of these killings were attributed to paramilitary groups and Carlos Castano, the first leader of the paramilitary, admitted that, 'we kill trade unionists because they interfere with people working' (Aviles, *ibid.*). The extreme and widespread nature of the violence has led international human rights groups to claim Colombia has some of the highest levels of human rights violations globally (Cartner et al. 2016).

Widespread corruption has also characterised Colombia's world of violence. There have been reports of Colombian judicial officials working in conjunction with the various armed groups. One of the Cali Cartel's leaders, Gilberto Rodriguez Orejuela, said 'we don't kill judges or ministers, we buy them' (Fukumi 2016, p. 15). Paramilitary groups have also widely been reported to have collaborated with the government. As a result, paramilitaries have enjoyed impunity and increased economic and political power (Human Rights Watch 2005). There have been numerous reports of government officials, including the police and the military, participating in the violence. Human Rights Watch (2017) reported that the Attorney General's Office was investigating thousands of cases of unlawful killings, with the majority of those convicted being low-level soldiers. Senior army officers involved in the killings are often able to escape prosecution and are even promoted through military ranks. The corruption and inequality perpetrated by government forces became evident throughout my fieldwork. While attending a peace march one afternoon in Medellin, I stopped to speak to a group of men from Uraba. One of the men narrated a story of how a group of government military soldiers had raped some of the little girls and women near where he lived. They had reported the incident to the military, but the military refused to acknowledge that their soldiers had carried out the rapes. He looked at me with frustration and said, 'what can we do when it is the government soldiers doing this?'

PERFORMATIVE VIOLENCE, DRUG TRAFFICKING, COCAINE

One of the most notable factors about the violence in Colombia was that it often seemed to be carried out in excessive and extreme forms. The tales of violence from my participants were frequent and always seemed to be filled with brutality. Taussig (1984, p. 487) has famously described Colombia as having a culture of terror and being a 'space of death' because of the constant presence of fear, uncertainty and terror throughout the country. Italian anthropologist Aldo Civico (2003, p. 4) also describes a culture of terror and speaks of paramilitary groups that have burned people alive or killed people with machetes. Even though the paramilitary groups were not visible on the street, he writes that their presence was felt and fear would fill the emptiness of people's words.

Ulrich Oslender (2008, p. 82) also emphasises the extreme nature of the violence in Colombia. He describes riverine environments, such as in Colombia's Pacific coast region, where dead bodies would float downstream, getting washed out into the open sea or becoming stuck in the mangrove swamps in the estuaries. There were empty spaces left after people fled and abandoned their villages, fearful of persecution and massacres. 'The disappeared, the incised body parts, missing family members, burned out towns all created a void that horrifies by its senselessness and brutality', he writes (Oslender, *ibid.*). They create 'silent spaces' as Nordstrom (2004) describes in her work on the civil war in Mozambique, left by the disappeared in war that creates a knowledge that torture has taken place that is so horrifying it cannot be described within normal social dialogue and 'cultural metalogue'. The stories throughout my fieldwork reflected these observations; I heard many stories of bodies being thrown in river, chopped into pieces by merciless paramilitary members, and civilians being displaced from their homes. I saw houses lying abandoned outside the cities, burned down, 'displaced by the conflict', informants explained.

Narratives of fear from the violence with the armed groups seemed to be present throughout the stories of my informants. They describe how the violence was different depending on the perpetrators. One afternoon in CAE as we sat at the lunch table I listened as Rosalba, the secretary and Lena, one of the psychologists, casually compared the types of violence that they had grown up with. Rosalba had grown up in Popayan where the FARC had had a heavy presence. She described how the FARC would arrive in towns with a list of names of people who had been chosen to be killed. They would also engage in activities such as 'miracle fishing', where they

stopped random cars and trucks and kidnapped those they perceived to be wealthy. Lena compared this type of organised violence to the uncertainty of living in Medellín during the time of Pablo Escobar, when drug traffickers and paramilitary groups dominated and one never knew when a bomb was going to go off or where a random shooting by one of the armed groups might take place. The paramilitaries were renowned for chopping up their victims alive, targeting guerrilla supporters and innocent civilians who would get caught in their countless massacres and mutilations. Such strategies were used in Argentina during the military dictatorship in the 1970s and 1980s to the same effect (Mendez 2012).

Silvia, a former guerrilla who grew up on a farm near San Jose del Guaviare, in an area where there were much poverty and heavy presence of the guerrilla, explained during our interview that it was violence from the paramilitary that led her to join the FARC. She entered the FARC when she was 17 and left when she was captured by the government when she was 34 years old. She spoke highly of the FARC and said that she felt proud to be part of the group. Her decision to join the FARC came out of a desire for revenge after the paramilitaries murdered some of her family members:

The paramilitaries killed my family in San Jose del Guaviare. They would throw small children into the air and catch them on knives. They would cut people open and pull out their insides while they were still alive. We were afraid of the paramilitaries. (Former child guerrilla, age 34, Florencia)

Her face contorted in disgust as she told the story and it was evident that the effects of the violence by the paramilitary groups had run deep, even after these many years. A conversation with Adriel, a priest working with disadvantaged youth in one of the paramilitary neighbourhoods, also highlighted the nature of violence by the armed groups in Colombia. Once we settled down in a space near his office where we could not be heard, he described how the neighbourhood had been affected by the violence between the multiple armed groups who had taken turns in dominating it. He observed:

There's a lot of unemployment here in Buenaventura which is in part because of the conflict. The guerrilla are here and they have a urban block so that they can extort the port. This neighborhood we're in now was a guerrilla area before. But then one of the groups of paramilitaries arrived, Bloque Calima and this has created an incredible violence here, massacres, murders, forced disappearances.

Here at least half the population are victims of the armed conflict. They are displaced, they have been forced to join an armed group, they have had someone killed, they have been sexually abused, they have had someone disappeared and they have been threatened. Whatever type of violence you can imagine, most of the population have been affected directly by this.

Halfway through our conversation a woman interrupted us to say hello to the priest. After she left he continued:

You see that woman, her son worked for the guerrilla. They lived here in this area. But the police took him and he became an informer for the police. I had to get him out of here because the guerrilla were going to kill him. So I took him to Bogota and put him in a children's home. But he returned because he missed his mother and it was the paramilitaries who killed him. They killed him in front of his mother, he was just 14 years old.

Ayde, a teacher living in a guerrilla-held area in Guaviare, also spoke of the fear of growing up there:

The FARC killed my husband and my brother. They make up things as reasons to kill people, they said that my brother was a rebel. And my husband, people were saying things, they invented things and they killed him. This part of the conflict is really difficult. If you don't share their ideology, you can't say to them I don't agree with your ideology, if you say this then you have to leave. To be able to live in this area then you have to work with them.

Johanna: *Is there police or army where you are living?*

Ayde: *No. Only the guerrilla, they're in charge.*

Johanna: *Why do the people live there?*

Ayde: *Because it's a place where you can survive. There's poverty everywhere.*

Johanna: *So what are some of the rules there?*

Ayde: *Don't think differently from them and accept everything that they say. You have to pay fines as a punishment. It was really difficult before; it's gotten a little bit better.*

Johanna: *Do you think that the children are afraid?*

Ayde: *They have grown up with this.*

Johanna: *Do you feel afraid?*

She is silent for a moment and says:

Yes. But I have to work there. (age 42, San Jose del Guaviare)

Throughout my fieldwork, I asked all of my participants, both those who had been in the armed groups and those who had not, why the violence was so extreme. The most frequent and common reply often came with a shrug of the shoulders and a simple, 'I do not know'. However, terror committed by armed factions is rarely just violence for the sake of it (Thornton 1964). Paul Richards (1996), who writes on violence during the civil war in Sierra Leone, argues that terror can be used as a performance to gain power. By performing extreme acts of violence, armed groups can compensate for a lack of weapons and manpower as a way of gaining control over civilian populations by terrifying them into submission. He gives the example in Sierra Leone where cannibalism was used as a highly effective means of frightening local populations and the enemy (Richards 1996). Krijn Peters (2006), who writes on child combatants with the RUF in Sierra Leone, said that fighters would shoot heavily, not because they had many bullets, but to frighten the enemy and give the impression that there are many rebels taking part in the attack. Terrified, civilians submit to the will of the armed group.

Anthropologists have long attempted to understand violence through its role as a performance and how even apparently senseless violence can 'make sense' in relation to the cultural context in which it is being enacted (Kapferer 1988). 'Rituals of provocation', as described by Gaborieau (1985), can be acts of deliberate disrespect, desecration or violation of sacred or symbolically charged spaces or times and are performed to enact violence. The connection between violence and symbolism has a long history; for example, Davis (1973) shows how 'rites of violence' in the religious riots of sixteenth-century France had ritualised and symbolic meaning as different forms of mutilation took place such as hacking off body parts and the desecration of corpses. Appadurai (1998) discusses what he calls 'intimate killing' as a search for understanding the extreme and argues that violence aims to destroy not only the body but the being of the victim.

In the case of Colombia, the use of dramatic performances of violence by the armed groups has served a purpose. With lucrative profits to be made from the country's vast resources, in particular cocaine, gaining access over the land and drug trafficking routes has been a primary goal for the armed groups. Paul Collier and Anke Hoeffler (2004) show that natural resources,

particularly highly lucrative resources such as oil, diamonds and coal, are key factors that produce violence and lead to the establishment of armed groups. When there are great economic benefits to be gained from natural resources, then it is likely that armed actors will emerge to challenge the government for control over those resources (Sanchez 2006). In Colombia, cocaine is the primary resource over which armed groups have fought for control, and it is estimated to produce 50% of the world's cocaine (UNODC 2017, p. 25). The drug trade first emerged in the late 1960s and grew largely uninhibited by the state until the mid-1980s, predominantly in the cities of Medellin and Cali (Gill 2009). The violence in the cities intensified as traffickers began to fight over trafficking routes and have continued to be one of the primary sources of violence throughout Colombia.

Buenaventura has become particularly infamous in Colombia for its extraordinary levels of violence, linked to its many resources. As one of the key port cities in Colombia, it produces around 48% of the national income and around \$1 million of revenue (Hristov 2009, p. 22). As a result, all the illegal armed groups are present there, seeking access to the port to export their illegal goods as well as extort local businesses and control the drug routes in the city. The violence in the city has been described by Human Rights Watch (2015) as systematic and endemic, as paramilitary groups have extorted, murdered and committed acts of sexual violence. Civilians have often been caught in the middle as the armed groups have battled for control over territory and they have been threatened with death or kidnapping if suspected of being an informer.

On one occasion, in a paramilitary-controlled neighbourhood on the outskirts of Buenaventura, I witnessed children playing games taking other children hostage. 'It's what they see', one elderly man told me. Buenaventura has, however, perhaps become the most well known for its 'chop houses', which are small, wooden structures which form slums above the sea on Buenaventura's coast. In grotesque performances of violence, the paramilitaries take their victims to small houses where they are chopped into pieces and then thrown into the sea (Human Rights Watch 2015). As a result, Buenaventura has one of the highest rates of forced displacement in Colombia. Indeed, throughout Buenaventura, houses lay in rubble, its inhabitants displaced, 'because of the conflict', explained a taxi driver. An estimated 12,956 residents fled their homes in 2015, and 1955 fled in 2016 (Human Rights Watch 2017).

The FARC have also been heavily involved in the production and sale of cocaine and have been reported to place taxes on coca farmers and steal from traffickers (Henderson 2015). In Hesterman's (2013) book looking at global networks of terrorism and drug cartels, she reports that the FARC have been linked to Mexican cartels as well as groups such as Hezbollah and al-Qaeda. The FARC have also reportedly had close ties with the Venezuelan government and trafficked drugs through Venezuela into the United States and the western coast of Africa and then into Europe. Remote-controlled submarines have been used in part to move drugs into Central America and Mexico. Hesterman also estimates that at least one half of the FARC's illegal worth of USD\$500–\$600 million annually comes from drug cultivation and trafficking while the rest comes from kidnapping, extortion and other criminal activities.

Many of the children with whom I worked at CAE reported their own involvement with drug trafficking either before they joined the FARC or while they were part of it. Take the following conversation with Yahir, for example:

Yahir: *The FARC and the ELN transport cocaine together.*

Johanna: *So the FARC grows a lot of cocaine?*

Yahir: *Ohhhh yes.*

Johanna: *Did you have to work in this?*

Yahir: *Yes. I didn't grow it, the campesinos grow it. I only sold it.* (Former child guerrilla, age 17, Manizales)

Other participants also talked about the drug trade. Marly, a 30-year-old veterinarian in Bogota, who grew up with the ELN in the north of Colombia, explained:

The ELN say that they want the same thing as the FARC, they want to form their own government. They survive with cocaine. I think that they are fighting to have control over the drug trafficking. They were saying that they are socialists fighting to overtake the government but now they kidnap and they sell drugs.

Johanna: *Why do people agree with them if they are just narco traffickers?*

Marlly: *Because there is no other option. They have the guns and they have the money. If you don't agree with them then things are going to go very badly.* (Vet, age 30, Bogota)

Violence, when used in culturally specific ways, can operate as a mode of communication through which actors seek to produce social transformation by staging symbolic acts of violence. Violence is used as a performance, as a way of communicating to the wider community about who holds the monopoly over violence, which in turn shows who holds the monopoly over power. With the civilians terrified into submission, the armed groups have then been able to take control of their land to gain access to the resources on that land. In my conversation with Adriel, the priest in Buenaventura, he explained the role of fear in the armed groups' quest for control over resources:

Johanna: *How do people manage the fear?*

Adriel: *They get used to it after so many years, well they're afraid, me too, I'm afraid.*

Johanna: *Why is there so much violence in Colombia?*

Adriel: *Terror, fear, control. They want to control. In Colombia there have been worse things.*

Johanna: *Like what?*

Adriel: *Like drinking the blood of people. Cutting off the heads of campesinos. Cutting people up and feeding them to the crocodiles.* (Priest, age 42, Buenaventura)

As Adriel described, armed actors show their willingness to use extreme brutality and their willingness to overcome social restrictions on killing to create fear amongst civilian populations. It shows others what will happen to them should they move against the wishes of the armed groups. As Scarry (1985, p. 23) has described it, 'torture silences and wrecks language, obliterating words and writing and thereby describing experience'. Thus, as dead, mutilated and tortured bodies become part of the daily reality, the destructive nature of the violence reminds people that they are powerless, that silence and conformity are the only options for survival. It is through the fear of being subject to both physical and ontological harm that one can be terrorised into submission and armed groups can sustain their power

over others (Civico 2016). In this way, armed groups have had the ability to maintain control not only over the physical bodies of individuals but over the ontological aspects that provide meaning and well-being to individuals. They can essentially hold control over people's lifeworlds.

These very public displays of violence are significant in the context of militarisation and child recruitment for two reasons. Firstly, because the violence has been so extreme and so encompassing, it has been a significant factor in forming the backdrop of the children's lifeworld. Secondly, through the constant repetition of the violence in the children's world, it has become normalised. As stories of violence are repeated through the narratives of their parents and grandparents, violence becomes embedded in the general stock knowledge of that group and eventually sediments into the background knowledge of the children, forming their understanding of the way that the world is. Through the violence the individual becomes linked to the subjective experience of the broader world, binding individuals of that world together. In this way, violence has the means to play a significant role in *making* lifeworlds and becoming part of the collective consciousness of those living within those lifeworlds. The use of extreme violence, then, seems not only natural but inevitable. Within this context, entering into a violent armed group will seem a relatively natural step to take. However, the violence has also had much deeper ramifications on the social worlds of young people living within these contexts, which I will explore below.

STRUCTURAL INEQUALITIES AND VIOLENCE

'*Una vida digna*', a dignified life, was a phrase I heard multiple times throughout my fieldwork. I saw it scrawled on the side of walls; I heard it being spoken at conferences and in everyday conversations. Jose Daniel, former child combatant and educator at CAE, met me for coffee at one of the local cafes in the centre of Medellin and our conversation turned to the structural inequalities so prevalent throughout the country:

There are families who have very little money, they don't have the money to live a dignified life, if you don't have a dignified place to live in that is very difficult. If you don't have a dignified life then society will reject you. So it's really complicated. (age 22, Medellin)

Throughout the testimonies of all of my participants, like Jose Daniel, ran a narrative of poverty. Jose Daniel had grown up in poverty and into his adult life it was still prevalent. It was a consistent and widespread factor that he saw affecting people throughout Colombia. For those who joined the armed groups, poverty was always part of their life histories. One afternoon I sat outside the front of CAE with Paula and Mariana, two former child combatants. We spoke about Cagua, the department where both Mariana and Paula had grown up and joined the guerrilla. The girls expressed their frustration at the lack of opportunities in their lives. Both came from poverty-stricken areas of Colombia where there were limited opportunities for both education and employment. They wanted to be doctors, but due to the lack of educational opportunities it was unlikely. The structural conditions in their environment were inflicting suffering by stopping them from achieving the goals that they desired. This is known as structural violence, which refers to systematic ways in which social structures harm or otherwise disadvantage individuals (Farmer 2004). Structures in this sense are patterns of collective social action that have achieved a degree of permanence that has become firmly entrenched in habits, social relations, economic arrangements, institutional practices, laws and policy (Bourgois 2001). Structural violence is essentially the forms of suffering and injustice that are deeply embedded in the ordinary, that are often the result of long political, economic and social histories as is the case in Colombia.

Colombia is one of the most unequal countries in Latin America. Poverty is widespread with a significant proportion of the country living below the national poverty line (Espinosa and Landau 2017). In areas affected by the conflict, the destruction of infrastructure and widespread forced displacement have led to many inequalities, most notably in education (OECD 2017, p. 31). Rural conditions in Colombia are particularly difficult with widespread poverty that is exacerbated by the economic liberalisation that occurred in the 1990s to grow investment (Aviles 2006). The government privatised state-owned enterprises, deregulated labour markets and lowered tariffs which affected rural life. There was a decline in the country's manufacturing sector by 22% in the 10 years following and coffee prices collapsed, which led to a weakened agrarian economy consequently increasing poverty in rural areas (Aviles 2006). Many agrarian workers were forced to abandon their traditional crops and seek alternative means of survival—largely drug production or joining the guerrilla groups or paramilitaries (Aviles 2006, p. 391). In 2000, the problem was exacerbated by the implementation of Plan Colombia, a USD\$1.3 billion package to increase

fumigation of coca crops and to intervene in the war against drugs and the guerrilla. The plan received criticism after many small farmers' legal crops were fumigated, which again added to displacement, unemployment and inequality and forced peasants to find alternative sources of survival such as drug production or joining an armed group (Gray 2008).

The link between poverty, violence and child recruitment became evident during my fieldwork. A conversation with Jorge, a young teacher in Villavicencio, illustrates how weak governance has contributed to the many problems found throughout Colombia:

There are so many people who want to study but they can't. If the government would invest more in education then they would keep people's minds so busy and they would be busy thinking about how they can make the world better but they are not, people's minds are relaxing. Things could be really different if the government is there to take care of you. But the government here in Colombia isn't doing that. They just care about power.

Many of my participants spoke of the corruption that is entrenched in the Colombian government, which they blamed for the long-running insurgency within the country. Former guerrilla member Oscar Gomez linked structural inequalities with joining an armed group. Oscar joined the FARC as an adult when he was picking coca leaves in Tomachipan in Guaviare. The area was heavily dominated by guerrilla and when they came around looking for recruits they convinced him to join them:

People need a job. This is one major problem in Colombia is unemployment. There are people who are very capable but can't find a job. So what do they do, they rob, they form bands. This is one of the biggest problems. There are no opportunities.
(age 52, San Jose del Guaviare)

All of the former guerrilla with whom I worked came from the rural areas of Colombia and, like Mariana and Paula, they described homes shaped by class deprivation and little access to cultural or economic resources where joining an armed group was one of the few options. As mentioned, this was a consistent factor throughout the narratives of the former combatants. They described environments of economic desolation where the rule of law was one of the armed groups. Farming was an option but so was narco-trafficking, which was far more lucrative. Eduardo was with the FARC for 10 years and joined when he was 11 years old because of the difficult

circumstances in his life. His parents were separated, his father had left and with his mother and siblings he experienced economic difficulties:

It is common for families to have a lot of children, though this is starting to change. The problem is that there are many separated families in Colombia and it is often in these cases that you see children becoming involved with the conflict and the armed groups. When children do not get a lot of attention from their parents, they often become involved with armed groups. There also isn't access to education. There are no universities. There is also no presence of the government. The military are sometimes there but when they are there they are often starting fights which creates an environment of hate. So psychologically this creates a difficult environment for the people living there. Women have been raped and people have been killed. So it is in these situations that people get involved with the FARC. (Former guerrilla, age 27, Florencia)

What Eduardo was describing, as did many of my participants, was a home life where the earliest observations of life were filled with physical and structural violence.

Considering the importance of understanding the social environments in which the children from the armed groups came from, one of my primary goals during the second phase of my research was to visit some of these areas. While it was difficult to travel to the areas where the highest rate of child recruitment was taking place, I was able to travel to a number of the urban areas which were safer. One was San Jose de Apartado in Uraba, which had been heavily affected by the armed conflict in the past and had seen much child recruitment. Some of the children at CAE were from that town, which is well known throughout Colombia as a site of intense violence where massacres were carried out at the hands of both the Colombian army and the paramilitary forces. With assurances from locals that it was safe to visit, I travelled to the small town where I spent the afternoon visiting a group known as the community of peace. They had declared that they would have no part of the Colombian conflict and armed groups were not permitted to enter. There I met with Jesus and he invited me to his home to talk. As we sat down on a wooden bench in his garden, I pulled out my notebook and asked him about his perspectives on the Colombian conflict. He told me:

The majority of the crimes in Colombia are committed by the government, 85% by the government and 15% by the guerrilla. Most of the victims are the campesinos because the armed actors always come into steal the land. It's an economic war,

it's a war over land. There have been many massacres, I want to know why the government has killed so many people? The story of Colombia is death, death, death. Kids are beings killed and kids are having their parents killed in front of them. Here in this community we're trying to resist this. The government and the military don't respect our views but we want things to be more fair in Colombia, we want the human rights abuses to stop. Colombia is one of the most violent countries in the world. One of our problems is our resources, the more resources that they take out the more deaths there are. Here in this area we have petroleum and carbon. The military make the campesinos plant coca here and then they come and tax them. Plan Colombia is not to stop the drug trade but just to stop the guerrilla from planning drugs so that the government can control the drug trade. If the campesinos don't pay the taxes to the military the military say they will denounce them, so everyone stays quiet. The war in Colombia is not because of the guerrilla but is because of the social inequality. If you don't have education, you don't have food; wouldn't you want to be part of an armed group?

He invited me into have lunch with his family and led me into a very small ramshackle house. It had been roughly put together with wood and there was an old stone kitchen where his wife was cooking and several children were there. He led me down a small hallway and there was an old lady sitting in a hammock whom he introduced as his mother. He asked me to sit down with her while he went to make the food. She was probably in her eighties and had deep lines running through her face. Behind her was a wall made of wooden planks and a large spider web was spun behind her. I could barely understand her but the words *soldados* and *matar* and *miedo*, soldiers, kill and fear came through clearly. She was telling me a story about soldiers coming onto their land and the distress on her face was evident. I was eventually called to eat and we all sat with one of Jesus's daughters. His wife and other children sat at a small table nearby. He explained that he had around 50 children and had had so many so that they could be workers on his land. After we finished eating, he showed me a photo of his child who had been shot by the government army.

The afternoon I spent with Jesus and his family highlighted some of the key themes in the Colombian conflict and children's involvement. He spoke of an environment shaped by violence of the illegal armed groups and the Colombian government. He spoke of the problem of resources and the role of Colombia's lucrative cocaine trade that has fuelled the violence. He spoke of poverty and a lack of education, all factors which, as he said, have played a fundamental role in drawing children into conflict. As Boyden and Mann (2005) argue, continuous war destroys the social fabric

of societies and generates a chronic state of poverty that gradually becomes rooted in families and communities in vicious cycles. When everyday places, such as the schoolyard, the home and playground become staging grounds for military activity, it becomes inevitable that some children will become drawn into the cycle (see also Derluyn et al. 2013; Reed 2014). However, what was the most notable about my experience with Jesus and indeed many of my participants was that all of our conversation took place in front of the children. It is in this way children learn about the violent environments in which they live, contributing to the formation of their lifeworlds.

HONOUR, GUNS AND CHILD RECRUITMENT

Throughout the testimonies of my participants, many suggested that attaining a dignified life was linked to economic wealth, something which most, if not all of the former guerrilla felt was out of their reach. Conversely, not being able to attain a means of living a dignified life led to feelings of powerlessness, humiliation and injustice. Jose Daniel explained:

If we had the opportunities to access opportunities then things would be different. Everything is in money, in power. The violence is always there because there isn't enough education. With my son for example, I always want to be able to offer him whatever he needs but I'm really worried about the education he will get. He's living in one of the poorest neighborhoods in Cali at the moment and everything that is around him is not good. So say for example there is a kid who is born in Poblado then he is going to have a different life, they will have everything that they need, there won't be any need to steal, there is a big difference from a kid who is born here.

Opportunities for education and living a dignified life were something that Jose Daniel did not feel he was able to access for himself or for his son. For many of the children in CAE, gaining a sense of worth, honour and prestige within the social context of Colombia was something that they believed out of their grasp. One afternoon during a girls' group in CAE for example, several of the girls expressed a desire to study at university but felt that it was unachievable because of their inability to pay the university fees. They also expressed concerns about fitting in because they believed they were from a different social class than the other students. Higher education was a goal for these young girls, but they lacked the finances and social position.

Being 'worthy', it seemed, was linked with not only coming from a certain social class but also with having a certain amount of economic capital.

For young people who have grown up in a world that has been defined by poverty and inequality, finding an alternate means of attaining social worth, such as joining an armed group, may then seem very attractive. Peter Singer (2006) argues that when children are humiliated, lack proper schooling and see a future with no opportunities, they are more likely to become involved with violent groups. Abby Hardgrove (2017) shows how youth in Liberia joined armed groups as a means of attaining cultural understandings of honour and respect. Liberians came to value parts of American culture, which over time became associated with elite society. For many of Liberia's youth, poverty denied them the opportunity to acquire the social skill associated with elite status. The result was a strong sense of social exclusion and a desire to attain status by any other means, such as joining an armed group. Henrik Vigh (2010, p. 9) likewise found that young armed combatants in Guinea Bissau joined armed groups due to a lack of opportunities and economic difficulties that made them unable to fulfil socially required processes of social becoming. Voluntary mobilisation into the armed groups became not only a means for survival, but also a way of social becoming. It is not only in situations of conflict that this process of responding to structural inequalities happens. Philippe Bourgois' (2003) work on slums in Harlem, in the United States, also shows how poverty as well as political and economic exclusion led young people to develop a sense of powerlessness which pushed many of them to seek alternative means self-empowerment and survival, such as drug dealing.

For young people in Colombia growing up in an environment where they have largely felt powerless, while observing power and respect being attained through the use of violence, becoming violent may seem very attractive. Uribe (2004) observed the way in which respect was given to people in Colombia who had gained reputations for being violent. Gangs and guerrilla leaders who committed repeated massacres inspired fear and terror amongst peasants but were also admired by them. A conversation with a taxi driver on the north coast of Colombia highlighted to me how poverty and an inability to attain culturally desired means of earning respect are linked to child recruitment. As we made our way down the windy road through the forest to Santa Marta, we started to talk about poverty in Colombia. He felt that much of the violence was related to fathers not taking responsibility for their children and added:

There are many children growing up in Colombia growing up without enough food and without feeling that they are loved by their parents. When the armed groups come along and offer them food, a uniform and a sense of belonging, they go for it. Boys find that with a gun and a uniform they can suddenly find a girlfriend though to keep this power he must do what the guerrilla want. If the guerrilla ask him to kill, he must kill.

One of the indicators that children chose to join armed groups as a means of attaining social worth was through a commonly expressed desire for a gun. Their explanations were usually centred around the feeling of power attained from having a gun. In a conversation with Marlon, mentioned earlier, in Nieva he explained:

Johanna: *Did you understand who the FARC were and that you were going to fight for Colombia?*

Marlon: *No, I just wanted guns. I didn't know about their ideology or their revolution. I knew that my father was there but he died there. I didn't go there to be a revolutionary.*

Johanna: *I have never wanted a gun.*

Marlon: *Yes, but you come from somewhere where you have everything.*

Johanna: *So you want a gun because you have nothing?*

He seemed taken aback by the question and paused for a moment before agreeing with me.

Marlon: *Yes*

I believe that Marlon was not quite sure why he desired a gun and this was a meaningful moment of realisation for him. From what I could gather of Marlon's story before joining the FARC, his family life had been difficult. The desire for a gun, I believe, largely came from a desire to find a means to escape the poverty in which he was entrenched and to gain a sense of social worth that he was largely unable to attain from his broader environment. The gun was a symbol of power through which he could communicate to others around him. It symbolised masculinity, status, social advantage, attention and respect. These are qualities that Marlon and many other young people felt were lacking growing up in the midst of structural poverty

and violence. As much was reflected in the rest of my conversation with Marlon:

Johanna: *Why do you think that the other kids went to the FARC?*

Marlon: *They go because they want guns. Not because of the ideology.*

Johanna: *Why do they want guns?*

Marlon: *I don't know. They see films about guns and so they want to go.*

Johanna: *They think that it's going to be the same as movies?*

Marlon: *Of course. If you're on a farm and you hear the bullets you think ooo I want to be there. You don't care if it's with the army or the guerrilla fighting in uniform. They want to feel powerful. Here in Colombia the people have the mentality to be bad, to be famous but for being bad, they want to be on the news. The people like this. To feel like they've been recognized because they're a guerrilla, a commander or a drug trafficker.*

Marlon's desire for power was directly linked to the idea that to be a guerrilla, a commander or a drug trafficker will bring status. Similar motivations have been found in Liberia and Sierra Leone where youth join armed insurgencies by connecting themselves to feared warlords because of the advantages such as being able to attain loot, bribes and girlfriends (Boas 2014). In Colombia, joining an armed group was a means of gaining social capital. This is reflected in this comment by Marly:

They would go for the easy money. It's also a social status for them. Because they would have a good social status in the town because they would get a gun and they had money. If you don't have money then you don't have social status. You can't ask out girls. You can't have a motorbike, this is very important for them.
(Vet, age 30, Bogota)

Marly and I also shared many conversations about the role of women in Colombian society and how the conflict had affected women. The following observation by Marly highlights how the culture of machismo along with the conflict and drug trafficking have played a role in shaping how women believe they are able to achieve social status:

Women are seen as sexual objects. There is a lot of machismo. In the coast a girl leaving to go to a party alone is a prostitute. Bogota isn't as machista as other

parts of the country but I have heard cases of sexual abuse. To have a woman who looks a certain way gives social status to a man. This is especially the case for poor women, many women try to get a specific kind of body because they want to be attractive to narco traffickers because they have a lot of money. All of this began with the narco trafficking. Most people don't think about this, they don't think that this standard of beauty is part of the conflict here in Colombia.

This is linked to the culture of machismo. Another female participant, Monica, explains:

What we don't see a lot in the countryside is families teaching their daughters that they deserve to be respected and that they don't teach them to respect their bodies. What families mostly want as soon as the girl is old enough that she finds a partner and gets married. Women get treated as sexual objects.

The lack of opportunities means that most girls won't try to do something with their lives, they'll look for a husband and stay in the house because they don't feel that there is anything else that they can do with their life. (Teacher in guerrilla-held area, age 44, San Jose del Guaviare)

The presence of the armed groups and their informants has destroyed existing ties of unity, solidarity and trust in communities and instead replaces them with isolation and terror. Children are left to navigate the difficult and complex social environment where it is difficult to survive and attain culturally constructed means of dignity and respect. For many of Colombia's children living in such a context, entrance into a guerrilla group, the attainment of a gun and the possibility of becoming a feared warlord therefore allow them the possibility to achieve dignity, respect and social worth that they would most likely be unable to achieve otherwise. In such a context, military life and the use of violence become part of the 'of coursesness', of the everyday common sense knowledge of children living in the militarised world. This process blurs the lines between the children's lifeworld and the world of the guerrilla, making the transition for children who choose to join an armed group a relatively smooth one.

CONCLUSION

I have argued in this chapter that violence, poverty and structural inequalities perpetuate a social world that is conducive to child recruitment and militarisation in Colombia. Violence, whether it has been performed by

the armed groups, drug lords or produced through government economic reforms, has eroded social systems leaving many children with few opportunities for a meaningful and dignified life. However, violence is also a source of attaining power. Armed groups have used extraordinary levels of perverse and extreme violence as a way to control resources and gain power. By joining an armed group, young people can reduce the power imbalances in their lives and find a way of achieving social status by accessing the power attained from the armed groups. Furthermore, through the intertwining of violence and social structures, violence has become normalised which has played a significant role in the militarisation process for the FARC. As will be explored in the following chapter, violence is a key factor in constructing guerrilla identity, so having recruits that regard violence as an acceptable recourse is essential for the FARC. As the violent nature of the armed group is much the same as the violent environment in which they have grown, the transition into an armed group is relatively smooth. There is no need for the guerrilla groups to break down recruits and deconstruct their identities in order to adapt to violence, as seen in many other guerrilla and armed group movements, because the environment from which the child recruit has come is already violent. As will be explored in the next chapter, the task for the FARC commanders is to complete this process, that is, merge the identity of the FARC and the identity of the child.

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CHAPTER 6

‘I’m a Soldier’: Life Inside the Armed Group

‘They don’t see a different world. They just see the guerrilla.’ Javier Porras, police officer kidnapped by the FARC for 9 years and 8 months.

INTRODUCTION

To be successful, armed movements must ensure that recruits internalise and adopt the values, norms and practices of the militarised world. They must convince young recruits that what they are fighting for is legitimate and worth risking their lives for. There must be ways to initiate and maintain feelings of loyalty and group coherence in order to achieve the military goals of the group as well as minimise the risk of desertion (Peters 2011). This chapter explores the second part of the militarisation process of young people who join the FARC. Drawing on participants’ narratives, this chapter examines the processes used by the FARC to draw children into their lifeworld and how they ensure that their new recruits attach to the guerrillas and take on the guerrillas’ identity. I will look at how the FARC ensures loyalty and attachment to the group by creating a sense of solidarity and cohesion through the use of broader structural and historical factors that revolve around violence and poverty. These include increasing divisions between classes, the use of historical memories, the creation of an ‘other’ and physical training. Through these processes, the FARC legitimise themselves and it is through the acceptance of this legitimacy that

the young recruits become drawn into the lifeworld of the FARC. This chapter therefore aims to demonstrate the ways in which the final stage of militarisation occurs inside the armed group through the construction of a militarised guerrilla identity.

ARMED GROUPS, VIOLENCE AND COLLECTIVE IDENTITY

Before I examine the specific circumstances of recruitment into the FARC, this section considers the wider literature on individuals' motivations for becoming involved in violence, in particular with armed groups. The underlying success of any armed group is to have a pool from which they can recruit members who see themselves as fighters with a desire to kill an enemy. Soldiers must be willing to use forms of violence that might not be considered to be legitimate in peacetime, which include killing. Richard Norman (1995) argues that there is a moral consensus within cultures throughout the world that one of the most deep-rooted features of being human is the recognition of the wrongness of killing another human being. It is generally assumed to be a morally unacceptable act that transgresses the boundaries of being human. Elaine Scarry (1985, p. 122) writes that by killing, one destroys the most fundamental agreements about how to live within civilisation. To kill, Scarry suggests, is to divest oneself of civilisation and to reverse learned and deeply embodied physical impulses that are supposed to regulate relations to other people's bodies. This is most likely because killing is seen as an extreme measure that is reserved for highly limited circumstances (Fuji 2009). Thus, while there may be exceptions throughout the world, killing is generally seen to be a morally and socially unacceptable act. For one to be able to kill, one must believe that to kill another is legitimate. For military commanders, creating soldiers who are willing to kill and use extreme acts of violence is a central task for military commanders as an essential part of achieving military objectives is primarily the defeat of the enemy.

David Grossman (2009), a former soldier and a professor of psychology at the US Military Academy at West Point, draws on his own battle experience as well on interviews with veterans of American wars since World War II. He argues that the real trauma of war is not about being killed but about killing, and most new soldiers face difficulties in being able to take the life of another person, even if it is an enemy. A boundary must therefore be crossed in war where soldiers must participate in violent acts that they would not do in peacetime (Halden and Jackson 2016). Martin van Creveld

(2009) advances a functionalist explanation of soldiering rituals and suggests that they enable individuals to consciously cross a cultural boundary, without which they will struggle with what mental frames they can use to approach both reality and life as a soldier. Not having clear boundaries would blur the line between murdering another human being and entering into combat and killing as part of your duty as a soldier. In this functionalist interpretation, the rituals are needed to increase performance levels and the effectiveness of soldiers as well as to protect their psychological well-being. Michael Ignatieff (1988) also suggests that they are necessary to create and establish honour in war and thus to create righteousness in killing.

Peter Halden and Peter Jackson (2016), in *Transforming warriors: The ritual organization of military force*, focus on how ritual practices and symbolic shifts entail a change of world views, identities and patterns of action. They argue that the military sphere must be understood as something more than a profession; rather, it is a lifeworld in the phenomenological sense in which the individual's experience of the world is created by cultural and historical patterns. Creating warriors is therefore about establishing new roles in a particular lifeworld, not only through training and education or ideology but through symbolic action. Military reality is created through narratives, symbols and bodily practices (Ben-Ari and Lomsky-Feder 1999). A transformation must take place between the civilian lifeworld and the military lifeworld as in the case of Colombian youth who join the FARC.

Getting soldiers to cross this boundary between the civil and military spheres in part involves armed groups being able to create a sense of legitimacy and purpose in what they are doing. They must be able to build loyalty and create a sense of cohesion and unity amongst their recruits. This is often best achieved through the creation of a collective identity, and in the FARC, violence has been a central tool in this process. While the FARC claims to be a peasant organisation that is fighting for the 'liberation' of the *campesino* and for justice in Colombia, as will be discussed in greater depth below, few Colombians I met throughout my fieldwork believed the FARC still had any legitimate call to arms. While it was commonly believed that they had started out with noble aspirations to improve Colombia and fight for the rural poor, it was now commonly believed that they had transformed into armed criminals whose sole purpose was to enrich themselves through the production of cocaine, exploitation of natural resources and the kidnapping and extortion of innocent Colombians. All of my non-guerrilla participants spoke about the FARC in this way, as did several of

my former guerrilla participants. They described the FARC as a group that used violence as a means to obtain material goods.

The children with whom I worked at CAE also placed a great focus on violence when speaking about their time with the FARC. While I asked them what the FARC were fighting for, they would say they were fighting against the government for the rural poor, but they could rarely go further than that. They would be unable to speak in any depth about the FARC's ideological beliefs or why they were being implemented. During my time at CAE, there were only two girls who were an exception to this. They could give deep ideological reasons for why it was necessary for the FARC to exist, in order to fight against the corruption, the inequality and the poverty in Colombia, all of which they attributed to the government and the country's elite. However, these girls were unusual. I spoke about this with Diego, one of the psychologists in CAE, who confirmed that most of the children had no real understanding of the ideological values of the FARC. Rather, their motivations to become part of the FARC revolved around factors such as getting a gun, attaining access to power through violence or getting away from violence, abuse and poverty in the home. Thus, while ideology has been a central element of the FARC's call to violence and has certainly played a role in the construction of their lifeworld, as explored below, a desire to become involved with violence has also played a significant role.

Denny et al. (2003) argue that group dynamics and group identity are essential in an individual's decision to commit violence. They claim that willingness to engage in violence occurs through a process whereby the individual gradually begins to forget about their own identity and take on the identity of the larger organisation. Recruits begin to measure their success and self-worth in relation to the success and value of the organisation as opposed to their own individual struggles (Denny et al. 2003). Once this has occurred, it becomes easy to convince new recruits to engage in violence because they will see it as not only legitimate but necessary in achieving the group's goals, which they also see as their own. This in part involves producing, negotiating and maintaining a set of beliefs and meanings that inspire and legitimate their activities. It means creating a system in which recruits can draw on shared experiences and viewpoints that come to form new systems of knowledge and new ways of being in the world. It means making the world meaningful in new ways and creating bonds between recruits, which is a defining aspect of military organisations (McCoy 1998). It means creating a lifeworld.

The transitions children make into armed groups raise specific issues, as it is different recruiting a child into an armed group than an adult. For this reason, there is a literature on 'child soldiers', which provides a valuable comparison with my research in Colombia. William Murphy (2003), writing on young fighters in Liberia and Sierra Leone, shows how through using a Weberian model of patrimonialism, a traditional form of domination, child soldiers became dependent on their commanders. The new patronage structures operated as a replacement for their previous family and commanders replaced parents or tribal elders in initiating children into adulthood. Young people then became dependent on them for survival and protection, and in exchange for fighting, adults provided the young recruits with a means of gaining power as well as material goods such as food, clothes and stolen items. Murphy shows that through this dependency children became drawn into the collective of the new group in part as a means of survival but also because commanders offered them a source of power that was not available otherwise. There is also evidence that magic has played a central role in military transformation in West African conflicts. The Kamajor militias of Sierra Leone, for example, faced with threats from both the national army and the rebels, mobilised collectively to conduct initiation through rituals, which was followed by military training (Kaihko 2016). Through these processes, a military identity was formed.

Singer (2006) shows how cultural concepts of honour and shame can draw young people into armed groups when they believe that they will be portrayed as heroes, as with child suicide bombers. Singer uses the example of Palestine where martyrdom is taught as being both good and honourable, which he argues has made violence and martyrdom a part of national consciousness. Some groups, such as the LTTE in Sri Lanka and the Jamiat Islami in Pakistan, have given special recognition and honours to the families of suicide bombers. Hamas in Palestine, according to Singer, celebrates the child's martyrdom by inviting hundreds of guests to gather at the family's home, and Kashmiri families have also been reported to celebrate the martyrdom of their children. Such celebrations and the possibility of achieving similar honour amongst their fellow villagers encourage children to join armed groups and become part of the collective identity, according to Singer. He also discusses the use of drugs and intoxicating substances, one of the most well-documented ways in which armed groups have recruited young people and compelled them to engage in violence. Drugs are effective in taking away feelings of pain and fear, giving young recruits a sense of bravado.

Ideology also plays a strong role in drawing young people into armed groups and convincing them to participate in violence. Financial incentives can serve as a means of enticing recruits into the group; however, as Gutierrez (2004) points out, military strategists have long said that armies whose main goals are material are the most easily defeated in combat because they often desert under attack. Without a strong conviction to keep fighting for a certain belief or a cause, many soldiers will simply give up. Thus, ideological beliefs can be a very effective tool in motivating soldiers to fight. Muldoon and Wilson (2001) show that youth in Northern Ireland with the strongest ideological commitment were the ones who viewed violence as acceptable. Extremist forms of religion and associated ideological beliefs have also drawn many young people into armed groups.

THE FARC

As I have shown, there are a variety of ways in which the transition into armed groups can take place. To explore how this process takes place in the FARC, it is therefore essential to consider the specific ways in which children make these transitions and what social and cultural elements are involved. For example, the FARC does not use drugs with its recruits even though the FARC is one of the biggest traffickers of drugs in Colombia. As discussed in Chapters 3 and 4, poverty and the normalisation of violence have been significant factors pushing children into joining armed groups. However, ideological beliefs have played the most prominent role in transitioning children between the civilian and military identity once they are in the FARC. A Colombian lawyer I spoke with in Apartado, Uraba, a region in the north of Colombia which had previously been heavily affected by the armed conflict, reflected on how the FARC's fight has largely been ideological:

The paramilitaries don't recruit children but the FARC do. So the FARC have more of an ideological fight because they believe that everyone should get involved with the conflict, the children everyone. They recruit children through their ideology. (male, age 42)

The FARC's ideological calls have largely been built around the declaration that they are fighting for the *campesinos*, or the rural poor. Describing themselves as a peasant armed movement, they claim that the long history of injustices perpetrated against the *campesinos* in Colombia has generated

a need for a defence movement to overthrow the government. Francisco Gutierrez Sanin (2004) argues that originally, the FARC was considered a Marxist–Leninist armed group but since 1988 they have articulated their ideology with what they call Bolivarian ideas, calling themselves the people's army with their mission being to take over the national government. Simon Bolivar, who liberated Colombia from the Spanish, is portrayed as a guerrilla fighter who is revered because he fought for the political emancipation of Colombia. Members of the FARC claim they are moving towards a new social order for Colombia and are committed to finding a political solution for the conflict. In a document they released titled *Marulanda and the FARC for beginners*, the title referring to Manuel Marulanda Velez who was the founder of the FARC and the first commander, they outline their political objectives. They write:

Our decision to take up weapons was just. First, because our guerrillas emerged as a response to aggression against the peasants and further because the causes we defend are the causes of the exploited. Our objectives were always based on the fundamental needs of the peasants and workers. We are part of the national liberation of our homeland. (Salgari, n.d., p. 60)

In their manifesto of September 2007, the FARC put forth their political and social plan, or what they call the Bolivarian Platform for a new Colombia. They argued that a new government should be built on democracy and people's sovereignty and should put an end to neoliberal policies, assume control of the strategic sectors and stimulate production in all ways which would demand respect for the nation's sovereignty and its natural resources, and implement efficient policies to preserve the environment (Salgari, p. 146). Borch and Stuvoy (2008, p. 110) found that the FARC's administration of resources follows a Marxist-based organisation in which they are centralised and equally distributed. Economic resources in the FARC are considered collective property, and FARC members are not paid. Torres (2008) also argues that the FARC's assets are collectively managed, and the ownership of private property and assets is not allowed. These rules are extended to everyone within the group and even to the hostages. Thus, at least officially, the FARC's political and economic platform has been built around Marxist ideology and they promote themselves as a Marxist army of all the people. As they write in *Marulanda and the FARC for beginners*, 'In the FARC, political education revolves around Bolivarian ideas and the classics of Marxism, especially Latin American.

From the moment a combatant joins the organisation, one's educational process begins' (Salgari, p. 151).

During my time with former child guerrillas, both in CAE and outside it, their descriptions of their time in the FARC indicated that ideology did not necessarily play a role in joining the armed group even though it did for some of the older guerrillas. However, it did play a role in convincing them to attach to the guerrilla identity as well as participate in violence. On many occasions at CAE, I would find the children writing the name FARC-EP on their notebooks, on their clothes and on their arms. During computer classes, I would find them searching for images of the FARC on the Internet or looking for pictures of weapons, all indicators that the FARC and the FARC's ideology were important for them. Eduardo, who joined the guerrilla when he was just 11 years old and was 27 when I interviewed him, described some of the key factors of the FARC's ideological struggle:

The FARC began in 1964 in a countryside community in the department of Tolima, to fight for the rights of the campesinos that were being threatened at this time. They are a political military organisation that aims to allow the people to be able to choose their representatives in the government who will guarantee their rights. They are made up of men and women of whom the majority come from the poor and working class.

Their ideas and instructions have been taken from those of Karl Marx and Vladimir Lenin in defense of the working class. They teach that people should be respected and that they should have rights. They will fight for everyone to live in better conditions and to live a dignified life. Everyone should have dignity despite their race, religion, ethnicity or culture and have a fundamental right to education, a place to live, food, health and place to work.

People can enter into the FARC who are between the age of 16 and 25. They can be of different cultures, ethnicities and from different regions. They just need to have the desire to participate and belong to the revolutionary organisation and help with the defense of the campesinos who have been threatened and humiliated by the Colombian government.

There are those in Colombia and in the world that call the FARC a terrorist organisation. However, the FARC is not a terrorist organisation because we have defined political rules. Each different block has a commander in charge. In each region of the country there are five or more fronts which have around 80 people in each front. They ask for those who have accumulated economic wealth to support them with money.

The people that live in this organisation are family. They learn to be united soldiers on an ethical and moral level. Everyone feels the same necessity to learn different activities in order to live the daily life of the political and military fight that has taken so many years. (former child guerrilla, age 27, Florencia)

Eduardo describes the FARC as a legitimate political organisation whose recruits are willing to fight and engage in violence for what he sees as the revolutionary cause of Colombia. He regards it as a defensive war where those who join must be willing to take up arms for this cause. Similar legitimations of the FARC's practices were made in the testimonies of other former guerrillas. Wendy explained:

The guerrillas are fighting for Colombia. The government is enslaving the people and the FARC is fighting against this. (former child guerrilla, age 21, Caqueta)

Silvia also saw the FARC's ideological beliefs as being a legitimate call to take up arms:

The FARC is fighting for a change in Colombia, there should be equality for everyone. They are fighting for the pueblo, the government should support these people. (former child guerrilla, age 34, Florencia)

Diana also legitimised the FARC's struggle as being centred around fighting for the rural poor:

The FARC are fighting against inequality. They want to help the people who are poor. There are people who say that the guerrillas are bad because of kidnapping or extortion but the extortion is like a tax. (former child guerrilla, age 25, Florencia)

Marc Gonsalves, the former hostage, observed throughout his time in captivity that the FARC used ideology as a means to legitimise themselves. He explains:

Their banner is to be fighting for the people of the pueblo. To fight corruption, to fight a bad government and put them in place because they're good. That's how they trick people, especially the young people. (age 44, United States)

These narratives indicate that the former guerrillas had formulated a deep attachment to the FARC's ideological beliefs. Through their ideological

beliefs, the FARC have created a specific type of lifeworld, where individuals are bound together through social relationships. The shared understandings formed through the ideological beliefs have created a sense of unity and integration amongst the individuals in the group that are specific to Colombia's history and culture. Marc's suggestion that the FARC use their ideology to 'trick' recruits is a reflection of the views held by many Colombians, that the FARC's ideological calls to violence are not genuine. Throughout the extensive time that I spent with Marc, this notion that FARC 'tricked' children and indeed all recruits into joining the FARC was a consistent narrative. He strongly believed that the FARC used their ideological beliefs as a way to 'trick' recruits into believing that the FARC and their calls to violence were legitimate although they were actually an excuse to use violence in order to obtain material goods.

Through adopting these beliefs, the new recruit slowly becomes immersed in the lifeworld of the FARC and begins to take on the identity of the guerrillas. Angstrom (2016) argues that the transition from a civilian into a soldier consists of three stages: separation from the old self, transition into the new self and social recognition of the new self. This analysis draws on the classic work on rites of passage by Van Gennep (1909) and Turner (1967). A similar transition process has occurred in the FARC. Throughout the narratives of the children, there are evident shifts that have been made both in entering into the FARC through different stages of recruitment, which will be explored in this chapter, and then in returning into the civilian world, which will be explored in this chapter.

SEPARATION

One of the first steps the FARC takes with drawing new recruits into their lifeworld is to break down their ties with their old world. They must separate recruits from any attachments to their civilian life so that they can start to build a new guerrilla identity. Samuel Huntington (1957) argued that in order for soldiers to be effective they should leave their civilian selves behind when they enter into a state of war. Once this is done, the military commanders can then begin to build up the military identity (McCoy 1998). For the FARC, the process of separating new recruits from their previous identities occurs in a number of ways. They first make new recruits cut ties with their families by not allowing them to talk about their pasts or mention the names of family members or loved ones. They are also not permitted to talk or encouraged to talk about all other aspects of home life.

Oscar Gomez, who spent many years in the guerrilla, described some of the ways in which these separations are made:

Life is really different in the guerrilla. There's no television, you can't have a phone because there's no signal, you can have a radio but the commander doesn't like it because the government speaks badly about them so they don't want their recruits listening, so you're completely separated from the world. So when you leave the group you feel completely lost because everyone can do things that you can't. (age 52, Guaviare)

Separating new recruits from their old life is a tactic that is often used by armed groups. In Sierra Leone, for example, the RUF abducted children and forced them to kill neighbours or family members in full sight of other villagers as a way of separating them from their previous worlds (Wessels 2006). Once a child has killed a family member, then they are no longer able to return home, giving them no other option than to stay with the armed group and attach to the soldier identity. In Angola, many young soldiers were forced to sing and dance non-stop through the whole night as a way of trying to make them forget about home and their parents (Honwana 2006). In other cases, acts of extreme violence are used to separate recruits from their civilian identities. In Paraguay, youth recruits suffered initiation rites that included exercise, hitting with sticks, burning with cigarettes and being kicked (Brett and McCallin 1996). As young people gradually begin to leave behind their old identities, military commanders are then able to begin creating new, militarised identities to shape them into effective soldiers.

In the FARC, recruits are expected to follow a strict regime and to follow the rules as given by the commanders. Strict expectations to follow rules and harsh punishments for not doing so play a significant role in separating children from their old identities. By being forced to follow the rules of the new organisation and leaving behind the rules associated with their old world, the new recruits are forced to understand that they have now entered a world where new rules and new ideas apply:

If they give you an order you have to do it, everything is about orders, such as when you eat. (former child guerrilla, age 34, Florencia)

Andres described some of the rules that recruits in the guerrilla are expected to follow:

There are many rules: don't drink, don't break the rules, go to sleep early, at 6 pm everyone is sleeping and you can't have lights on because of the airplanes. Don't go out to the areas where the civilian population are. Phones are prohibited because the satellites can detect them. The commanders can have a phone but normally there is no signal. There are many rules. (former child guerrilla, age 24, San Jose del Guaviare)

The government army would regularly conduct air raids over areas they suspected to be held by the guerrillas and drop bombs. Marc, the ex-hostage, also spoke of spending the nights terrified and unable to escape as bombs would drop. It was a great fear for the guerrillas. Former child guerrilla Wendy also confirmed that following orders is part of the guerrilla's daily routine. Wendy grew up in Caqueta near San Vicente in the *despe*, a zone held by the guerrilla. The guerrilla were always around and so for Wendy they were a normal part of life. She decided to join the guerrilla when she was 13 years old because she felt attracted to their ideology:

If you adapt, you'll be fine. If you don't follow the rules you will be punished, you have to follow the rules. You can't sleep when you're on guard duty. (former child guerrilla, age 21, Caqueta)

New recruits are also not allowed to leave the armed group once they have entered and attempts to escape are met with harsh punishments, which are most often a war council where it is decided upon whether the child should live or die. Diana explained:

They have war councils. If you try to escape then you have to go and stand in front of all of the bosses and they have to decide if you live or if they will kill you. Most of the time they kill you. They normally shoot you and one of the guerrillas has to do it. If you say no they have a war council for you. So there are times where you might have to kill a friend. (former child guerrilla, age 25, Florencia)

Jose Daniel also explained about not being able to leave the armed groups and the severe repercussions that one could face for attempting to escape:

The people that they catch, yes absolutely, they kill them. Because they say that you are a traitor. In the guerrilla you have to be there forever. You can't leave. You feel relaxed in Medellin but you never know who is here and who is around. You could make a mistake in one moment and they could get you. (former child guerrilla, age 22, Medellin)

This loyalty expected from the recruits is part of the FARC's method of drawing their recruits into the FARC's lifeworld. By sustaining the idea that children cannot leave and must be part of the FARC forever, children, and indeed any recruit, are left with the idea that embracing the new world of the FARC is their only option. Using harsh punishments such as death for attempts to escape is a powerful reinforcement that children should embrace this new world. Marc also explained some of the ways fear of being punished for attempting to leave controlled children:

The kids were really paranoid. Especially the ones that were friendly to us. There were times when you would see them shaking or trembling when they were talking to us. Whenever somebody would see them doing something that they could get in trouble for it would make them extremely scared. In the FARC there are people with aspirations and they want to be commanders and be above their peers. There would be rivalries and there would be no hesitation to report on somebody else.

The FARC has a system where they will use each other to report on each other. So if you're a low ranking kid guerrilla in the FARC you could be told that you need to keep an eye on so and so and if they're doing something treasonous then they have to report on it. And then that person is reporting on somebody else and so it's like a chain. Everybody is reporting on everybody else. So stealing would be something, or not being devout to their cause is something that could be reported on or wanting to leave or escape. There are a lot of things that they can get in trouble for. They can get sanctioned but if it's more serious then there could be a war council and then they would vote on if they should get killed or not. These war councils happen a lot, if there's a war council it's not good for whoever's being accused. Part of the FARC culture involves always looking tough and that they can kill without a second thought and so to have somebody put on a war council there is pressure to vote for death because if you vote to not kill somebody then it makes you look soft or weak and everybody's scared to say no. So everybody would say kill him.

Johanna: *Was there a culture of brotherhood or a culture of mistrust?*

Marc: *Yeah I would say that it was more of a culture of mistrust.* (Ex hostage of the FARC, age 44, US)

The harsh punishments for leaving the group are a way of increasing group coherence and preventing desertion. Recruits learn that in order to survive they must adapt to the rules and conform to the FARC's ideological beliefs. Young people then leave their old identities behind and the military commanders can then start to create the identity of the guerrilla.

TRAINING

Military training socialises recruits through the transfer of the necessary skills to become an effective soldier. It also builds solidarity and closeness amongst the soldiers where a sense of ‘family’ can emerge, as in the saying ‘brothers in arms’. In the FARC, they refer to each other as comrades, a term that was frequently used by the children in CAE. Creating a ‘family’-like closeness between recruits is essential in building military identity and constructing military lifeworlds. Harsh and difficult training has long been used by militaries and armed groups around the world, and as Jan Angstrom (2016) points out in his work on Swedish Army Rangers, such training helps soldiers make the transition from civilian life to forming a military identity. For Woodward (2000), military training is the acquisition and development of a collection of physical and mental attributes required for taking on the necessary elements to conduct war. Through intensive training, the individual’s mind and body are combined to produce a particular kind of physical engagement with the world. This primarily involves embodying patterns of action and certain ways of thinking through which recruits learn the new expectations and expected codes of behaviour. Newlands (2013) shows how British soldiers in World War II were subjected to a regime of physical activities by the military which focused on exerting control over and transforming the body so that the recruit would submit to the regime. By the end of the training, the military had established total control over the recruit and was then able to start turning him into the ideal soldier.

In the FARC, harsh and difficult training is also used and involves combat training, including survival techniques and tactics for mounting ambushes and surprise attacks. There is specialised training for new recruits in marksmanship, explosives, the handling of cylinder bombs, use of heavy machine guns or special operations including undercover missions and assassinations. Eduardo, who had spent a significant amount of time with the guerilla and who had joined the FARC as a young boy, describes a typical day of training in the FARC:

You learn about the norms that regulate the daily life of everyone who joins the organisation and their different aspects. They will tell you what you have to do every day from when you wake up to when you go to sleep. You have to make food, shower, there has to be time for culture and recreation, political education where you learn about the economy, culture, politics, environment, national and international themes. You also need time for physical activity and institutions to organise security.

Everyone has to get up at 5am. They then have to go to the military house and they tell them about things that have happened in the night and they take notes. They have to get dressed and then they have breakfast. After they go to the salon and listen to news about the world and study about whatever is going on in the world. Then they go and eat biscuits or bread. Then they go back to the salon where they continue to study. At 1 pm they do military exercises.

When you first arrive you have to do basic training. To know why you are there, what your rights are, what your names are, you have to do exercises, to read and write. To participate in military life you have to learn to fight, you have to learn to attack and to defend yourself in a group and as an individual. (age 27, Florencia)

Carlos, who also had joined the guerrillas as a child, reported strict training during his time in the guerrilla:

At the beginning we had to do exercises, we had to learn how to manage a gun, lots of exercises, learn to shoot, learn how to enter into a camp of the military, learn how to make bombs. Lots of things. (age 22, Guaviare)

Parts of guerrilla life also included long marches when moving camps. Children would have to carry all of their equipment including tents, cooking equipment and weapons. Discipline was especially strict during these marches because of the fear of detection. Oscar Gomez describes the difficulties of the long marches:

You can't rest. You can sleep in one place for 2 or three hours and then you have to go and rest somewhere else. Nowhere is safe because you have enemies everywhere. You are always running. You suffer a lot. You are hungry. (former child guerrilla, age 52, Guaviare)

Part of the training also includes managing the fear that comes with going into armed battle. Andres explains:

When they would come with planes we would have to run. Whenever the fights are on land the guerrillas always win but when they come with planes we can't beat them. When I would hear the sound of a plane I would start to shake. It's a really big help for the state, they can drop bombs on us and there's no way to fight back against this.

We would have to run. Everyone would have to run. Sometimes at 1 in the morning and everyone would be sleeping and you would hear your friends start

to panic everyone would start to pack their things. (former child guerrilla, age 24, San Jose del Guaviare)

Finding a way to help the recruits manage their fear is essential because if recruits feel afraid, they are more likely to desert. One of the methods the FARC uses to help their recruits manage the fear that comes with armed battles is by getting them to eat gunpowder. Yahir explains:

Well when I fought with the guerrillas I was not afraid. I was only afraid when I was sleeping in the mountains but when we were fighting no, I would eat gun powder. (former child guerrilla, age 17, Manizales)

Oscar Gomez also reported:

There are some who eat gun powder, there are some who are very afraid. (former guerrilla, age 52, San Jose del Guaviare)

Training teaches the recruits about the new social structures of the armed group, which revolve around military ideals and the use of violence as a means to obtain their objectives. These social structures include learning how to dress in uniform in accordance with the military, how symbols such as guns represent power and control, new concepts of gender and legitimacy. Through the training, the new recruits learn about the collective codes of meaning and symbolic patterns of the military lifeworld. Training also reinforces the idea that violence and in particular extreme acts of violence, such as killing, are acceptable. As shown in Chapter 4, many of the children who join the FARC have already come to see violence as a normal part of the world. This normalisation of violence in their civilian lives plays a significant role in the militarisation process, which is further reinforced during the training period. Thus, it is through the training and as the military commanders begin to gain control over their bodies that the recruits become drawn into the lifeworld of the FARC.

MEMORY

Part of building the new world of guerrilla means constructing a world which is legitimate, with values, morals, beliefs and behaviours that one believes to be true and correct and should therefore be reproduced. One of the FARC's primary tools to create legitimacy has been by drawing on

historical memories and relating them to current events. Through using memories of past injustices, the FARC have created a bridge between the past, the present and the future for their new recruits. Halbwach (1980) was one of the first to look at how collective memory is like a collective consciousness and can be used by groups to serve their own purposes in the present. Shared heroes and collective pride formed over past conquests and victories can bind groups together by linking individuals with their predecessors and their successors in a meaningful way. This is able to transcend individual existence to something greater (Berger and Luckman 1966).

Nissan Rubin (1985) looks at how the Israeli army has drawn on memories from a shared past in which all of the individuals of the group can remember together, bringing them together into a collective military identity. These memories are then used to legitimate their identity as a military organisation and their calls to violence. Mirta Furman (1999) looks at how this is done through the use of educational rituals used for political purposes in kindergartens in Israel. Furman shows how rites give messages to children that include statements about the necessity of war and sacrifice or the glories of heroism through the use of memories. As Furman shows, through rites in kindergarten during childhood, the adult Israeli is being prepared for the future. By the time they reach the army, Israeli youths have internalised the knowledge and the motivation to be part of the military.

Memory can be used in multiple ways in order to construct a social reality in the present (Assmann 1992). Cultural memories come from events deep in the past and are often reproduced in cultural groups through myths, genealogies or traditions. Carol Kidron (2015) discusses the concept of 'danger memory' where a parent passes on a memory to their child through telling narratives of a dangerous event that was survived. Through listening to the story of the parent, the child may feel a threat against their ontological security as the child links the parent's memory to the imagined future of the child. The children may then take on this memory as if it were their own, believing they also face the same threat. Memories passed through generations in this way can produce what Ron Eyerman (2001) calls cultural trauma. As Nietzsche (1957, p. 5) said: 'only that which never ceases to hurt stays in the memory'. The suffering produced from the memory can then be used to create and legitimise realities in the present. The use of such memories can be an essential part of building military lifeworlds, such as in the FARC.

Borch and Stuvoy (2008) argue that the FARC have used memory narratives as a way of building a collective identity within the group. Using a

similar method to Kidron's (2015) concept of danger memory, the FARC have used memories from past injustices perpetrated towards the *campesinos* to justify their actions in the present. Using the memory of these injustices they argue that it is essential to continue the struggle against inequality and injustice that the FARC argues continue to be perpetrated by the Colombian government. These primarily include the unequal distribution of wealth, corruption and perpetrating acts of violence. By emphasising these narratives of past suffering and injustices, the memories are brought into the present, which legitimises the FARC's existence and their call to arms. The memories link all the members of a society so they can understand themselves as being part of a meaningful universe which was there before they were born and will be there after they die. As Derrida (1976) points out, by turning experiences of violence and oppression into politicised memories, a call to arms or for justice can be legitimised.

The FARC have also used the memory of their founding fathers, whom they present as being heroes, as a way of legitimising themselves. Marulanda, one of the founding fathers of the FARC, is presented as a revolutionary hero. The FARC speak of him as a sort of David, while presenting the government as a Goliath and the evil oppressor of the Colombian people. Worship is concentrated around those who died during the foundational and mythical event of Marquetalia and they are remembered within the FARC as revolutionary brothers. By remembering those who are presented as revolutionary and patriotic heroes, combatants get a sense that they are part of the continuation of great historical events that are working towards the liberation of Colombia from oppression by the ruling class (Borch and Stuvoy 2008). Through reliving the memory of their revolutionary brothers and sisters, recruits are able to interpret their personal experience within an understanding of collective destiny and reinforce that they are fighting for a legitimate cause. In this way, combatants feel as if they are equal to the others within the group and that they too have the potential to be heroes.

One of the primary means by which the FARC transfer these historical memories into the realities of their recruits is through what they call cultural hour. The meetings are held weekly, and during these meetings, they discuss current political developments and give lectures on Marxism, Leninism and the revolutionary heroes such as Che Guevara, Jacobo Arenas and Camilo Torres. Children are taught about the exploitation and oppression of the peasants and the people's struggle against the oligarchy of the Colombian government and US imperialism (Pachon 2012). Fernando Bosco (2001) shows how spatial dimensions can play a role in forming collective identity,

and rituals that take place in a specific place can serve to maintain social network cohesion both spatially and symbolically. As places are collectively identified as meaningful through rituals or through specific events that take place there, this can then be used to reinforce participants' feelings of group solidarity. As cultural hour takes place weekly it is used as a ritual to reinforce the FARC's ideology and create cohesion amongst the recruits. During this time, recruits are brought together and the rules and ideological beliefs of the FARC are taught and reinforced. Marc was forced to attend the cultural hours during his time as a hostage and he described his experience:

They have a pretty good brainwashing system which is forced on these people and the kids. The FARC have this thing called cultural hour but it goes on most of the day. They would gather and sing communist songs where they would praise their leaders and recite things written in their ideological books.

They would do that every Sunday. So a kid would be called and they would be told to recite something. It was just a whole brainwashing thing. I would see the kids with the books in the week and they would be studying their manuals or writing things. They would have to write some of the rules down and they would have to write them 10 or 20 times.

Some of the songs were about killing Colombian soldiers, there was one song about capturing three Americans. Songs boasting military victory, songs about the corrupt government, about them fighting the government for equality. It is always about demonising the Colombian government and emphasising how good the FARC is and how they always win and how when they win they're going to have everything and have equality across the board. This is their doctrine and how they get people to join. They even told us that they had to keep holding us hostage because if they let us go the Colombian government would kill us and then blame the FARC. They would tell us that our government doesn't care about us that the Colombians wanted to kill us, if you try to escape they'll try to kill you. (former hostage of the FARC, age 44, US)

By using cultural hour as a means of transmitting the ideas of the FARC to their recruits, they are able to begin constructing a new reality which is based on the specific ideological values of the FARC. As Marc recounts, the recruits were made to recite the FARC's ideological values and sing songs that emphasised the military value of the FARC. In this way, storytelling has a transcending power that has the ability to shape realities and bring the past to life into the future in an ongoing and meaningful way (Berger and Luckman 1966). Through repetition of the ideas through ritual events such

as cultural hour, they eventually sediment into the child's consciousness and through learning together about the ideological values of the FARC, the new reality becomes a shared reality. As this identity becomes embedded in one's core sense of self, then not only does this legitimise the existence of the FARC but one may see a very personal and individual call to violence.

CREATING AN OTHER

Part of the FARC's process of legitimising themselves has involved creating an 'other'. Harrison (1993, p. 17) notes that the formation of social groups is done by defining them against one another. It is the negative relations, the building of non-relationships and the creation of social divisions and barriers that creates social groups. Henri Tajfel (1974, p. 69) argues that as people compare their group with others, this leads to a sense of 'social psychological distinctiveness' in which their own identity is reinforced. Those 'inside' and 'outside' a group may be constructed in a number of ways, most effectively through the construction of fear. Through the use of cultural resources, one can create a demonised, dehumanised or otherwise threatening ethnically defined other. Horowitz (1985) showed how, through the social construction of fear, regularities in cultural groups can be formed. These groups can be created through narratives, myths and rituals which can create the perception of another group of people as being threatening. Tambiah (1986) shows how fear of other ethnic groups can be created through the use of certain narratives and representations such as rumours. When presented within a historical context they can be connected to an inner logic, which can then be used to create a perception of reality. It is through this process that 'othering' takes place.

The concept of 'othering' has particular significance when it comes to convincing soldiers to take part in violence. Once a certain group of people have been presented as threatening and fear has been generated, then violence no longer seems random or meaningless but rather becomes meaningful (Brubaker and Laitin 1998). Senechal de la Roche (1996) proposes a concept of 'relational distance', where people will be more likely to commit violence against others who they feel are further away from their social group. The further in distance one feels the 'other' is, the easier it is to perpetrate violence against them. This is particularly relevant in convincing soldiers to kill. For armed groups, as Protevi (2013, p. 133) argues, commanders aim to suspend the individual's sense of self so that soldiers dehumanise the enemy.

Bandura (1973) argues that the process of learning to kill is usually achieved through gradual desensitisation where the enemy is turned into an 'other', making it easier for the soldier to kill because the 'other' is not considered to be human. As the violence becomes routinised, individuals start to see killing as simply a normative act which can be repeated without much distress (Kelman 1995). As Ignatieff points out, once the killing has started, dehumanisation is easily accomplished. Once the out-group becomes seen as less human than the in-group, it becomes both moral and justifiable to commit violence against this group of people. McMahan (2009) argues that when it is believed there is a moral reason for harming someone, then it is considered an achievement. Such forms of 'othering' have taken place in such different contexts as in Rwanda during the genocide, with the Hutus referring to the Tutsis as cockroaches, as well as during World War II, in the Balkans and South Sudan (Borch and Stuvoy 2008). 'Othering' is essentially what Schroder and Schmidt (2001, p. 11) refer to as forming a 'macabre form of certainty'. By pitting yourself or your group against the other, you are able to reassert your own identity with a sense of certainty.

The FARC have used 'othering' in their efforts in legitimising themselves. As already mentioned above, they have created two binary groups within the Colombian population that are primarily divided through class lines. The *campesinos* are presented as the poor, working-class Colombians who have faced a long victimisation by the elite class and the Colombian government. The FARC present themselves as the group which is in legitimate need of defence while the 'other' are the Colombian government and its armed forces who are presented as bourgeois and belonging to the oligarchy. As the FARC have portrayed the Colombian government as being dangerous and a direct threat to the working-class Colombians, this then legitimises the FARC and their use of violence against the 'other'. Javier, a former policeman who was held hostage by the FARC for over nine years, explained how othering has legitimised the use of violence in the FARC:

They indoctrinate the recruits in the FARC, for them it's something normal. To kill a policeman is normal. To kill an enemy is normal. If they don't think the same as them they are an enemy and it is necessary to eliminate them. They all think like this. They only think in killing.

In the training they give them this hate, this mentality. A kid of 17 or 18 years old will kill someone with just an order. It is part of making a violent mentality.

They sell this idea that you have to kill your own family for the revolution. (age 44, Villavicencio)

For Wendy, the process of ‘othering’ had become internalised:

There are a lot of rich people in Colombia, so the FARC takes from them, they take their land. With kidnappings the state kidnaps FARC soldiers and calls them prisoners of war. So the soldiers and the police that the FARC kidnap are also political prisoners. With civilians, the FARC takes those who are living in the countryside and who work with the government. It is difficult for the campesinos because they are stuck in the middle. You are not allowed to sell information to the government. (former child guerrilla, age 21, Caqueta)

Wendy’s justification of the FARC’s violence is in part linked to Colombia’s long history of wealth inequality between the rural poor and Colombia’s ruling elite, in which the historical memory of the rural poor has largely been shaped until now. The FARC hold the government and the Colombian elite responsible for this and any suffering that has occurred as a consequence. Their view is that anyone from the upper classes in Colombia, or from the government, are legitimate targets for extortion and kidnapping. Wendy’s reference to not being allowed to sell information to the government is also indicative of her belief in the FARC’s legitimacy. Civilians are regularly approached by both the government and the armed groups and asked for information on where the ‘other’ is. This places those civilians in a precarious situation because if they are known to have given or ‘sold’ information to the other side, this can lead to serious repercussions, particularly from the armed groups, who regularly kill informers.

Former child guerrilla Eduardo also demonstrated his belief in the legitimacy of the FARC:

Kidnappings are necessary for several reasons. Economic fines are where they ask for a small amount of money according to the economic capacity of the individual. Military fines are where combatants, soldiers and police are captured for a humanitarian exchange with guerrillas who are in prison. They are not called hostages because they are only people who are being transferred from one place to another and kept under surveillance. (age 27, Florencia)

The FARC has become well known throughout Colombia for their use of extortion and kidnapping civilians in exchange for money. Eduardo justified both kidnapping and extortion by referring to extortion as ‘economic

finer'. His terminology here demonstrates that he saw such actions as being legitimate. He also makes reference to the capturing of police and soldiers as being necessary for political hostage exchanges. He makes a specific reference to the police and military as *not* being hostages, which again is an important use of terminology that implies that the actions are legitimate. Eduardo's testimony implies that he had internalised and accepted the FARC's ideological beliefs, demonstrating that he saw the FARC as a legitimate group. He accepted the new values and morals of the FARC and became drawn into the lifeworld.

The following exchange with former child guerrilla Yahir also demonstrates how the FARC's process of 'othering' had successfully taken place with him:

Yahir: *It is okay to kill bad people. Politicians and people who are corrupt. I know that maybe it is different in other countries but if a child grows up around violence they will think that violence is normal. That's how it is in Colombia*

Johanna: *How is it for you now when you see a soldier or a police?*

Yahir: *It's normal. Before in the FARC, you think about them with anger, you have the idea in your head that you want to kill them, you have this way of thinking. That they are your enemy. You think that you are better than them. It's really different. They tell you that there's a lot of corruption in Colombia and that there's a lot of poverty, they put the idea in your head that you have to fight the government because of the corruption. (age 17, Medellín)*

Yahir's statement here is significant. He justifies killing the 'other', whom he specifically refers to as being police and soldiers. He refers to the government as being responsible for the creation of poverty and corruption in Colombia which, as he argues, makes them legitimate targets for violence. Even more significant is his reference to his anger. Yahir explained that he felt a deep sense of anger towards soldiers and police to the point where he wanted to kill them. This shows a deep sedimentation of the FARC's ideology whereby he felt a physical, emotional response to seeing police or military which was heightened to the point of being willing to kill.

Kennely et al. (2015) argue that to grasp the full range and power dynamics of performative acts, we need to draw upon concepts such as affect and embodied practices to understand how human subjectivity is formed. Affect is understood in terms of a set of embodied practices and is largely a feeling and experience that cannot be understood through lan-

guage. Vivian Sobchack (2004) describes embodiment as a condition of human beings that entails both the body and consciousness, objectivity and subjectivity, where the meaning of experience is lived in context. For those who have taken on the ideology of the FARC, their experiences, including the violence, become represented in their bodily actions and their expressions of how they see the world. The violence has become seen as natural and normal and they are not able to see it as anything other than this. This embodiment of the FARC's ideology was further reflected in another conversation with Yahir:

Johanna: *Why do you think that people like violence?*

Yahir: *Because they're happy to kill someone.*

Johanna: *Do you like violence?*

Yahir: *Not now but before, yes.*

Johanna: *Why?*

Yahir: *Because I liked to fight with the corrupt people, with the army, the people who are stealing from the poor. Like with the paramilitaries, they massacre people. They steal, they take land, they kill people it doesn't matter if there's a pregnant woman they kill everyone.*

Yahir's account reveals how the FARC's processes of legitimisation had become normalised within him. He enjoyed being violent because he felt that he was seeking justice for those he deemed to have been wronged. Whether this is in fact what he was achieving is debatable, however, the fact that he believed this was what he was doing is what is significant. He had taken on the FARC's ideological beliefs as his own. They gave him meaning in the world and it is through this meaning that he justified violent action and behaviour. The following discussion with Andres also shows how he had embodied the FARC's ideology:

Andres: *There are many people who like the violence, to kill, to fight, to be in conflict all the time.*

Johanna: *Why?*

Andres: *Because they have the mind set of this. Just war, war, war.*

Johanna: *And they like to kill?*

Andres: *Of course, when you don't kill you get sick.*

Johanna: *Why?*

Andres: *It's a saying, if you don't kill you get sick.*

Johanna: *They're talking about soldiers?*

Andres: *Yes, soldiers and police. They want to be fighting with them.*

Johanna: *Do you know why? I mean why do they want to kill the police?*

Andres: *It's because the FARC gives them these ideas. The police have always been their target. The army is the enemy of the guerrillas. The guerrillas are always looking for the police or the army to kill. They are enemies.* (former child guerrilla, age 24, San Jose del Guaviare)

What is particularly interesting is where Andres makes reference to the guerrillas who just think of 'war, war, war', which indicates a clear process of having embodied the violence. Violence has become embodied to the point where if one does not kill, then the body would become unwell. For the soldier to be healthy, to survive, he or she must kill, which indicates a bodily link between acts of violence, killing and the body. It indicates a state of being that is deeply interlinked with violence and being violent. In the case of the FARC combatants Andres describes, the embodied nature of the violence indicates that they have fully accepted the structures of the lifeworld of the FARC, fusing their own identity with the identity of the guerrillas.

Participating in acts of violence together reinforces group identity and as violence begins to take over the inner world, the individual becomes unable to separate violence from the self. Through continued repetition, the child comes to understand that violence is a source of survival and as the violence becomes intertwined in the self, it becomes a source of meaning. Extreme acts of what an outsider would see as senseless violence become meaningful, simply because they are part of sustaining a structure in which meaning can be sought. By accepting the lifeworld, the child can achieve a degree of control over the violence and learn a kind of discipline, a way of looking and behaving that would be taboo to others or even to who the person he would be as another self. 'Children adapt to violence in order to not only survive, but to thrive. This way they can gain some kind of control over their life' (Baines 2009, p. 180). Acceptance of the violence provides stability, a sense of belonging and safety. Finnstrom (2008, p. 207) says: 'by

engaging and incorporating the unknown, foreign other, or by framing the alien within the cosmological order, one can bring it under control'. Denov and Maclure (2007, p. 256) note that children taken by the RUF in Sierra Leone increasingly came to intertwine their own personas with the norms and anarchic objectives of the RUF. By fusing individual identities with group identities, children came to find a sense of normality in the violence. The cultural values of the group shaped the child's understanding of the world so that they could not see what they were doing as wrong. In this context, violence becomes the primary template for the construction of meaning.

SHIFTING INTO THE GUERRILLA IDENTITY

Violence in the context of the FARC lifeworld is transformative; it can shift and change mental landscapes, thus also shifting identities. Violence has played a fundamental role in pushing young recruits away from their civilian lives and drawing them into the world of the FARC. Thus, the violence has created an ontology of personhood linked to aggressiveness and wildness fundamental to this kind of lifeworld. Some of the former guerrillas reflected on feeling a transformation when entering the FARC, as shown in the following conversation with Katerine:

Johanna: *When you entered into the group did things change in your mind, did you start to think differently?*

Katerine: *Well you feel full of hate. When you go there you change the way you think a lot, you don't think a lot there. When you leave you realize that it's quite ignorant. To take the life of someone.*

Johanna: *So it's something normal there, to kill?*

Katerine: *Yes. (former child guerrilla, age 16, Nieva)*

Katerine was able to distinguish between the mentality of being in the guerrilla and the mentality of being a civilian. 'You think differently', indicates that the mental landscapes in guerrilla and civilian life are different and that a shift had been made when she had entered into the collective lifeworld of the FARC. Later, as Katerine moved out of the guerrilla world, she had been able to make a distinction between the way of being in the guerrilla and the way of being as a civilian. As we continued our conversa-

tion, Katherine explained how she felt a shift in identity when in the guerrilla group:

Johanna: *You liked the guns?*

Katherine: *Yes, you felt big because you felt powerful so I thought it sounded interesting, I liked it. When I was there with the guns, the power and everything. I felt really different, with the guns*

Johanna: *When you left the group did it feel different?*

Katherine: *Yeah I felt free, like a normal person, I could do normal things of my age.*

As already explored in Chapter 4, guns play a significant role in motivating children to join the FARC. Guns are a symbol of power and by having a gun, children believe that they are gaining power that they did not previously have in their lives. The power represented in the gun shifts them from one status to another, a shift which is associated with entering the armed group. We can see through Katherine's testimony that guns played a role in her transition into the armed group. The guns gave her a sense of power that led her to believe that she had experienced a shift in identity. She also makes reference to a change in her identity when she left the armed group, where she speaks of feeling like a child of her own age. Jose Daniel revealed that he also felt a similar shift in identity with the possession of a gun:

With a gun you feel like a big man. When the army was nearby we would put on the uniform and I would feel a change. All the training, the way of life. You always have to adapt. (former child guerrilla, age 22, Medellin)

Jose Daniel also makes the link to feeling a sense of power when attaining a gun which made him think differently. Having a gun, this literally led him to feel as if he had transformed into a different identity. Similarly, Eduardo made references to feeling a shift while in the armed group:

My way of thinking changed when I entered the armed group. They changed my name for reasons of security and I felt that I changed when my name changed. Things changed when I had to carry arms because they signify authority. (former child guerrilla, age 27, Florencia)

Wendy also said:

I felt different when I joined the guerrillas, the life was different. (former child guerrilla, age 21, Caqueta)

Through the above narratives, we can see that a shift in self-perception has accompanied a shift in the social environment. As Richards (1999) has argued in relation to the RUF in Sierra Leone, the behaviour of its recruits fits with patterns predicted by neo-Durkheimian cultural theory as developed by Mary Douglas and others, which looked at how social solidarities are created. Emile Durkheim's (1858–1917) view of society, based on Rousseau's 'social contract', argues that agreements between people occur when they trust each other enough to make any such agreement. Once society has been established, then contracts are possible and solidarity can be created. Through this solidarity, the 'collective conscience' is formed. If we regard the FARC as a society in Durkheimian terms, then the collective consciousness has been built through resentment of the government, social exclusion and not being satisfied by the life chances they had been offered. In the FARC, new recruits learn that by participating in actions that are deemed to be 'legitimate' and 'good' such as killing the evil 'other' or taking part in acts of kidnapping, then they will be accepted by the group.

As a young person learns that one can achieve positive reinforcement by engaging in extreme acts of violence such as killing, then the violence begins to look, even feel, right. Shared understandings of behaviour become built around violence and young people understand that killing and engaging in violent behaviour are not only normal but a way of becoming part of the group. As the children participate in acts of violence together, social identification takes place and the group's goals and welfare eventually become connected to individuals' own well-being, drawing them further into the lifeworld of the FARC. A new worldview is formed and as the new rules of conduct are understood, the military world becomes the natural way of the world for the recruit. The recruits learn about themselves through being in the new world, and over time the world becomes part of them. As the group becomes collectively bonded, then the individual's identity becomes attached to the group's identity. It is through this fusion of world and self that the guerrilla identity is formed.

CONCLUSION

I have argued in this chapter that violence has played a fundamental role in the construction of the guerrilla lifeworld. The FARC have legitimised their

existence through the use of historical memories of violence perpetrated towards the working class. The FARC argue that within this context the use of violence is not only necessary but is justified in order to protect not only themselves but all working-class Colombians. The FARC have transformed the Colombian government and their military forces into an Other, making them legitimate targets to be attacked, which further justifies the FARC's existence as well as their use of violence. New recruits learn about these norms through the military training and observation and as the new norms gradually sediment in their consciousness, how they see themselves and the world begins to shift and violence increasingly becomes seen as the 'natural way of the world'. As individuals become drawn into the collective identity of the FARC, they begin to lose their own sense of individual identity and the identity of the FARC becomes the most important part of their identity. In this way, violence and the memory of violence in past injustices create a transformative and binding force that brings children into the world of the FARC and transforms them into effective warriors. As the children conform to the collective identity of the guerrilla, eventually they can only see themselves as being guerrilla, creating challenges for when they are no longer part of the militarised world. The next chapter is an exploration of children's experiences when they come out of the armed group and how the reintegration process attempts to bring children back into the civilian world.

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Coming Home: The Unmaking of a Child Soldier

'People have gotten so used to the war I think that they can't fathom there being peace. They're afraid of it'. John Otis, American journalist living in Bogota

INTRODUCTION

In August 2016, Colombia's President Juan Santos and the leader of the Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (FARC) shook hands to sign the peace agreement which would bring an end to Colombia's decades-long war (Edwards and Gaynor 2016). It had taken more than three years of negotiations for a bilateral ceasefire and the creation of demilitarised zones to finally be agreed upon between the Colombian government and the FARC. The road towards peace has been long and difficult. During nearly six decades of war, more than 200,000 people died. Only approximately 40,000 of them were combatants, so more than 80% of those who have been killed were civilians living in combat zones. Moreover, government and international agencies estimate that more than 4,700,000 Colombians have been forced to leave their homes as a result of the conflict (LaRosa and Mejía 2017, p. 231). The Red Cross, which has conducted extensive humanitarian missions throughout Colombia, reports that as of 2017, disappearances, death threats, targeted killings, sexual violence, displacement, extortion and the recruitment of children into armed groups and gangs have continued to be a problem. The violence has generated a huge

amount of suffering throughout the country and much time will be needed to heal Colombia. Part of creating this road to peace will include reintegrating the many combatants coming out of the jungle. They will need to be convinced that the best way to move forward with their lives is with a life of peace and education as opposed to one of violence and armed groups. Previous demobilisation attempts with other armed groups in Colombia have shown that this will be no easy task.

This chapter aims to explore the numerous challenges facing children as they come out of the armed groups and enter the civilian world. I will explore how the undoing of militarised identities is attempted in the reintegration process as children re-enter the civilian world. I will also look at the many issues that need to be addressed to prevent the recruitment of children into armed groups in Colombia in the future. This will include reducing the overwhelming poverty throughout the country and providing children with educational and employment opportunities. It will also involve reversing the well-established idea, created by the armed groups and the long-running conflict that violence is a natural and normal part of life. The children must readjust ideas of ‘othering’ and normalised ideas of violence that they have learnt from being in the armed group. They must also learn to deal with the stigma that ex-combatants face when re-entering society. This chapter ultimately aims to explore how children ‘shift’ out of the guerrilla lifeworld and back into the civilian one.

REINTEGRATION AND THE COLOMBIAN PEACE PROCESS

Before discussing the experiences of my participants, I will explain the overall peace process that preceded the demobilisation of the FARC and the challenges of the reintegration process. A number of attempts at constructing peace in Colombia have been made by past governments. Between 1994 and 1995, then President Ernesto Samper attempted to construct peace with the FARC but was unsuccessful (Tokatlian 2000). Former President Andres Pastrana also attempted to negotiate peace with the FARC in 1998, but was also unsuccessful (Tokatlian 2000). In 2012, Santos began peace talks with the FARC and the current peace process began with his re-election on 15 June 2014 when he began a dialogue with the FARC (Reed 2013). The negotiations primarily focused on six issues that included agrarian reforms in rural areas, political participation for opposition groups, elimination of the illicit drug trade and incorporation of alternative crops, and victims’ rights advocacy (Castro et al. 2017).

Another key issue was the disarmament of all FARC combatants and allowing internally displaced people (IDP) to return home (United Nations 2017). The negotiations also focused on a Special Jurisdiction for Peace to try those responsible for gross human rights violations committed during the conflict. The International Criminal Court (ICC) has determined that there is a reasonable basis to believe that crimes against humanity under Article 7 of the Statute have been committed in Colombia by various actors, since 1 November 2002. These include murder under Article 7(1)(a); forcible transfer of population under Article 7(1)(d); imprisonment or other severe deprivation of physical liberty under Article 7(1)(e); torture under Article 7(1)(f); and rape and other forms of sexual violence under Article 7(1)(g) of the Statute (International Criminal Court 2018). Individuals responsible for crimes against humanity and serious war crimes who fully cooperate with the new jurisdiction and confess their crimes will be subjected to up to eight years of effective restraints of rights and liberties (Human Rights Watch 2017). An Amnesty Law was proposed in the negotiations that would benefit those accused of ‘political and related crimes’ (Amnesty International 2016).

Once the Colombian government and the FARC came to an agreement it was put out to the general public through a referendum. However, the Colombian public rejected the result of the referendum, as many people were unhappy that the guerrilla would not receive adequate punishment for their crimes (Castro et al. 2017). A new, revised agreement emerged on 12 November 2016 and passed through the Colombian Senate and House of Representatives on 29 and 30 November 2016, allowing the peace process to officially begin (LaRosa and Mejía 2017, p. 1). On 7 June 2017, the first phase of the FARC’s demobilisation process began, in which they began to hand over their weapons. All of the registered arms are now under UN control (IOM 2017). This was completed on 27 June, followed by the destruction of the weapons (Amnesty International 2018). The next step of the peace process has been to reintegrate many of the former guerrillas (Amnesty International 2018).

Point 5 of the Peace Agreement created the ‘Truth, Justice, Reparation and Non-repetition System’, which included the Special Jurisdiction for Peace and judicial mechanisms such as a unit for investigating and dismantling criminal organisations. Point 5 is also supposed to give guarantees of access to justice and the right to truth and reparation, especially for groups such as those who were forcibly displaced, and victims of sexual violence as

well as indigenous, Afro-descendants and peasant farmer communities who are at risk. This has yet to be implemented (Amnesty International 2018).

The agreement has received widespread support from the international community. The then UN Secretary-General, Ban Ki-moon, participated in the ceremonial signing of the agreement and said that it created conditions for lasting peace (Human Rights Watch 2017). The ICC Prosecutor, Fatou Bensouda, also welcomed the announcement of the peace deal with the FARC but emphasised that it was necessary to ensure that there were genuine accountability and effective punishment of those responsible for atrocities (Human Rights Watch 2017). The United States, which has been the most influential foreign actor in Colombia, also welcomed the peace agreement and the then US President, Barack Obama, announced 'Peace Colombia', a new framework for bilateral collaboration to support peace efforts, and pledged US\$450 million in 2017 (Human Rights Watch 2017).

The FARC has now been allowed to enter politics and established a political party in 2017. The FARC will have a number of seats in Congress through 2018. They will not have voting rights but can speak on matters to do with the peace accords. After 2018, they will be able to win seats through elections (United Nations 2017). In June 2017, the FARC released their policy for their new political party which included a statement with the changes that they would bring to government. Significantly, this also included the involvement of women. They have said that women will enjoy equal conditions with men and their participation will be sought. They will work to create a political environment that counters traditional patriarchies of Colombian political life and will create a department of Women and Gender (IOM 2017). In a country dominated along patriarchal lines that has largely excluded women from political life, making such a move would be significant in bringing positive changes to Colombia and reflects one of the positive aspects of the FARC's platform. The FARC have also begun training former guerrillas to be security and bodyguards to protect the future political party leaders of the FARC which is linked to fears concerning past guerrilla leaders who have been killed when forming political parties (IOM 2017). They have also agreed that they will work together with the National Police. The Colombian National Electoral Council announced that it would financially support a future FARC political party (IOM 2017).

Implementing the peace agreement and moving forward with the proposed changes will be a challenge. In order to promote peace in the country,

it is going to be necessary to reduce the factors that have led to the rise of the conflict in the first place, which will include reducing the widespread poverty and inequality throughout the country. The Colombian government will need to find ways to increase economic development throughout the country to raise standards of living, which will include improving social mobility and better access to education (LaRosa and Mejía 2017). Making such moves will most likely reduce the number of children who choose to join armed groups or criminal gangs out of economic necessity. Improving the economic situation would also help to reduce the very high rate of domestic violence throughout the country, which has pushed many women and children to seek protection outside of their homes such as in the armed groups. The Colombian government will also have to ensure there is a suspension of hostilities by Colombia's armed forces so the guerrillas can emerge from the jungle and can hand over their weapons and peacefully reintegrate into society (Castro et al. 2017). This is essential as there are still criminal gangs, such as the *bacrim* and drug trafficking groups, operating throughout the country who provide an option for demobilising soldiers to rejoin an armed group.

The government must also regain control of the land previously under the control of the FARC for more than 50 years and ensure that there is effective redistribution. Struggles over land have been one of the most definitive factors of the armed conflict and one of the largest causes of violence. The many people returning to their land after being displaced by one of the armed groups will also remain a significant issue. The government has already started to address this and in 2011 the government passed the Victims and Land Restitution Law, which calls for more than 2 million hectares of land to be returned to the original owners, and has created the Colombian National Land Trust whereby 3 million hectares are to be distributed to 800,000 small farmer families (IOM 2017). Ensuring that land is effectively redistributed is an essential part of bringing stability to the country as well as improving development in rural areas (OECD 2017). It is also essential that the government find substitutions for farmers who have been working with illicit crops such as coca for the production of cocaine. The drug industry has been one of the greatest causes of violence in Colombia and so bringing an end to the violence will involve bringing an end to drug trafficking.

A successful road to peace for Colombia is also going to involve ensuring that the many soldiers who are emerging from the jungle are able to successfully demobilise and reintegrate back into Colombian society. The typical

process used around the world for bringing soldiers out of armed groups has been a disarmament, demobilisation and reintegration (DDR) program which involves soldiers agreeing to leave the armed group and hand over their weapons and ammunition to be destroyed (Denov 2010). Combatants are typically gathered in predetermined areas where they agree to hand in their weapons and return to civilian life (Denov 2010). They must agree that they will give up their military identities and behaviours associated with violence and return to civilian life (Theidon 2009). DDR programs often include economic assistance as well as technical or professional training (Theidon 2009). Demobilisation processes are also required to respect the rights of victims and ensure rights to truth, justice and reparation (Steinl 2017). The majority of DDR processes globally receive support from international organisations such as the World Bank and the UN agencies such as the United Nations Development Program (UNDP), UNICEF, United Nations Development Fund for Women (UNIFEM), International Organisation for Migration (IOM), International Labor Organisation (ILO) and other NGOs (Denov 2010). The support from international organisations helps to ensure that there is a successful transition to peace. Demobilisation and reintegration programs are considered to be essential to the peace process, bringing an end to conflict, and thus continue to play a role in most conflict situations around the world that involve children.

In Colombia, thousands of children have demobilised from the guerrilla groups throughout the various stages of the conflict. Since 1999, according to available figures from the IOM, 3793 children have demobilised from the FARC, most of whom have been male (IOM 2017). The ages of these children vary between 9 and 18 years old with the majority between 14 and 17 years old (IOM 2017). Most children who enter into the demobilisation process usually do so after they have escaped from the guerrilla or have been captured by the government armed forces. In Colombia, all reintegration programmes are implemented under the government-mandated Colombian Family Welfare Institute (ICBF) and receive support from the other agencies including the IOM and the United States Agency for International Development (USAID) (IOM 2017).

Montoya (2014), who conducted extensive fieldwork with the former child combatants at CAE, explained that the demobilisation process begins when a person is identified as being under 18 years of age and are then taken to a representative of the ICBF. The children are then given the option of going through the reintegration programme. Once an ex-combatant has agreed to enter into the demobilisation process, then they must agree to

abandon their illegal activities, hand in their weapons and agree that they will no longer be part of an illegal armed group. Upon agreement, they are given a package of benefits that include education, health, housing, therapy and skills development. Psychologists are available who aim to promote the personal, family and social development of the children and to help them with any problems they have while in the centre. They are given educational assistance and an emphasis is placed on relearning social skills. Every demobilised combatant must agree to develop a long-term plan related to education or business and upon completion, they are expected to graduate from the demobilisation programme (Mendez 2012). They then receive a lump sum of money to help them start their new lives as civilians. Reed (2014) argues that this programme has received some criticism as the children do not usually receive sufficient training or advice on how to use this money sustainably. Many then use the money quickly and are left without any means of support.

Once the former combatants reach 18 years old, they can receive further assistance from the programmes run by the Colombian Agency for Reintegration (ACR), which are demobilisation programmes for adults (Reed 2014). They also have the option to leave the demobilisation process and begin their new lives as civilians. This process has faced a number of challenges, one of them being that the children have been demobilising during an ongoing conflict. Children have to adapt back to a civilian life while surrounded by the violence that brought them into the conflict in the first place. Within this context, children must delegitimise the use of violence and uproot the ideologies associated with it (Woodward 2000). Children must learn to change the social and political practices they have learned through their physical, psychological and ideological training with the FARC and rebuild new identities that are built around non-violent ideals. These are values that have in part been shaped by Christian values and each Sunday the children would have to attend a church service inside the rehabilitation centre. They must reverse the ideas learned from living in conflict-affected areas and their perception that the guerrilla and violence are a normal and accepted part of daily life. Children must relearn how to behave, alter their value systems and recalibrate their understanding of good and bad. The world must be made meaningful to them again in new ways and this is what the reintegration process aims to do. They must transform their identities and enter a new lifeworld.

The demobilisation process, however, is no easy task. A number of demobilisation processes have been carried out in Colombia over the course

of the conflict, but after demobilising many people joined other criminal gangs. The demobilisation of the paramilitary, which was carried out in Colombia between 2003 and 2006, was widely recognised to have been a failure. The government began a 'peace process' with the leaders of the AUC in 2002 and within this time the Colombian government demobilised 31,671 AUC adult paramilitaries (Kemper 2012, p. 17). A 'demobilisation law' was passed in June 2005, which was criticised by numerous groups including Human Rights Watch for 'giving paramilitaries almost everything they want' and for not ensuring that the paramilitaries confessed their crimes, gave information about how their groups operated or turned over their illegally acquired wealth (Aviles 2006, p. 406). It was also criticised for not including specific protocols for children's demobilisation, despite three in every ten paramilitary combatants were under eighteen years of age (Montoya 2014, p. 4). The demobilisation process also took place during an ongoing conflict and as drug cartels were still operating throughout the country (Mendez 2012). Facing an uncertain future, a large percentage of the demobilised paramilitaries rearmed and joined armed groups.

After the demobilisation process, new groups began to form such as the Aguila Negras, the Rastrojos, the Urbanenos, the Paisas and the Gaitanistas. In 2007, it was found that there were at least 34 new criminal groups operating throughout the country (Guaqueta 2009). To avoid admitting to the failure of the demobilisation process, the government insisted that the paramilitary groups were no longer present and that the new groups were instead emerging criminal gangs, *bandas criminales emergentes* or *bacrim*s. Some of these new groups were led by former mid-level paramilitary leaders and followed similar command and control structures to those of the earlier paramilitary groups. They used similar tactics such as inflicting terror on local populations and recruiting children (Gray 2008, p. 72). These groups took over areas previously dominated by demobilised paramilitary, sowing terror, delivering threats, imposing curfews, killing criminals and prostitutes and controlling strategic routes through drug trafficking (Civico 2016).

The demobilisation process had not stopped the violence, nor had it stopped new armed groups from forming. According to one paramilitary fighter, 'the demobilisation is a farce. It's a way of quieting down the system and returning again, starting over from the other side' (Aviles 2006, p. 406). By January 2011, the head of the Colombian National Police declared the new armed groups to be the biggest threat to national security (Reed 2014). As a result, the demobilisation and reintegration

of more than 30,000 former members of the paramilitaries were largely deemed to be a failure. While the reintegration of ex-combatants into society does not guarantee durable peace, without it there will almost certainly be ongoing issues with security, transitional justice and peaceful coexistence over the long term (United Nations 2006). The return to civilian life, however, is not always an easy transition and the combatants often face a number of challenges, which I will explore below.

SHIFTING OUT OF THE VIOLENT LIFEWORLD

Johanna: *What do you want to do when you leave here?*

Juan Pablo: *Kill people*

Johanna: *Kill people?*

He laughs and says, *no just joking*

The above conversation took place with Juan Pablo, a former child guerrilla in CAE. Juan Pablo is from Guaviare, a region of Colombia that has been heavily dominated by the guerrilla. I spent a significant amount of time with Juan Pablo at CAE and he often expressed sadness at his experiences with the guerrilla. He left the CAE suddenly however I was later able to meet with him again at one of the other CAE's in the country. Since I left Colombia we have remained in contact on Facebook and on a number of occasions he has made similar comments about killing people or violence. Whether Juan Pablo was serious about his desire to return to killing people is difficult to determine. It is possible that he was making such comments to demonstrate his power. Alternatively he could have been making very serious statements about what he intended to do. What is significant about his statement, however, is that it shows that the violent structures in which Juan Pablo had grown up, as explored throughout this thesis, had normalised for him just as they had for many of the other former guerrillas. To kill people, or at least to joke about it, was something Juan Pablo considered acceptable, as it was to the other children from the armed groups. Within other contexts, where violent structures had not been part of the everyday norm, making such a statement might come across as shocking and frightening. However, as I listened to such comments being made throughout my fieldwork, particularly in the first phase with the children at CAE, it became evident that such casual references to violence were nor-

mal largely because they were a reflection of the structures of both their home lifeworlds and that of the armed group.

It was these normalised structures of violence that presented one of the greatest challenges for the reintegration staff and the reintegration process in general. The reintegration staff needed to find a way to shift the children away from the violent mentalities learned in the armed group and shift them into a more peaceful mindset where they could be productive civilians. They had to reverse the idea in the children that violence is normal and instead convince them that a path of non-violence was the best one for them. Essentially, they needed to shift the children from the lifeworld of the FARC into the lifeworld of the civilian. They had to transform their identities. However, this transition came with a number of challenges. Oscar Gomez, a 52-year-old former guerrilla whom I met in San Jose del Guaviare, reflected on the challenges of reintegration. Having grown up in Vaupes, one of the more remote departments of Colombia that had been dominated by the conflict and significant poverty, the guerrillas and the armed conflict had been around him for much of his life. As we sat in a quiet corner of my hotel lobby he explained:

The people are living in such poverty, since they were little they have grown up with this. It's a really big problem. They need to change their mind. For many children here in Colombia they only see bad. Killing, no work, those are the ones who are usually stealing. It is because of a lack of education. Since they were little they haven't had a chance to see anything else apart from bad things. They become guerrillas from a very young age and their way of thinking begins from a very young age and they can't think in a different way.

For Oscar Gomez, transforming the children's minds out of the violent lifeworlds is a significant task. He attributes this to the children's mindsets being shaped by poverty and violence since they were young. This was further reflected in Leah's observations. Throughout our time together at CAE, we often spent time after work in one of the small local cafes drinking coffee trying to understand the complexities of the lives of the children with whom we were working. During one of these conversations, Leah reflected:

I see violence there every day. I see punches thrown, it could be done jokingly, but it's quite normal. And then some days actual fighting breaks out because they're angry or mad. When we have internet time and they start googling the Colombian war and guns and they're happy about it. I remember when there was a really big fight between the children at CAE and the children at Don

Bosco and I haven't seen the children come back with that much energy and that many smiles on their faces. Ever. They were so pumped up about it. (Volunteer, age 24, Medellín)

Being able to participate in a fight with the children from Don Bosco that day had given the children at CAE a sense of enjoyment. They also enjoyed looking for pictures of weapons and armed groups. Certainly, my own observations while in the reintegration centre were similar to Leah's. As shown in previous chapters, I would often find children searching for images of violence and weapons on the Internet and speaking of violence and the armed conflict in general in a positive way.

Arcesio, an educator at CAE who became a friend as well as a trusted informant, reflected on how these mindsets presented a great difficulty in shifting the children away from the world of the guerrilla. After I had left CAE during the second phase of my fieldwork, we met on several occasions in a café in the centre of Medellín where he explained the following:

Arcesio: I don't think signing the peace agreement will bring peace to Colombia. Many of those that are in the guerrilla don't want to change their way of life, they're afraid because they don't know anything different from war.

Johanna: Do you think most of them are still on the side of the FARC?

Arcesio: Well yes, since they were really little they were educated by the FARC.

Johanna: What do you think it is like for them when they come out of the FARC?

Arcesio: Well I think when they come out they realize that a lot of people don't think well of the FARC. But they also realize that the government is incompetent which is what they were told in the FARC. So they think what they were doing in the FARC is good. This is what I saw with them (age 26, Medellín).

Arcesio makes several important points. He first notes the reluctance of the children to shift away from the guerrilla identity, which he in part attributes to them being influenced by the FARC from a young age. As mentioned above, this presents significant challenges to the reintegration staff. They must convince the children to forget about what they have learned and to relearn a new set of values and ideas. This is made more difficult as children emerge from the jungle, as Arcesio points out, to find that the government is corrupt and poverty is widespread which confirms the FARC's processes of legitimization. This makes the reintegration process

more difficult as children have fewer viable reasons to leave behind the world of the FARC and accept the civilian lifeworld. Yahir, one of the children from CAE who grew up in the guerrilla, reflected on this when I asked what it was like when he left the guerrilla:

It was strange because it was really different in the FARC, I saw a really different environment, it's really different there. (age 17, Manizales)

For Yahir, transitioning into civilian life was a difficult process, largely because the lifeworld of the guerrilla was so different from the civilian lifeworld. The transition between these worlds required a shift in the values and understandings of the world which he had learned in the FARC, which was not an easy task. Andres, who had joined the FARC as a child in Guaviare, also reported some difficulties in adapting back to a civilian way of life, specifically with leaving behind the idea of the police and the military as being an enemy. He was now living in San Jose del Guaviare after going through the reintegration process and made the following comment about coming back into civilian life:

To see police, to see military and to see so many civilians it was really strange. The army was once your enemy and then you're on the side of them which is strange. But you get used to it and you realise that the army is the same as you and now we're friends. I say hi to them, but at first when I saw them I felt really afraid, before when we saw them we would try to hide. But now it's normal, now I can walk in the city and I don't have to be afraid of anybody. (age 24, San Jose del Guaviare)

Thus, as reflected in the narratives above, for the young people going through the reintegration process there were a number of factors that required a shift in their values, beliefs and perceptions of the world. These included reversing ideas of 'othering' as taught to them by the FARC and learning to accept that the government armed forces were not an enemy. This is significant as the FARC's process of othering and dehumanising the Colombian government and their armed forces have been the basis of much of their violent action including killing, extortion and kidnapping. Thus, ensuring the sedimentation of this as a value in their recruits has had political and economic importance for the FARC. Reversing these ideas that the army and the police are enemies who are legitimate targets to be killed is a significant part of the reintegration process. The reintegration

staff at CAE were attempting to do this with a programme where a policeman came weekly and would go into the garden with the children to clean up rubbish. The idea was that they would do this somewhat degrading job together, allowing them to work on equal footing.

Several of the children who have left CAE have gone on to join the government army. As the FARC view the government army as the enemy, this is a significant shift, although there are several reasons it could occur. It may be because the ‘othering’ of the army as taught to them by the FARC had not sedimented deeply for them, or because their motive for joining the FARC had been economic rather than ideological so switching alliances was not considered problematic. In addition, while the reintegration staff would prefer the children to do something not involved with the military, joining the government army would not necessarily be seen in a bad way since those who are not involved with the guerrilla regard it as a ‘legitimate’ group and see the army’s violence as ‘legitimate’. What is seen as more important by CAE staff is that the children shift away from the ideology of the FARC, as an essential element of the peace process. Some of the other significant challenges to reintegrating the children will be explored below.

DEMOBILISING IN VIOLENCE

One of the challenges for the demobilisation process is that it has been taking place within the context of continued conflict. Violence has continued to be widespread throughout Colombia as has the trafficking of drugs. Demobilisation processes have been attempted in other contexts where fighting is still taking place, such as by UNICEF in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC), and were often unsuccessful. As one Congolese NGO noted, ‘demobilisation in the middle of war is neither possible nor permanent’ (Thomas 2008, p. 13). One of the consequences of children demobilising during an ongoing conflict is that they still have the option to rejoin an armed group. There are still numerous groups operating throughout the country including the *bacrim*, various paramilitary groups and the ELN. Since the FARC have demobilised there have been reports of *bacrim*s going into areas that have previously been dominated by the FARC and trying to recruit ex-FARC members (United Nations 2017). In 2017, the ELN agreed to engage in peace talks with the Colombian government in Quito, Ecuador, however, little progress has been made. For the peace process to go ahead, the ELN is required to stop kidnapping, extortion,

recruiting children and attacking infrastructure and public forces (IOM 2017).

Up until now, violence by all the armed groups continues to present a major challenge to the successful reintegration of children who belonged to those groups. As much was reflected during a conversation with Mauricio, one of the former child combatants, one afternoon at CAE. We were sitting in one of the staff offices and our conversation had turned to the conflict. Mauricio had previously been in CAE and had left to go home but had to return after having problems with some of the armed groups in the area where he was living. He said:

It's not going to be easy, the problem is that there are so many gangs in the neighborhoods, so it's complicated because of this. There are people who for their whole lives have only been in armed groups and so if they leave the mountains they are going to get involved with these groups again. It's very difficult to change their lives, it is for this reason that they get involved with the gangs. It's difficult in the demobilisation process. For someone who hasn't studied and doesn't like to be inside it is difficult to come here and be inside all the time.

Johanna: *But you are doing it.*

Mauricio: *Abh yes, but not all the people think the same. Everyone is different.* (age 18, Medellín)

As Mauricio points out, while there are some children such as himself who were willing to participate in the demobilisation process, there were many who were tempted to rejoin one of the armed groups and go back to a life of violence. Almost all of my participants expressed fears that the demobilisation of the FARC will yield the same results as attempts at demobilisation in the previous decade. Javier, a policeman who was held as a hostage by the FARC for almost ten years and had therefore spent significant time amongst children from the FARC, also explains the possibilities of children returning to the armed groups:

To kill is normal. It is what they have to do. They talk about it like it's normal. This is a really big challenge when children re-enter society and for peace. They have to be re-educated. The police always have a huge job because violence is something so normal. In the cities as well because all of these violent people from the armed groups arrive. It happened with the EPL, it happened with the paramilitaries and it is going to happen with the FARC as well. (age 44, Villavicencio)

For the children at CAE, the presence of the paramilitary groups or the *bacrim* certainly posed a threat to their reintegration. As described in Chapter 2, the demobilisation centre was located in a neighbourhood that was controlled by *bacrim* and violence was widespread throughout the neighbourhood. With these groups present around the demobilisation home, the presence of these groups around the demobilisation home, then, posed great challenges to the reintegration staff for reversing the idea that violence and armed groups were normal. The *bacrim* also presented the children with options. Many of them joined an armed group in hopes of achieving social mobility; however, the skills learned in armed groups cannot necessarily help them in other social fields. The use of violence may be the only skill they have to offer which can be an obstacle for them when they want to transition from combatant to civilian. Children who believe that they have few choices view joining a group such as the *bacrim* as attractive. Jose Daniel, the former guerrilla and educator at CAE, reflected on this during one of our conversations at a café in Medellín, where we met on several occasions during the second phase of my fieldwork:

All of us have been born for something, these people who are born with the military mentality are dangerous. There are people who like to have guns. So this is one of the problems that the government has, is what to do with all of these people. They might demobilise but if these people want to continue with this life they will. The thing is that when somebody has had a gun and had power over somebody else's life they don't want to give up this power. They miss it. (age 22, Medellín)

This was again reflected in another conversation with him:

When one person is used to being powerful and having control, it's difficult to change.

As the FARC goes through the demobilisation process, other armed groups have already shown interest in taking the land previously dominated by the FARC. The drug trafficking corridors, previously dominated by the FARC, have already become of prime interest to the other armed groups (Dickson 2016). Neo-paramilitary groups have reportedly carried out military operations, taking over entire towns by blocking all major roadways and targeting the police and military forces (Castro et al. 2017, p. 5). Just days before the peace agreement was finalised, María Emilsen Angulo Guevara, the mayor of Tumaco, a municipality with a long guerrilla

presence, wrote to President Santos asking for help to combat a new armed group, ‘which aspires to continue the extortions and drug trafficking’ (Dickson 2016). Without help from the government, Emilsen described a ‘cruel, bleak outlook’ for her town (Dickson 2016). This poses a direct threat to the demobilisation process because there remain so many options for children to become part of armed groups.

FOCUSING ON THE FUTURE

One of the key ways the reintegration staff tried to encourage the children to move out of the violent lifeworld of the FARC was to encourage them to focus on the future. Discussions of the past were discouraged, particularly those centred on their life with the guerrilla. A strong emphasis was placed on getting the children to put their experiences with the guerrilla behind them and to refocus their aspirations and identities on being back in the civilian world. However, this process also faced challenges as many of the ex-combatants believed that violence and war are natural and would inevitably always feature in their world. It was difficult for many of the children to believe that peace would ever be able to come to Colombia:

The war will continue like always, they are going to return to war. The groups will continue to fight, the FARC may have finished but there are a lot of groups. There are some who want to work and study but there are others who don't want and are going to continue with the same thing. The war will continue. (Former child guerrilla, age 16, Medellín)

Amongst my participants who had not fought in the armed groups, there was also a general sense that peace would not come to Colombia. One afternoon I was invited into the home of David, an informant in Villavencio, for lunch with his family. When we finished lunch, we moved to the living room where the conversation turned to the conflict. The family recounted many tales of violence that had been carried out by the FARC over the years. We spent the afternoon sharing stories and the conversation ended with their thoughts on the peace process. The entire family agreed that peace was not likely to come to Colombia. The father of my informant said:

The guerrilla only exist to grow drugs. They're not political, they're just talking, they're in Havana in this moment and they're not coming to any agreement because of the amount of money that they have.

Gustavo, an informant in Buenaventura, also expressed his doubt that peace could come to Colombia. He was an Afro-Colombian who had grown up in Buenaventura and was aware of the many realities of the armed conflict, in particular the violence of the paramilitaries. One afternoon we were sitting in his small apartment in the centre of Buenaventura. With a market bustling below us and the afternoon heat streaming in, we began to discuss the conflict and he observed:

Right now we are in a peace process but Santos wants to be a hero for Colombia but it's impossible because history shows us that the peace process takes a long time. The leaders are in Cuba at the beach, drinking rum, smoking tobacco, relaxing, maybe talking but not doing anything. The opinion is very divided in Colombia, maybe half think it's something good whereas the other half don't think that it's something good. (Student, age 24)

Gustavo's sentiments were common amongst my participants. They believed that neither the government nor the FARC were taking the peace process seriously and because of this, they were generally reluctant to believe that peace would actually ever come to Colombia. It was also an idea that was particularly prevalent amongst the children from CAE. All of those with whom I have stayed in contact on Facebook have expressed a reluctance to believe that peace could ever come to Colombia. Such beliefs certainly pose a significant challenge to the peace process as without the belief that it is possible to live in a world characterised by peace, then how will it be possible for Colombians to construct a world that is shaped by peaceful ideas?

Gustavo, who was a university student and not involved with any of the armed groups, or violence in Colombia, had views that reflected the pessimism about the plight of his country. He believed that because violence had been prevalent for so long, it was unlikely to ever be any different. He did, however, know that there were opportunities in his country in which he could become involved, that did not involve violence. In the case of the children at CAE, most of them were unaware that there were opportunities to do things that were not violent or even that it was possible to live in a peaceful country. They are therefore much more likely to replicate violent ideas, simply because they do not know anything else.

Another significant challenge for children demobilising was that many of them were unable to return home upon finishing the demobilisation process, because there was still a heavy presence of guerrilla. Returning

home could mean a high chance of re-recruitment or, in cases where the children had escaped, there was a high risk of repercussions from the guerrilla. Escape is considered treason by the guerrilla and is almost always punished through a war council and the offender killed. This was a fact that was reiterated by a number of my participants, including all of the ex-guerrilla with whom I met, both the children in CAE and in the second phase of my research. Those who had been captured by the government, the ex-guerrilla explained, did not have to worry about repercussions from the guerrilla, since they had not left the group by choice. However, those who had chosen to escape had to be concerned about being caught by the guerrilla because if they were, they would most likely be killed. Several of the children at CAE were unable to return home for this reason and indeed when many of the children finished their demobilisation process they stayed in one of the bigger cities. For children who came from areas still dominated by the guerrilla, returning home was often impossible.

The risks facing these children became apparent to me during one of the family weekends at CAE. Once a year the families of the children at CAE were allowed to come and spend a weekend at an event called *encuentro* or meeting. I was there on one of these occasions and I sat in a meeting between the director of CAE and the families. The families were asking the director if it would be possible for the children to return home. The director explained that if they lived in what she referred to as the ‘corridor of violence’, the threat to the children’s safety was too great. I watched as parents put up their hands to ask if their village or town was considered safe enough for their children to return and the director shook or nodded her head. Observing this meeting highlighted not only the extent to which the violence had pervaded the lives of these children and their families, but also the enormity of the weight that these young people and their families were carrying. Those who had chosen to escape the guerrilla, some only 16 years old, were living with the knowledge that they were wanted individuals. They were at serious risk of execution if caught by the guerrilla and this made their situation at CAE precarious. When I asked Andres during our interview if he was afraid of the FARC, he reflected on his fears:

Well a little bit, I know that they can kill you but I also know how to avoid this. Living in the city I'll be fine but if I go to where they are then obviously they are going to kill me. (Former child guerrilla, age 24, San Jose del Guaviare)

Such fears were also reflected by one of the children from CAE. One day I saw Joiber, a 16-year-old boy, sitting on some steps inside CAE looking miserable. I asked him what was wrong and he explained that his family was not going to be able to come to the latest *encuentro*. I asked if he would see them when he left CAE and he shook his head. ‘I can’t go home’, he said, ‘the guerrilla will kill me’.

STIGMATISATION, RESENTMENT AND ACCEPTANCE

Another significant challenge to reintegrating children was acceptance. Mendez (2012) found that most ex-combatants from the FARC have said that one of the reasons they demobilised was to reunite with their families; however, many found difficulties in adapting to their new roles with their families. This is especially the case when reuniting with children they left behind. Some women who had joined the armed group when they had children stated that their children were resentful and angry at them because they had left them. Some children also mentioned that their families had been stigmatised for having a guerrilla member in the family. Many of my participants agreed that returning former combatants face stigmatisation from neighbours, peers, teachers and employers who both fear them and are critical of their actions with the armed group. Take this statement from Gustavo:

People will look badly at the guerrilla. They won't think that they are a child anymore, so they think that it would be okay to kill them. The majority of people hate the guerrilla because we have been in conflict for more than 50 years. Many people in Colombia don't know why the guerrilla started, they just know that they're bad people. (Computer Engineer, age 30, Cali)

It is sentiments such as these expressed by Gustavo that reflect the type of stigmatisation that individuals coming out of the guerrilla were facing. There was a general unwillingness amongst the Colombian population to accept demobilised guerrillas back into society and for those who did return, they were seen with a sense of disdain. This was made evident to me on several occasions throughout my fieldwork. During my interview with Katherine in Neiva, she was happily explaining about her new boyfriend, but said that his family was not happy with their relationship because they were aware that she had previously been in the guerrilla.

The children at Don Bosco also discriminated against the children at CAE. I often heard the boys referring to them as ‘bad people’ and speaking about them in mocking tones. On one occasion, I asked one of the boys from CAE how the relations between the children at CAE and the boys at Don Bosco worked, as the children from CAE went there each day for their classes. He shrugged his shoulders and said, ‘they discriminate against us because we were in the guerrilla and we discriminate against them because they are from the street’. The fight between the children from CAE and those from the guerrilla, mentioned above, and the enjoyment generated from it were mostly likely due to this resentment between these two groups of children that was based on their different affiliations with the violence in Colombia. Thus, the children faced challenges of being accepted back into society by adults, as well as by other children.

According to Colombian law, those who come out of the armed groups who are under 18 years old are considered victims. The Peace and Justice Law (Law 975 of 2005) states that all children and adolescents affected by the conflict are considered victims and have the right to reparation (Mendez 2012, p. 113). This law also offers amnesty and pardon to individuals who choose to demobilise voluntarily. This responsibility of the state for reparation is outlined in Decree 1290 of 2008, the ‘Program of Individual Reparation for the Victim Via Administration of the Victims of the Armed Groups Outside of the law’ (Reed 2014, p. 15). In July 2012, as part of the peace process, the government enacted a Constitutional Amendment, the Legal Framework for Peace, which allows Congress to limit the scope of prosecutions of atrocities by guerrillas, paramilitaries and the military if a peace agreement is reached with the FARC. It also provides statutory immunity to others who planned, executed and covered up the same crimes but are not deemed most responsible (Reed 2014, p. 15). However, it was agreed in the peace agreement that a special tribunal would be established to prosecute war crimes and other atrocities committed by the guerrilla. All combatants are eligible for alternative sentences but in some cases may be criminally prosecuted. It remains one of the most controversial elements of the peace deal (United Nations 2017). The law has faced criticism, due to the high level of amnesty granted to ex-combatants, the lack of compulsory confession and its lack of reparations to victims, and for not successfully punishing perpetrators for human rights abuses, such as sexual violence (Mendez 2012).

Amongst my own participants, the terms of the peace agreement had not been well received. Perly, a young Colombian teacher living in Neiva,

reflected on her own views of the guerrilla being given benefits. While Perly had not been directly affected by the conflict living in the centre of Neiva, she was well aware of the problems that had been generated throughout Colombia because of the conflict:

I really don't agree with a couple of things. The government really wants to give the guerrilla so many benefits and they get away with so many things. It's so unfair. And the victims. What if I run into my former kidnapper? I think that it has to be really hard if this guy was beating me or this guy was doing that to me, and I have to see him in the street. It has to be really hard. There are some TV commercials that say: 'come guerrilla we are saving a place for you'. It makes me mad. I know they deserve a chance, I agree with that. And I believe that every human being can change and become a better person. But treating them like nothing happened? (age 32, Nieva)

Arcesio also reflected on some of the difficulties related to the benefits received by demobilised guerrilla during one of our conversations at a café in the centre of Medellín:

It's really difficult for us as well because we see the government giving so many benefits to the guerrillas knowing what damage they have done to the country. It's going to be really difficult. (Educator at CAE, age 26, Medellín)

Throughout my fieldwork, I spoke to many Colombians who expressed fear of having to live alongside the demobilised combatants. Perly's perspective, for example, while she had not been directly affected by the violence with the guerrilla, she felt afraid of them:

Perly: I would be so nervous I knew someone in the guerrilla. Because you can't really know if you can be honest with them. What if you say something wrong? What are they going to do, kill you? It's frightening.

Johanna: I guess I never felt afraid of any of the guerrillas.

Perly: I think that it's easier for you. You can leave. You can forget about them. You can pretend you never met them. But for us this is our place. What if you say something that they don't like? What if you do something that they think is unforgiveable. Where can you go?

The displaced people are not having an easy life. They have to run all the time. They have to hide. They have to be scared all the time. They have to fear for their kids. It's a nightmare. (Teacher, age 32, Nieva)

Pamela, a geography student living in Cauca, also explained why she felt resentment towards the guerrilla. She too had not been directly affected by the guerrilla but had grown up where there was guerrilla activity taking place not far from where she was living. She became a friend and a trusted informant and during one of our many conversations in her small home in Cauca, she said the following:

Pamela: I'm lucky because I can study and I have my friends and family and we haven't had any problems with kidnappings or anything. But I have friends who have had their parents killed and so they are really angry with the guerrilla. They kidnap people for money. So they would kidnap people and they would say pay me a lot of money and so people would have to sell their homes and their cars and then the guerrilla would kill the person. So the family would be totally broken and the kidnapped person is dead.

Johanna: Why would they kill the person?

Pamela: Because they don't care. They have the money. There are other cases where they would release the person. In other cases the person would give the guerrilla the money and then the guerrilla would say that they want more money. The person would say no and they would say okay well we are going to kill the person. So they would have to go to the bank and get a loan.

Johanna: So the people must be very afraid?

Pamela: Yes of course. (Geography student, age 28, Cauca)

The widespread violence perpetrated by the guerrilla has led to feelings of resentment and to the stigmatisation of former combatants returning home, all of which presents a challenge to children re-entering the civilian world. Goffman (1963) explores the realities and implications of stigma and how stigmatised individuals are able to navigate social worlds that are likely to condemn them for their previous actions. According to Goffman, stigma is a natural part of all societies and provides a system of evaluating members on the basis of a number of factors. Stigma can weaken one's ability to feel normal and make people feel as if they are not quite human. This plays a powerful role in dictating social status and how one interacts with others. In the case of child soldiers, Theresa Betancourt (2011) found in her study in Sierra Leone that stigma came largely from family and community and led to greater experiences of stress and a lowered social status. In Colombia, the stigma placed on the guerrilla has meant that many children who have returned home have had difficulties being fully accepted back into their communities. This played a significant role in how children have been able

to move back into the civilian world and reconstruct their identities as civilians. Leah reflected on this view of children needing acceptance to reintegrate:

I think that a big part of the feeling better of their roles outside of the guerrilla is acceptance. I think that one of the reasons why they left their families to go and join the guerrilla is because they were looking for inclusion and acceptance and if they leave all of that then they have to find new ways of being included and accepted. They can kind of find that in CAE but when they leave they're in this big city where a lot of people want them dead or who think that they are stealing resources. (Volunteer, age 24, Medellin)

Love and acceptance from their families and encouragement to pursue a life that was not dominated by violence or being part of an armed group were key factors for the reintegration process and bringing children back into the civilian lifeworld. As Krijin (2006) points out, the attitudes of communities towards children returning from armed groups play a considerable role in the creation of poor youths who were easily recruited by the fighting forces in general. These attitudes create a mental barrier in the minds of those wanting to escape and especially for those who do escape. If the attitudes of communities towards returning combatants were not hostile, then it is likely that many more would return.

BECOMING A CIVILIAN AGAIN

Towards the end of my fieldwork, I travelled to Manizales to meet with Yahir, a young boy with whom I had worked at CAE. We had remained in regular contact through Facebook and he invited me to visit him in the foster home where he had gone to live after leaving CAE. Children who could not return home after they finished the demobilisation programme due to security threats had the option to live with a foster family. The Colombian government sponsored the programme to assist children such as Yahir. In his case, he had explained that he was born in the guerrilla and so upon graduating from the demobilisation process, he had nowhere to go. It is typically not allowed for guerrilla to have children: however, in Yahir's case an exception had been made because his father was a commander. We met in the small, mountainous city where he invited me to his new home not far from the city centre. As we settled down in the small but cosy living room, he described his experience of entering into civilian life:

Yahir: *So I grew up with the FARC, they taught me everything. But after 14 years they caught me, the paramilitaries. So they handed us over to the defensoria del pueblo (local government), then they took us to the alcadia (local government) and then to the police. When we were handed over we spent four days in a hotel and then we were taken to bienestar familiar. Then we arrived to Medellin, to a foundation. And there I began my process.*

Johanna: *And how was it when you first left the FARC, in CAE, in civilian life was it better?*

Yahir: *Yes much better. Because you can study, you can have a family. Now I have a house, a bed. Now I'm thinking about a better future because I have what I need. Before when you're poor and you don't have anything you go to the group because you think it will be better.* (Former child guerrilla, age 17, Manizales)

Yahir is regularly attending school and has made no specific references about returning to the guerrilla or to any armed group and is a positive example of a child moving forward with his life. While that is not a definitive indicator that Yahir has completely left behind his attachment to the FARC, it is a positive sign that he is showing a willingness to move into the civilian world and adopt a civilian way of life. Since leaving Colombia, for the children from CAE with whom I have stayed in contact, I have watched as their new lives as civilians unfold on Facebook. I regularly see photos of what appears to be them enjoying daily life in their homes with friends. One of the boys posts regular videos of new rap videos he has made. Katherine, the young former guerrilla with whom I had worked at CAE, now has a boyfriend and often posts photos of them together, indicating that she has chosen a life as a civilian. Several of the children have said that they have continued with their studies and have stayed in one of the cities rather than returning home. Several of the children have also gone on to join the Colombian armed forces, and on occasion, I see photos of them in their uniforms. On several occasions, I have seen children posting pictures on Facebook with guns, although I am uncertain where exactly the photos have been taken or what they were doing with the guns. However, from my observations of the children in CAE, when they looked at images of guns on the Internet or showed pictures of themselves with guns, they always did so with happiness that was in relation to their experience with the armed group.

As ex-combatants continue to have experiences associated with studies and new relationships, it can be hoped that these form new structures in their lives that form new lifeworlds that are not shaped by guns and violence. With exposure to new phenomena, it is possible that the children

can redefine their identities as their civilian lifeworlds become meaningful. For children to be able to move into their civilian identities, they must move away from the idea that violence is a natural part of the world. Young recruits must learn to find legitimacy in the civilian world. They must learn to see the Colombian people as one group, where they are not divided as 'others'. Children must relearn boundaries around violence and understand that violence and killing are no longer an acceptable part of daily life. They must learn values that are shaped by peace and learn behaviours that are not defined by violence. For this to happen in Colombia, there will have to be a complete shift in the consciousness of the entire country that makes violence and the use of violence completely unacceptable. This will require a shift away from values systems in which young men believe they can achieve social status and prestige from being violent. When this happens and violence decreases, young women will no longer search for violent men to feel protected which will give men less reason to see value in being violent. If this can be combined with an improved economy and more opportunities for young people to seek prosperous lives for themselves and their families, then there will undoubtedly be fewer children looking for alternative sources of survival in Colombia, such as joining an armed group.

MOVING FORWARD AND ECONOMIC OPPORTUNITIES

Economic assistance is an essential factor for the reintegration process. As former guerrilla Oscar Gomez explains above, one of the primary reasons children become involved with armed groups is because of a poor economic situation and limited opportunities. Returning to an environment characterised by poverty and a lack of opportunities was a major concern for many of the former combatants at CAE. Many felt that their lack of work experience or education would affect their chances of finding a means of survival once they left the demobilisation process. Martha Campina, a social worker working with demobilised adult guerrilla in San Jose del Guaviare, said:

There are people who come back with a lot of fear, they are worried about their economic situation. They come out of the guerrilla with no experience and not knowing how to live in the world. When they find work they stay but when they don't they often go back to the armed groups. (Age 34)

The frustration of having few opportunities when returning home was reflected in many of the narratives of the former combatants from CAE.

Many of the children expressed a desire to do something different with their lives and to 'move forward' as they so often expressed it. However, they were uncertain and doubtful. One sunny afternoon at CAE I was talking to John, a former guerrilla from the FARC, about the future. He was narrating his story of trafficking drugs across the border to Venezuela before joining the guerrilla. He was only 17 years old and already had extensive experience as a drug trafficker and as a guerrilla in the FARC. He was explaining that he wanted to be a chef and that he was going to try, but that if he could not find an opportunity then he was going to have to go back to the illegal economy. A few weeks later I found out that John had been sent to a drug rehabilitation programme in another part of Medellín after he was found consuming drugs at CAE. I later heard that he had escaped and was now thought to be living on the streets of Medellín. I assumed he had gone back to the illegal economy, and later I learned that John had been sent to prison for drug trafficking. Whether John had returned to narco-trafficking because he had not been able to find an opportunity that did not involve violence or because it was simply the easiest option, is difficult to know. However, what was certain was that John, like most of the children at CAE, was simply trying to survive in an environment that offered him little opportunity. Drugs and armed groups provide a lucrative and easy form of survival when there are few other options.

These issues were raised by Jose Daniel one afternoon in a café in Medellín:

Many of the paramilitary who demobilised have come to form the bancrimis in Medellín. So the FARC demobilised, great but what are they going to do with these people? There's no work. The amount of people that are in these groups is terrible and so is the amount of children. It's possible that a small group of the demobilised guerrillas are going to return to the war. (Former child guerrilla, age 22, Medellín)

Jose Daniel's concerns were reflected by many of my participants. Providing children with economic support and educational opportunities will require fundamental structural changes to address Colombia's unemployment and educational problems as well as problems with drug trafficking, corruption and inequality. Nestor, a friend and informant living in a wealthier part of Bogotá, who had been able to remain somewhat at a distance from the conflict, explained:

The reason for the conflict is the lack of education. If you have educated people and everyone has rights and everyone is equal then you won't have conflict. You'll just talk. People won't kill just because someone told him to. I think the main cause of the violence is education. (Engineer, age 25, Bogota)

Thus, for children to be able to successfully reintegrate into their civilian lifeworlds, they are going to need opportunities and a means of finding empowerment. It is also going to mean addressing the issues that have caused so much violence in Colombia. The drug trade, for example, will continue to be a problem for the reintegration of children as without lucrative alternatives, they may continue to see drug trafficking groups as a means of making income. In an early 2018 Facebook conversation, I asked one of the boys with whom I worked at CAE how he felt the peace process was progressing. He replied that it was not going well that there were more and more criminal gangs who were struggling to gain control over territory, drug trafficking routes and illegal mining. 'As long as there is cocaine, there will never be peace', he said. The Colombian government has already attempted to address this issue by creating a crop substitution programme, and it is estimated that 80,000 farmers have joined (UN 2017). However, reports have shown that coca growing has increased as farmers are planting coca to be able rip it up again and receive payment (UN 2017). The drug issue, as long as cocaine remains a lucrative source of income, will remain a major challenge to the successful reintegration of children in Colombia.

Since then, there have been increasing reports of children rejoining various armed groups. In 2018, it was reported by the Office of the Human Rights Ombudsman that there may be as many as 800 former FARC-EP fighters who had formed or joined other illegal armed or criminal groups, which would make up approximately 11% of ex-combatants (OHCHR 2018). There have also been reports of the ELN and other illegal armed groups recruiting persons younger than 18. During the year, the government launched a programme called 'My future is today' to counter recruitment of child soldiers in 500 at-risk villages, affecting an estimated 27,000 minors and 15,000 families (US State Department 2018).

Improving the economy is perhaps one of the most important ways in which the Colombian government can ensure that children no longer return to armed groups as well as bringing sustainable peace to Colombia. Improving the economic situation will mean ensuring that the wealth generated from the country's lucrative resources is shared more equally, ensuring better job opportunities in poorer regions, higher public invest-

ment to improve infrastructure and lower costs of doing trade (OECD 2017). Most of the guerrilla with whom I spoke in Colombia spoke of problems in the home that were the result of economic stressors. As I have shown, it was these problems that pushed many young people to leave their homes and join an armed group. With fewer economic challenges, there will be less stress on family members which will most likely result in less violence in the home. With less violence in the home and more opportunities to attend school and seek a meaningful career, there will be fewer children looking to join armed groups as means of escaping their home lives. The government has also begun to address this issue and will invest in infrastructure projects in areas where the FARC was dominant (United Nations 2017).

Equal participation for both genders in the economy is also essential. All of my female participants spoke of violence and gender inequality being a serious issue in Colombia. Many of the girls who joined armed groups did so in relation to the endemic machismo throughout the country and the insecurity that it brings. Women must be given equal opportunities in the workplace to reduce their vulnerability to abuse, particularly in rural areas as women who work in informal jobs where earnings are lower are likely to have less social protection (OECD 2017). With more opportunities to access income, women and girls may be less likely to see joining an armed group as a means of escaping violence. There must also be institutional reform and the transformation of all institutions that have contributed to the conflict or systematic violence, including the judicial sector and criminal justice system (Steinl 2017). More effective justice systems that protect women and girls from physical and sexual violence would also give girls alternatives to seeking protection in armed groups.

CONCLUSION

This chapter has shown that there are numerous factors that play a role in the successful reintegration of children into Colombian society. These include children returning to environments where there is still a heavy presence of armed groups and where violence is still considered a normal part of daily life. As thousands of children are leaving the FARC since their demobilisation, the stigma faced by the children in the wider society as they come home poses a further challenge to their reintegration. It is only with time that Colombian society will be able to forget about the violence that has shaped its history for so long and accept the ex-combatants

back into their society. There remain, however, a number of significant challenges to their successful reintegration. The poor economic situation in Colombia is one of these challenges. Without alternatives, many children may be left with few other options but to rejoin an armed group or to become involved in the illegal economy. Addressing the issues surrounding poverty are therefore essential if Colombia is to successfully reintegrate the children who are coming out of the armed groups. It will also be essential in providing young people with alternative means of achieving power and self-worth. For now, Colombia sits precariously on the edge of peace. As armed groups such as the ELN, the *bacrim*s and various paramilitary groups are still prevalent throughout the country, Colombia has a long road ahead ensuring that the violent structures that have led young people to become involved in violence in the country are no longer prevalent.

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Conclusion: Colombia and the Road to Peace

Since the signing of the Additional Protocols of the Geneva Conventions in 1977, the global community has shown a continued commitment to keeping children out of armed conflict. The establishment of the International Criminal Court (ICC) in 1988 and the criminal prosecution of numerous warlords for the recruitment of children demonstrate that across the globe, there is widespread agreement that children should be kept out of war. As conflict and violence continue to threaten many parts of the world, continued research becomes all the more pertinent to understanding the changing dynamics of conflict and the ways in which it affects children. Anthropological research in particular has a significant capacity to contribute to knowledge about how and why children become involved in armed groups and to delve into the intricate cultural nuances that shape children's recruitment and militarisation. Thus, anthropological research can play an important role in drawing attention to the fact that the experiences of child recruitment across the globe are not the same. This is particularly relevant where international bodies such as the United Nations and international NGOs are involved in reintegration efforts but might not be aware of the local cultural factors that have influenced recruitment and militarisation.

Such research can therefore not only help international bodies and institutions shape policy to better understand the factors that draw children into armed conflict but can also draw attention to human rights abuses and atrocities that might otherwise go unnoticed. By taking into consideration the complex cultural nuances that run deep through the social fabric of

the diverse environments in which children are recruited, anthropological research has a significant capacity to contribute to implementing reintegration practices in a way that is meaningful to the children coming out of armed groups. It can help to build more contextualised, culturally appropriate understandings of why children become involved in war and more importantly why they stay involved.

This book has examined the cultural nuances of the entire process that children undergo in order to ‘become’ soldiers in the Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (FARC) in the context of Colombia. I went beyond the current humanitarian perspectives on child soldiers and, using anthropological methods, delved deeper into the specific social and cultural aspects of the Colombian conflict to give a contextualised, culturally relevant understanding of the militarisation of children. By showing how children can go through phenomenological transformations of their identities along with shifts in their social environments, I have shown how children have become militarised and have joined the lifeworld of the FARC. I have given a nuanced insight into the realities of children who have joined the FARC, and I have analysed the specific factors that have led them to join an armed group. To effectively understand the militarisation of children in Colombia, it is essential to examine how children have been taught ‘to be’ in the world and how they have been taught to conform their behaviour, values and morals to fit in with their social worlds. Through understanding how meaning and sociality have been constructed within these worlds and how children make the transition between them, we can begin to understand how children are militarised. Thus, it is by paying attention to the subjective, phenomenological and cultural perspectives of a specific social world we can begin to understand how children take on the identities of armed groups.

Conducting fieldwork was imperative to my research. The six months I spent with the former child combatants of the FARC in their home environments enabled me to gain insights into what led them to become militarised. Listening to the children and allowing them the agency to express their perceptions and experiences were essential. I was able to gain a deeper understanding of the complex sociopolitical context in which children are living in Colombia. As anthropologist Sveker Finnstrom (2008, p. 243) writes:

If we make the effort to spend some time with these young people, listening carefully to what they have to say when they confide in us, without editing their stories

to better fit into the official discourse of fixed meanings, we will find that these stories uncover a more complex version of the sociopolitical.

The relationships that I built with the children in both CAE and Don Bosco were therefore integral to my research. Living with the boys from Don Bosco taught me about the nature of the violence in the cities and the context into which children from the guerrilla were demobilising. The children of the guerrilla taught me about the structural inequality and poverty in Colombia and how this can lead one to make the choice to join an armed group. From the girls at CAE, I was able to learn about the violence and discrimination facing women and girls in Colombia that have led them to seek alternative forms of protection, such as joining an armed group. My own experiences of sexual harassment also provided an insight into the gender dynamics that exist within Colombia.

The six months that I spent travelling through Colombia meeting the many individuals who had been directly affected by the armed conflict, such as teachers living in guerrilla-held zones, ex-hostages and former guerrilla, also gave me valuable insights into the multitude of ways individuals have been affected by the armed conflict. It was also through meeting many Colombians who were just trying to live their lives amidst the conflict that I was able to understand the distinct lifeworlds that exist within Colombia. Through my interactions with these participants, I was able to learn about the spatial dynamics of the Colombian conflict and how they have played a role in forming the different lifeworlds within Colombia. Through using lifeworlds theory, I have been able to show that there are two distinct broader lifeworlds that have emerged in Colombia as a result of the spatial dynamics: the world of violence and the world of non-violence. I argue that it is primarily in this 'world of violence' that the recruitment of children into the armed groups has taken place in Colombia. However, it should again be noted that there are many lifeworlds that exist within Colombia that are complex and overlapping. Through using lifeworlds theory, I have delved deeper into the violent 'world' to see that there are in fact a multitude of lifeworlds. I have focused on the lifeworld in which many children grow up as well as that of the FARC.

During my fieldwork, I also learned about the important role of silence in Colombia and how it reveals a great deal about the nature of the violence and how social dynamics have been impacted by it. Navigating the silences, knowing what they meant and when I should employ them was imperative while conducting the fieldwork but also for understanding the realities in

which many children are living in Colombia. I also learned about the central role that children have played in the armed conflict. Towards the end of my research, I was walking in the town of San Jose del Guaviare when a boy about 11 years old approached me on a bicycle. He had a pink ice cream and began to ask me questions about where I was from and why I was there. I was immediately suspicious of him and wondered who he was working for. It struck me that anywhere else this may have seemed unusual—that an 11-year-old boy with a pink ice cream could somehow be involved with an illegal armed group—but in Colombia, it was a reality. After more than a year in Colombia, I had begun to feel wary of children which was a phenomenon that I had not experienced before. I became aware that I had begun to understand Colombia's 'war world'. Thus, through listening to children's voices as well as gaining an understanding of the broader sociocultural factors that have created both children's civilian lifeworlds and the lifeworlds of armed groups, I was able to gain a deep understanding of the Colombian conflict and some of the key factors that had drawn children into it.

One of the key themes I noted throughout my fieldwork was the role of socio-economic status in child recruitment. Colombia is considered to have one of the highest rates of socio-economic inequality in Latin America, which became increasingly evident throughout my fieldwork. A clear pattern emerged in that the majority of the young people who had joined an armed group came from the lower socio-economic classes while those from middle and upper classes tended to go to university and find jobs in the formal economy. I therefore determined that in relation to militarisation, there was a link between socio-economic status and recruitment into an armed group.

Physical insecurity was a clear theme that ran through the narratives of the participants. The way that insecurity was experienced by the participants did appear to be dependent on their socio-economic status. Participants from the higher socio-economic class indicated that they had a greater likelihood of protecting themselves simply because they were able to afford to build walls around their homes and install security systems. However, richer families and individuals also had a higher likelihood of being targeted by one of the armed groups for extortion or kidnapping. Individuals from the lower socio-economic classes also had the risk of being targeted and often lived in areas where armed groups or criminal gangs were present. There appeared to be a link between children who lived in areas of insecurity and recruitment and militarisation, most likely due to the fact that the

armed groups offered a source of protection and were also a means to escape violence and poverty in the home.

Fear was another important theme as it pervaded the lives of many of the participants. Fear was usually related to whichever armed groups were present in the area where they were living, and it has promoted a culture of mistrust, weakened social capital and created a great deal of suspicion about other people. Suspected informants face harsh penalties from armed groups, and kidnappings and extortion have been a continuous problem throughout Colombia. Many of the participants shared stories of macabre forms of violence, such as chopping victims into pieces and throwing them into rivers, that have resulted in mistrust and uncertainty about others.

Structural violence emerged as a major theme throughout the narratives of my participants. For those living in poverty-stricken parts of Colombia, inequality and exclusion were common. Such factors included unequal access to employment, education, health and basic physical infrastructure. Lack of state security protection, policing and judicial systems was also a common sub-theme making those living in such areas more susceptible to corruption and brutality that were carried out with impunity.

Gender inequality was a prime example of such violence. Many of my female participants faced additional unequal life opportunities that were a direct result of their gender, such as having unequal access to paid work and experiencing sexual harassment. Combined with structural inequalities, this was one of the key causes for young girls joining an armed group. Most of the girls claimed that there is equality within the FARC, and some evidence did support this, such as women and girls being assigned equal roles and the presence of female commanders. However, all of the top commanders were male. There were also many cases of much older male commanders having female teenage recruits as girlfriends, which reflected a clear unequal power balance. The girls reported that they would agree to these relationships because they would be able to get things that other recruits would not get, like shampoo, and would not have to do any of the more difficult work.

One of the key factors that ran through the testimonies of the child recruits, but also many of the other participants were living with a sense of feeling powerless. The former combatants often spoke of feeling as if they did not have the means to move out of poverty or get an education or a decent job. They also spoke of combat and war as if these were inevitable in Colombia and there was little likelihood of these coming to an end. Thus, the combination of living in poverty and what they perceived to

be eternal conflict led to the belief that they had little control over how they could direct their lives. This led to a desire to look for a means to empower themselves through their environment, which in their case was through violence. Joining an armed group and the attainment of a gun and a uniform led to a sense of power whereby they could earn respect that they had been unable to gain before joining the group. Disempowerment and the journey to seek empowerment thus emerged as a key theme in the participants' narratives.

It is these common experiences of living within environments that have been shaped by violence and structural inequalities that have formed the lifeworld from which the children who have joined the FARC have come across the different regions of Colombia. The breakdown of institutional structures has meant that access to education and meaningful forms of work has largely been denied for many of Colombia's children. Diminished social capital and limited opportunities have led to a sense of social exclusion and frustration amongst many youth, who feel that they have been unable to find culturally relevant means of attaining dignity and respect. This has generated a need to find an alternative means of achieving dignity and respect and in many cases sources of protection and survival. For many of Colombia's children who have grown up in an environment of violence, where the power of weapons and force have been accepted and valued, then joining an armed group has in large part been seen as a natural and desirable course to take in life. Entrance into an armed group, the attainment of a gun and the possibility of becoming a feared warlord have given children a culturally accepted means of achieving dignity, respect and social worth that they would be unlikely to achieve otherwise.

The normalisation of violence has played a significant role in the militarisation of children, in particular by initiating the transition between their home lifeworld and the lifeworld of the FARC. Having recruits who are willing to use violence is essential for any military or armed group. Thus, an essential part of the militarisation process requires normalising the use of violence. As many of the children who have joined the FARC in Colombia live within highly militarised, violent environments, this process of normalising the use of violence has already for the most part been achieved. This means that the transition into the FARC from their civilian lives is relatively smooth. As I have shown, the FARC draw new recruits into their lifeworld by using memories of violence being perpetrated towards the working class by the Colombian elite. Through the use of these memories, backed up with present-day realities, the FARC have made the Colombian govern-

ment and their military forces into an Other, legitimising them as targets to be attacked. As the new recruits accept these views of the new world, the FARC are able to justify their existence as well as their use of violence. Then as the children undergo military training and the worldview of the FARC is further sedimented into their consciousness, they begin to shift into the guerrilla lifeworld and it begins to be seen as the natural way of the world. In this way, violence and the memory of past injustices become a transformative and binding force that brings children into the lifeworld of the FARC and transforms them into effective warriors. The recruits begin to understand themselves in the new lifeworld, and over time, it becomes part of them. It is through this fusion of the guerrilla lifeworld and the self that the guerrilla identity is formed. The militarisation process has then been finalised.

As Colombia now moves into a peace process with the FARC, as discussed in Chapter 6, the challenge will be finding ways to move the country into lasting peace, which in large part will involve finding ways to reintegrate children coming out of the armed groups. The long-running nature of the Colombian conflict means that violence has become deeply entrenched in the Colombian way of life, particularly for those who have been living in the conflict-affected areas. For children coming out of the FARC, this is in part going to mean finding ways to not become involved with the violence that has shaped the country for so long. However, I have shown there are a number of challenges with the reintegration process. One of these includes children returning to environments where there is still a heavy presence of armed groups and where violence is still a normal part of daily life. The poor economic situation in Colombia will also pose significant challenges. Without alternatives, many children may be left with few other options than to rejoin an armed group or to become involved in the illegal economy. Addressing the issues surrounding poverty will therefore be essential for Colombia's move towards peace and will provide young people with alternative means of achieving social status and self-worth.

Amongst the Colombian population, stigma also poses a significant challenge for children returning home. There is still fear and mistrust of the children coming out of armed groups. It is only with time that Colombian society will be able to move on from the violence that has shaped Colombia's history for so long and accept the ex-combatants back into society. However, there will be a number of challenges for these children in rebuilding their lives as civilians as outlined in Chapter 6. Whether children who escaped from the FARC will continue to face threats from the FARC

when returning home is unclear as the peace process began after I started my fieldwork. However, further research could follow up how the situation has changed for people who are former child guerrillas and what types of challenges and risks children returning from the guerrilla face. What is likely to come next for Colombia will be a long process of forgiveness. One evening at CAE, the reintegration staff held a church service with the children and their family members who had come to visit. The church was set up high on one of the hills, with the forest on one side and the city of Medellin spread out on the other side. One of the *padres* was passing around candles to everybody, and as soft music played in the background, the children were asked to stand up and to ask for forgiveness from their families. I watched as one of the boys stood up to embrace his aunt and uncle in a hug. The hug was long and compassionate, and his aunt and uncle were clearly willing to allow him back into their family. The moment was emblematic of what, ideally, is to come next for Colombia: a long road of forgiveness and moving forward.

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APPENDIX

This table lists the participants at who were the most significant in my study.

The first section of the table shows participants who were resident at CAE while I conducted my fieldwork. Whilst I worked with over 50 children in the demobilisation centre, I have only included those with whom I developed the strongest relationships, who became key participants.

<i>Name</i>	<i>Age</i>	<i>Gender</i>	<i>Location</i>	<i>Status</i>
<i>Former child guerrilla at CAE</i>				
Daniel	22	Male	Medellin	Ex-child guerrilla of the ELN
Juan Pablo	16	Male	Medellin	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Julio	16	Male	Medellin	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Katerine	16	Female	Neiva	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Luz	25	Female	Florencia	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Mariana	16	Female	Medellin	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Marlon	19	Male	Neiva	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC

<i>Name</i>	<i>Age</i>	<i>Gender</i>	<i>Location</i>	<i>Status</i>
Mauricio	18	Male	Medellin	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Yahir	17	Male	Manizales	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
<i>Former child guerrilla outside CAE</i>				
Eduardo	27	Male	Florencia	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Felipe	23	Male	San Jose del Guaviare	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Francisco	27	Male	Villavicencio	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Silvia	34	Female	Florencia	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Sophia	25	Female	San Jose del Guaviare	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Steven	17	Male	San Jose del Guaviare	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Wendy	21	Female	Caqueta	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Carlos Steven	22	Male	San Jose del Guaviare	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
Andres	24	Male	San Jose del Guaviare	Ex-child guerrilla of the FARC
<i>Former adult guerrilla</i>				
Diana	25	Female	Florencia	Ex-guerrilla of the FARC
Oscar Gomez	52	Male	San Jose del Guaviare	Ex-guerrilla of the FARC
William	38	Male	San Jose del Guaviare	Ex-guerrilla
<i>Staff at CAE</i>				
Arcesio	26	Male	Medellin	Educator at CAE
Diego Aries	42	Male	Medellin	Psychologist in CAE
Jesus	36	Male	Medellin	Psychologist from CAE
Leah	24	Female	Medellin	Co-worker at CAE
Rosalba	56	Female	Medellin	Secretary at CAE
<i>Former hostages of the FARC</i>				

<i>Name</i>	<i>Age</i>	<i>Gender</i>	<i>Location</i>	<i>Status</i>
Cesar	46	Male	Villavicencio	Ex hostage of the FARC
Consuelo	54	Female	Bogota	Ex hostage of the FARC
Javier	44	Male	Villavicencio	Ex hostage of the FARC
Marc	44	Male	US	Ex hostage of the FARC
<i>General community members</i>				
Adriel	42	Male	Buenaventura	Priest
Ayde	42	Female	San Jose del Guaviare	Teacher in guerrilla held area
Andres	34	Male	Bogota	Anthropologist
Angelica	34	Female	Cali	Mother
Carmen	17	Female	Apartado	Student
Diana	32	Female	Bogota	Teacher
Eduard	42	Male	Apartado	Lawyer
Emmanuel	21	Male	Cali	Student
Gustavo	30	Male	Cali	Computer Engineer
Jaime	25	Male	Bogota	Student
Jaime	26	Male	Popayan	Student
John	72	Male	Sierra Nevada	Writer
John Otis	41	Male	Bogota	Journalist
Ma	54	Female	San Jose del Guaviare	Displaced
Marlly	30	Female	Bogota	Veterinarian
Martha	34	Female	San Jose del Guaviare	Social Worker
Mateo	21	Male	Apartado	Student
Monica	44	Female	San Jose del Guaviare	Teacher in guerrilla held area
Nestor	25	Male	Bogota	Engineer
Padre Fabio	55	Male	Apartado	Priest
Pamela	28	Female	Cauca	Teacher
Perly	32	Female	Neiva	Teacher
Rubesindo	54	Male	Santander de Quilichao	Indigenous Man, Nasa indigenous group

<i>Name</i>	<i>Age</i>	<i>Gender</i>	<i>Location</i>	<i>Status</i>
<i>NGO workers</i>				
David	29	Male	Quito, Ecuador	Colombian Refugee Project
David	28	Male	Quito, Ecuador	Colombian Refugee Project
Ines	42	Female	Carachi, Ecuador	World Food Program
Jacqueline	36	Female	Quito, Ecuador	Hias
Sarah	42	Female	Carachi, Ecuador	Hias
Mariposas	30s–50s	Female	Buenaventura	Group of women working for women's rights

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